

Traffic chaos: Delhi-Noida border choked in massive jam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

From Chilla Border towards Mahamaya Flyover, and from Mahamaya Flyover towards DND Toll/Chilla Border (towards Delhi), as well as on National Highway-9 to the DND Flyover and the Noida-Greater Noida Elevated Road, commuters faced a harrowing morning on Monday, as a massive traffic jam brought vehicular movement to a near standstill at the Delhi-Noida border.

The protests led to congestion on key arterial roads connecting Delhi and Noida, including National Highway 9, leaving commuters stranded during the peak rush hour. Queues of vehicles stretched for several kilometres. Security was tightened along Delhi's key entry points.

The protests, which have been taking place in the area for the past four to five days, have stemmed from workers' demand for a hike in their wages, in accordance with

the labour laws. Meanwhile, commuters reported massive traffic jams near the Crown Plaza flyover in Mayur Vihar, adding to the chaos in the National Capital Region.

According to officials, a large number of workers from various industrial units gathered in the morning to press their long-pending demand for salary revision and raised slogans during the demonstration.

The protests soon spiralled into violence, with some protesters vandalising property, pelting stones and setting vehicles on fire.

A Delhi Police officer said members of the labour union from Uttar Pradesh gathered near the border area to stage a demonstration. They blocked portions of the road, halting traffic movement.

"Delhi Police and Noida Police personnel were deployed to manage the situation and divert traffic, but the heavy volume of vehicles compounded the chaos," the officer said.

Frustrated commuters took to X to share their ordeals and urge authorities to intervene.

An X user, who works with a private company, said she left her home around 7.30 am and had been stuck in traffic for over an hour without any significant movement. "There is no movement at all. People are getting down from vehicles and trying to figure out what's happening ahead," she said.

Another person said, "Due to heavy traffic jam in Delhi caused by a protest/dharna, passengers who need to reach different railway stations in Delhi facing difficulty reaching the stations. Kindly consider delaying the train by 15 minutes."

"My vehicle (has) not moved even (a) single inch from last 1 hour. Neither the Delhi Traffic Police, nor the UP Traffic Police made any diversions to ease the congestion," said another distressed commuter on X.

Delhi Traffic Police also took to X to inform commuters about the blockade. "Traffic at



Vehicles remain stuck in a traffic jam as factory workers stage a protest demanding a hike in wages in Noida, Gautam Buddh Nagar district, Uttar Pradesh on Monday

PTI

Noida severely affected due to on going agitation by the workers from private factories. They have completely blocked Noida Link Road coming from Chilla Border (Delhi). Traffic movement towards Noida from the Chilla Border is severely affected," it said in a statement.

People are hereby advised to plan their journey accordingly and use DND for travelling to Noida. Those intending to go to Noida may use DND from Sarai Kale Khan or alternatively use NH 24 — Kondli Bridge and enter Noida through Noida Mod, it added.

Authorities said efforts were underway to clear the congestion and restore smooth traffic flow as soon as possible. Delhi Police officials said the force is on high alert.

According to police, several teams have been deployed at all motorable roads connecting Noida to different parts of

Capital on alert after Noida workers' protest turns violent

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In order to maintain law and order in the national Capital, the Delhi Police placed its rank and file on high alert and took several proactive security measures to prevent any spill over of the violent factory workers' protest that erupted in the neighbouring Noida on Monday.

It began with factory workers, mainly from the Hosiery Complex in Noida Phase-2 and Sector 60, protesting for a wage hike and better working conditions. The demonstration turned violent with stone-pelting, arson and setting vehicles on fire, vandalism and road blockades, causing massive traffic chaos on routes like NH-9 and near the Delhi-Noida border.

Delhi Police immediately implemented the steps and adequate police force was deployed at all strategic locations. Multiple police teams



Security personnel stand guard as factory workers stage a protest demanding a hike in wages in Noida, Gautam Buddh Nagar district, Uttar Pradesh on Monday

PTI

were stationed at all motorable roads connecting Noida to Delhi, with special focus on major Uttar Pradesh-Delhi border points.

Intensified barricading and checks: Barricades were strengthened at key entry points. Vehicles were subjected to thorough inspection to prevent anti-social elements from entering Delhi under the pretext of the protest.

Additional personnel, rapid

response teams, and paramilitary forces were positioned for swift action in case of any incident.

A traffic advisory was issued by the Traffic Police advising motorists and a close coordination was maintained with Uttar Pradesh Police to monitor the situation in real time. When asked, a senior Delhi Police officer said: "No one will be allowed to breach law and order."

CM Gupta assures adequate LPG supply, no shortage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday assured residents that both domestic and commercial LPG supplies in the Capital remain stable, adequate and under control, with no shortage of LPG or any other fuel.

Sharing an update on domestic LPG, the Chief Minister said that on April 12, a total of 1,11,766 bookings were recorded, while the three Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs) delivered 1,30,094 cylinders well above the number of bookings. This indicates that pending backlogs are being cleared efficiently and the supply chain remains robust. The average delivery time has improved to 3.87 days from 4.24 days earlier, ensuring timely doorstep delivery. She urged people not to be influenced by rumours or panic, and to remain calm.

On the commercial side, Delhi has been allocated 6,480 LPG cylinders (19 kg equivalent) per day. In comparison, the average daily offtake over the past week has been only 4,268 cylinders, including 5 kg Free Trade LPG cylinders clearly showing that supply is exceeding demand. The Chief Minister appealed to all commercial LPG con-



sumers, particularly users of 5 kg cylinders, to avoid unnecessary concern or stockpiling. She reiterated that the distribution system across the city is functioning smoothly and that adequate stock is available at all times.

"To facilitate access, a dedicated control room of the Food and Civil Supplies Department is operational. Commercial consumers facing any difficulty in obtaining LPG cylinders can contact 011-23379836 or 8383824659 between 9:00 am and 7:00 pm on any day of the week. The Government has also encouraged consumers and institutions to opt for Piped Natural Gas (PNG) wherever available, as it pro-

vides a reliable and continuous fuel supply. Bulk users such as hospitals and educational institutions have been advised to shift to PNG at the earliest to enhance efficiency, safety and supply reliability," the chief minister said in a statement.

Additionally, consumers are being encouraged to consider electric or induction cooking as a medium to long-term alternative to ensure uninterrupted energy access. The chief minister reiterated that the Delhi Government is closely monitoring the situation on a daily basis and remains fully committed to ensuring uninterrupted LPG supply across the Capital.

Traffic curbs across Central Delhi for Ambedkar Jayanti rally

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Traffic Police has issued a detailed advisory ahead of a large public meeting and Shobha Yatra to mark the 135th birth anniversary of Dr BR Ambedkar on April 14, warning of major



traffic restrictions in central parts of the city from morning till evening.

According to the advisory, a public meeting will be held at Ramliya Ground between 11 am and 3 pm.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Sarthak Verma S/o Rajnarain, R/o Near National Modern School, Chhalera, Sector-44, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, UP-201303, solemnly affirm and declare that my father's name is wrongly mentioned as Rajnarain Verma instead of Rajnarain in my 10th & 12th Class Mark Sheet. Both Rajnarain Verma & Rajnarain is one and same person.

PD(856)C I, USHA JAITLEY W/O LATE PIARA LAL JAITLEY R/O 71/42, PREM NAGAR, JANAK PURI NEW DELHI - 110 058 have CHANGED MY NAME FROM JAITLEY USHA TO USHA JAITLEY FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.

PD(857)C I, Meena Devi, Mother of JC-783511M Nb/Sub Ravi Kumar, R/o- H.No. DT- 129 Sharma Road, Po& PS - Dhurwa, Dist- Ranchi, Jharkhand- 834004, have changed my name from Meena Devi to Meena Kumari Singh, vide affidavit dated 13/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(858)C I, Girver Kanwar, Mother of- No.16021816A Hav Surendra Singh, R/o- Vill- Rooppura, Teh- Nawa, Dist- Nagaur, Rajasthan- 341508, have changed my name from Girver Kanwar to Giravar Kanwar, vide affidavit dated 13/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(859)C I, Urmila Devi, Mother of JC-473718A Nb/Sub Styendra Kumar Singh, R/o- Madhinath Road, Shanti Bihar Subhash Nagar, Near Chandrapal Shop, Bareilly, U.P- 243001, have changed my name from Urmila Devi to Urmila, vide affidavit dated 13/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Omesh Kumar Singh, Father of JC-783511M Nb/Sub Ravi Kumar, R/o- H.No. DT- 129 Sharma Road, Po& PS - Dhurwa, Dist- Ranchi, Jharkhand- 834004, have changed my name from Omesh Kumar Singh to Umesh Kumar Singh, vide affidavit dated 13/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(861)C I, Jatin Aggarwal S/o Late Gyarsi Lal Aggarwal, R/o- RZ- 8M/3D, Gali No. 5, Main Sagar Pur, South West Delhi, Delhi-110046, declare that in my documents, my father's name has been written as Gyarsi Lal Aggarwal, Gyarsi Lal, G L Aggarwal & G. L. Aggarwal all names pertain to one & same person i.e. my deceased father.

PD(862)C I, Shailja Mehara W/o Inder Singh, R/o Vill- Kasani, PO- Bin, Teh- Pithoragarh, Dist- Pithoragarh, State- Uttarakhand, PIN- 262501, have changed my name post marriage from Shailja Mehara to Shailja Samant vide affidavit No 2638/026, dated 11/04/2026 before Notary Public, Mhow, Indore, MP

PD(863)C I, Kismati Devi W/o- No.13886490F TS/NK Rajendra Prasad Yadav (Retd.), R/o- Vill- Gurmia, Post- Nounara, PS- Ghorashan, Dist- East Champaran, Bihar- 845303, in my husband's service records, my name is wrongly written as Krishmatiya Devi whereas my correct name is Kismati Devi which may be amended accordingly.

PD(864)C I, Bacha Bihari Sah, S/o Shri Raj Deo Sah, H-39 Gali Number-2, Janta Vihar, Mukundpur, Delhi-110042, Have changed my name to Ram Bachan Shah.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN TENDER NOTICE
The Director/Admin, Northern Railway Central Hospital, New Delhi-110055, for and on behalf of the President of India invites sealed open electronic-tenders for under noted work:-

S. No.	Name of Work	Approximate Cost of work	Earnest Money to be deposited	Completion Period	Date of Opening
1.	Supply of portable water through tankers at NRCH for three years in the section of SSE/WNRCH under ADEN/NRCH.	Rs. 50,99,723.64	Rs. 1,02,000/-	36 Months	05.05.2026

The e-tender is to be submit through railway website **"www.ireps.gov.in"**. The tenders can be submit on website up to **15:00 hrs. on 05.05.2026** and shall be opened there after.

No.: 128-W-269-O.E-T-01-26-27-NRCH Date: 13.04.2026

1239/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

AXIS BANK LTD.
Axis Bank Ltd., Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, 1-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida (U.P.)-201301, REGISTERED OFFICE: "TRISHUL"-3rd Floor Opp. Samaratheshwar Temple, Near Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad - 380006.

APPENDIX IV [Refer Rule - 8(1)] POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)
Whereas The undersigned Being The Authorized Officer Of Axis Bank Ltd. Under The Securitisation And Reconstruction Of Financial Assets And Enforcement Of Security Interest Act, 2002 And In Exercise Of The Powers Conferred Under Section 13 (12) Read With Rule 3 Of The Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 Issued Demand Notice Dated 22-Sep-2025 Calling Bobby Tiwari & Manoj Kumar (Borrower/ Co-Borrower/Mortgagor) To Repay The Amount Mentioned In The Notice Being Rs. 30,12,702/- (Rupees Thirty Lakh Twelve Thousand Seven Hundred Two Only) Against Loan Account Nos. XXXXXXXXXX430 As On 18-09-2025 And Interest And Cost Thereon Within 60 Days From The Date Of Receipt Of The Said Notice. The Borrower(S)/Co-Borrower(S)/Mortgagor(S)/Guarantor(S) Above Said Having Failed To Repay The Amount, Notice Is Hereby Given To The Borrower(S)/Co-Borrower(S)/Mortgagor(S)/Guarantor(S) And The Public In General That The Undersigned Has Taken Possession Of The Property Described Herein Below In Exercise Of Powers Conferred On Him/Her Under Section 13 (4) Of The Said Act Read With Rule 8 Of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 On 11-04-2026.

The Borrower(S)/Co-Borrower (S)/ Mortgagor(S)/ Guarantor(S) Above Said In Particular And The Public In General Is hereby Cautioned Not To Deal With The Properties And Any Dealings With The Properties Will Be Subject To The Charge Of The Axis Bank Ltd. For An Amount Of Rs. 30,12,702/- (Rupees Thirty Lakh Twelve Thousand Seven Hundred Two Only) As On 18-09-2025 Together With Further Interest Thereon At The Contractual Rate Of Interest Till The Date Of Payment & Expenses Thereon.

The Borrower(S)/Co-Borrower(S)/Mortgagor(S)/Guarantor(S)'s Attention Is Invited To Provisions Of Sub-Section (8) Of Section 13 Of The Act, In Respect Of Time Available, To Redeem The Secured Assets.

DESCRIPTION OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
All That Part And Parcel Of Property Bearing: Unit No-Kd-00030003, Ground Floor, Tower-Kd-03, Classic Jaypee Green Wing, Up-201301
Please note that as mention in sub section 13 of section 13 of the aforesaid act, you shall not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of the assets stated under security referred to in this notice without prior written consent of our bank.

Dated: 14.04.2026, Place: NOIDA Sd/-, Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

AXIS BANK
Registered Office: "Trishul" 3rd Floor Opp. Samaratheshwar Temple, Near Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad - 380006.

Appendix IV [Refer Rule - 8(1)] Possession Notice (For Immovable Property)
Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued demand notice dated 05th June 2025 calling M/s. Namdhari Timmer, Mr. Vaajeer Singh & Harmet Kaur (Borrower/ Co-Borrower/Mortgagor/Guarantor) to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs. 4,53,88,344.01/-Rupees Four Crore Fifty Three Lakhs Eighty Eight Thousand Three Hundred Forty Four and Paise One Only) as on 15th May 2025 together with interest and cost thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) above said having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) and the Public in General that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on 08.04.2026. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower (S)/ Mortgagor(s)/ Guarantor(s) above said in particular and the Public in General is hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the properties will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount of Rs. 4,53,88,344.01/-Rupees Four Crore Fifty Three Lakhs Eighty Eight Thousand Three Hundred Forty Four and Paise One Only) as on 15th May 2025 together with further interest thereon at the contractual rate of interest till the date of payment & expenses thereon. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s)'s attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Description of immovable property All that part and parcel of Property bearing:
Entire Third Floor with Roof/Terrace Rights, out of built up Property, Built on freehold Plot No. 164, In Block - F, situated in residential colony known as Mansarovar Garden, Delhi along with proportionate undivided, indivisible and impartable ownership right of the land measuring 297 sq. yds. beneath the said building with common rights of the staircase and passage, with all other common facilities of the said building within the limit of Delhi Municipal Corporation West Zone New Delhi in the name on Shri Vaajeer Singh Son of Manjit Singh and Smt. Harmet Kaur Wife of Vaajeer Singh, East - Property No. F-165, West - Property No. F-163, North - Road, South - Lane. Please note that as mention in Sub Section 13 of Section 13 of the aforesaid act, you shall not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of the assets stated under security referred to in this notice without prior written consent of our bank.

Dated: 14.04.2026, Place: Mansarovar Garden, Delhi Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

Public Notice
My clients, **Sh. Gurbachan Singh** S/o **Sh. Shaka Singh** R/o **H.No. B-5, Gurudwara, Majnu Ka Tilla, Aruna Nagar, Civil Lines, North Delhi, Delhi-110054** and **Smt. Manpreet Kaur** W/o **Sh. Gurbachan Singh**, My clients due to disrespectful and uncontrollable behavior of my son namely **Sh. Arvind Singh** and his wife **Smt. Amarjeet Kaur** debar them from his all movable and immovable properties from this date of present public notice. In future my aforesaid clients shall not be responsible for any public transaction done by his son **Sh. Arvind Singh** and his wife **Amarjeet Kaur** on behalf of my above named clients.
Rohit Manchanda (Advocate)
OFF-106, 1st Floor Rajendra Market, Near Gate No-3, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-110054

Public Notice
My client Mrs. Amrit Kuman Nagpal and Mr. Sanjeev Kumar Nagpal are the registered owner of Freehold Built-up Shop No. 131, measuring 38.69 Sq.Mtrs, situated at Mehar Chand Market, New Delhi by virtue of Relinquishment Deed dated 18.04.2015 read with Rectification Deed dated 27.05.2015 executed by smt. Sweetly Bhutani, Smt. Neeru Arora and smt. Neeti Karki after the demise of Late Mr. Arjun Dev Nagpal died on 03.04.2015 and except the above said legal heirs there are no other legal heirs remains of Late Mr. Arjun Dev Nagpal. If anybody including Bank, Financial Institutions, persons, relative has any claim, right, interest whatsoever in the said property subject to the above mentioned deed, the undersigned with documentary evidence. In the event of no response to this notice, then My client shall presume that title of the said property is unencumbered and clear.
Karnail Singh, (Advocate)
K-8, Basement, Jangpura Extension New Delhi, Contact No. 9811163363 & 9958683363.

PUBLIC NOTICE
(Known to all that my client Mrs. Seeta Bhatnagar owner of PLOT No. 5128 & 5129, AREA 36 SQ. YDS, WAKA SECTOR-3, HUDA URBAN ESTATE TEHSIL & DISTT., FARIDABAD, and My Client have lost original Allotment letter and Conveyance deed dated 08.12.2005 of plot no. 5128 and original allotment, Possession and Conveyance deed dated 08.12.2005 of plot no. 5129. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.
AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

LOST AND FOUND
I/we, Saurabh Singhal S/o Shri M.P. Singhal R/o 225, Second Floor, Iskon Temple, Sant Nagar, East of Kailash, Srinivaspuri, South Delhi, Delhi - 110065, along with Mrs. Kamlesh Singhal W/o Shri M.P. Singhal do hereby state and declare as under: That we were jointly allotted a unit/plot bearing No. CF-248, situated at Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, in the project Ansals East End, Loni (hereinafter referred to as the "subject unit"), developed by Ansal Housing Limited. That the original allotment letter pertaining to the above-mentioned subject unit has been lost/misplaced at our above-mentioned residence, despite our best efforts to trace the same. The said original allotment letter is not traceable and is presumed to be lost. If any person finds the aforesaid original allotment letter, he/she is requested to kindly contact the undersigned at the above-mentioned address. Contact no. 86262-86256.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE
Invitation of Tender through E-Tendering (e-Procurement Systems)

N.I.T. No.	367025
Name of work and its location	"Complete stripping of electrical and mechanical items and fitment of Flooring and PVC Installation along with plumbing items in LHB Coaches under MLR Schedule"
Approx. Cost of work	Tender Cost: Rs. 9590111.28/- including GST (Rs. Ninety Five Lac Ninety Thousand One Hundred Eleven and paise Twenty Eight Only)
Earnest Money	Rs.191800.00/-
Completion period of work	12 months of date of issue of letter of acceptance
Cost of Tender document on cash/by post	NIL
Date and Time for submission of tender and opening of tender	Upto 12:00 hrs on 25.04.2026
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in
No. 367025 Dated 11/04/2026	

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 1231/26

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, चतुर्थ वृत्त, लोक निर्माण विभाग, रुद्रपुर (उधमसिंह नगर)
फोन: 05944-240921 ईमेल: sepwdsun@gmail.com

पत्रांक : 769 / 23 एम-04 / 2026 दिनांक : 10 / 04 / 2026

ई-निविदा शुद्धि-पत्र सूचना
इस कार्यालय के पत्रांक 683 / 23 एम-04 / 2026 दिनांक 31.03.2026 द्वारा क्रमांक 1 व 2 में अंकित कार्यों की आमंत्रित निविदा सूचना में ठेकेदार की श्रेणी त्रुटिवश सेतु कार्य हेतु अंकित हो गयी है जिसे मार्ग कार्य हेतु पढ़ा जाये।
निविदा की शेष शर्त पूर्ववत रहेगी।
(ई० अनिल पांगती)
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

FORM NO. URC-2
Advertisement giving notice about registration under Part I of Chapter XXI of the Act (Pursuant to section 374(b) of the Companies Act, 2013 and rule 4(1) of the Companies (Authorised to Register) Rules, 2014)

- Notice is hereby given that in pursuance of sub-section (2) of section 366 of the Companies Act, 2013, an application is proposed to be made after fifteen days hereof but before expiry of thirty days hereinafter to the Registrar at Central Registration Centre that **TIWARI PROPART REALTY LLP**, a LLP may be registered under Part I of Chapter XXI of the Companies Act 2013, as a company limited by shares.
- The principal objects of the company are as follows:
 - To carry on the business as builders, consultants, Real Estate Agents, collaborators, civil engineers and constructional engineers, surveyors, designers, town planners, estimators, valuers, interior and exterior decorators, general and government civil contractors of immovable properties, all types of structural and piling engineers work, interior designing land scaping and graphic.
 - To construct, erect, build, repair, re-model, demolish, develop, improve, grades, curve, pave, macadamize, cement and maintain building, structures, houses, apartments, hospitals, schools, places of worship, highways, roads, paths, streets, sidewalks, courts, alleys, pavements and to do other similar construction, levelling or paving work and for these purposes to purchase, take on lease, or otherwise acquire and hold any lands and prepare lay-out thereon or buildings of any tenure description wherever situate, or rights or interests therein or connected therewith.
 - To engage in infrastructure development, real estate, promoters, developers & project Management Association including civil, construction, mechanical, electrical and all other types erection, commissioning projects, project trading as well as consultant for execution of projects turnkey basis for equipment's of industrial, domestic and other purpose.
 - To buy, exchange, purchase, or otherwise acquire an interest in any immovable property such as houses, building, market, shops industrial sheds & plots, within or outside the limits of municipal corporation or such other local bodies and to provide roads, drains, water supply, electricity and light within these areas, to divide the same into suitable plots and rent or sell the plots to the people for building, houses, bungalows & colonies for workmen according to schemes approved by improvement trusts, development boards and municipal boards there on and to rent or sell the same to the public and realize cost in lumpsum or otherwise to start any housing scheme in India or abroad.
 - To acts as an agent, Liaison House, commission agent for government and non-government organisation in India and Foreign Countries.
 - A copy of the draft memorandum and articles of association of the proposed company may be inspected at the office at **F-005, FIRST FLOOR, ALPHA-1, TRADEX TOWER-I, ALPHA GREATER NOIDA, GAUTAM BUDDHA NAGAR, UTTAR PRADESH 201310 INDIA.**
 - Notice is hereby given that any person objecting to this application may communicate their objection in writing to the Registrar at Central Registration Centre, Indian Institute of Corporate Affairs (IICA), Plot No. 6.7, 8, Sector 5, IIT Manesar, District Gurgaon (Haryana), Pin Code-122050, within twenty-one days from the date of publication of this notice, with a copy to the company at its registered office.

Dated this 14th day of April, 2026

Name(s) of Applicant
1. Mr. MANISH KUMAR TIWARI
2. Ms. NIDHI TIWARI

Delhi Assembly gets fresh bomb threat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Assembly received a fresh threat email claiming 15 RDX bombs laced with cyanide gas would be detonated within 3 hours, along with a demand calling for the evacuation of Muslim employees. The alert was flagged by Assembly authorities, following which teams of the Delhi Police, along with bomb disposal units, dog squads and fire services, were deployed to the premises.

The Delhi Vidhan Sabha was also placed on high alert after another email claimed that 16 RDX-laden improvised explosive devices had been planted inside the Assembly, with a warning of a blast at 1:40 pm. Security agencies evacuated the building as a precaution and conducted thorough checks.

A comprehensive search operation was conducted across the Assembly complex. "Nothing suspicious has been found so far. The situation is under control," a senior police officer said, adding that efforts are underway to trace the source of the threat email. Officials said the sender was allegedly based in Coimbatore and had cited political grievances, and efforts are ongoing to verify the authenticity of the threat.

This comes just days after a major



Speaker Vijender Gupta

security breach occurred at the Assembly when a car rammed into the gate.

Expressing concern over a series of threatening e-mails targeting the Delhi Assembly over the past few weeks, Speaker Vijender Gupta on Monday sought urgent action from the Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golcha for addressing the issue and enhancing security at the Vidhan Sabha premises.

"The Assembly received a threat mail on Monday as well. So far, the official e-mail IDs of the Assembly and the Speaker have received five bomb threat emails targeting the Vidhan Sabha. The fresh threat mail warned of 15 RDX blasts and cyanide gas use at the Assembly premises within

three hours, he mentioned in the letter. Three threat mails were received consecutively during the budget session at the Delhi Assembly on March 23-25. All the threats were found to be hoax mails after thorough checks by the police.

In a letter to Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golcha, the Speaker said the emails reportedly mention plans of planting bombs in the Assembly building and carrying out blasts within a specified time.

He further noted that another such threatening email was received at 11.12 am on the official email ID, as well as from another email address, containing alarming claims about explosives being used inside the Assembly premises. "I request you to kindly treat this matter with utmost urgency and trace the source of these emails so that the perpetrators could be brought under law," Gupta said in his letter to the police commissioner. "Further, immediate steps be taken to enhance the security arrangements in and around the Assembly premises to prevent any untoward incident," he said.

The emails were repeatedly received by the Assembly on its official as well as on his personal email, from various email addresses during the past few weeks, threatening that bombs were planted at the premises,

the Speaker said.

The repeatedly received threat e-mails not only hamper the smooth functioning of the Assembly but also instil a sense of fear among the staff working there, the Speaker said.

The Delhi Legislative Assembly is a very important democratic institution, and any threat to this institution is a very serious matter as it is also a threat to the democratic system, he added. A security breach was reported at the Delhi Legislative Assembly on April 6 after an SUV rammed through Gate number 2 and entered the premises, police said.

According to officials, three suspects were detained after the vehicle broke past security barriers and reached the porch area, where a bouquet and garland were placed inside the Speaker's official car before the accused attempted to flee.

The development comes a day after similar threat emails were sent to the assembly, the Speaker's office, and nearby locations, including the Vidhan Sabha Metro Station, triggering security sweeps. Authorities said the mails mentioned several prominent leaders, raising the seriousness of the alert. Despite this, officials maintained that Assembly proceedings would continue, asserting that security has been tightened and there is no cause for panic.

LG backs Project SANGAM to fix Delhi traffic woes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday said the Delhi Traffic Police has launched Project SANGAM, a new initiative aimed at improving traffic management through community participation and coordinated governance.

The project, described as Synergistic Action and Networked Governance for Area Mobility, focuses on resolving local traffic issues by bringing residents and civic agencies onto a common platform. The Lieutenant Governor said the initiative follows his recent review and guidance to strengthen traffic systems in the Capital.

In a statement, he said the project is rooted in collaborative governance and aims to deliver citizen-centric, ground-level solutions. It seeks to involve Resident Welfare Associations, Market Welfare Associations and civic bodies such as the Public Works Department and



Municipal Corporation in decision-making and problem-solving.

Officials said the initiative enables real-time resolution of issues such as unauthorised parking, congestion and pedestrian safety. So far, 30 meetings have been held across key areas, including Connaught Place, Saket and Karol Bagh, with participation of more than 6,000 residents.

The Lieutenant Governor said the approach ensures that all stakeholders work together to make Delhi's roads smoother, safer and more organised. He added

that active public participation is central to the success of the project. The development comes days after Sandhu visited the Traffic Headquarters at Todapur on April 2, where he reviewed the functioning of the Delhi Traffic Police and emphasised the need for modernisation and better coordination.

During the visit, he was welcomed by Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golchha and Special Commissioner of Police for Traffic Management Neeraj Thakur, along with other senior officers.

CM Rekha Gupta hails women's quota Act



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday hailed the 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam', saying the legislation will enable women-led development in the country in a "big way". Addressing a gathering of women from different walks of life at 'Nari Shakti Vandan Sammelan', in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, she appealed for support for the legislation. She thanked the prime minister for a series of schemes launched under his leadership, which have provided women with a dignified life and opened avenues for them in various fields.

Pointing towards the prime minister, Rekha Gupta said, "The women can excellently accomplish even the most dif-

icult tasks when provided an opportunity - you gave this message." The 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam', more commonly known as the Women's Reservation Act, was passed in 2023. Under the prime minister's leadership, the country has moved beyond 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' to an era of 'Beti Badhao', she said.

Highlighting the long and difficult journey of Indian women, the Chief Minister noted that society has moved past challenges such as sati, child marriage, illiteracy and female foeticide. "There was a time when even the existence of daughters was under threat. Today, under the Prime Minister's leadership, the country has moved beyond 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' to an era of 'Beti Badhao'," she said.

Govt to identify lesser known candidates for Padma Awards



Padma Awards

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday directed officials to identify and recommend desirable and lesser-known candidates for the Padma Awards by June 15 for the honours to be announced on Republic Day 2027.

The direction came following a communication from the Ministry of Home Affairs on March 12, inviting nominations for the country's highest civilian honours - Padma Vibhushan, Padma Bhushan and Padma Shri.

The ministry said, "It has been observed that in the past, while nominations are received in respect of a large number of persons, there could, however, be several talented persons who are left out of consideration despite exceptional contribution in their field."

The city Government has

also advised that a committee may be constituted to identify and finalise deserving candidates, ensuring that recommendations are based on merit, lifetime achievements and contribution to public service.

The secretary to the chief minister and ministers here have been asked to send nominations with detailed citations highlighting the nominee's distinguished and exceptional achievements in their respective fields.

The communication emphasises that nominations must be submitted online through the Rashtriya Puraskar portal and should follow the prescribed format, including a brief narrative of up to 800 words.

Special focus has been laid on identifying individuals from underrepresented sections, including women, weaker sections and those whose work may not have received adequate public attention, it stated.



MINISTRY OF
SOCIAL JUSTICE &
EMPOWERMENT
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

“ On the birth anniversary of Bharat Ratna Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar, I offer my heartfelt tribute. His struggle to bring the marginalized sections of society into the mainstream will remain an inspiration for every generation ”

— Narendra Modi
Prime Minister

The Nation Pays Tribute to Bharat Ratna Dr. B. R. Ambedkar on his Birth Anniversary

Architect of Indian Constitution and symbol of social equality, Babasaheb's vision guides our path in making Viksit Bharat.

While realizing the dreams of Babasaheb, the Government of India is making efforts for the upliftment of Scheduled Castes (SC) and Scheduled Tribes (ST)



Shiksha Bhoomi - London



Deeksha Bhoomi - Nagpur



Mahaparinirvan Sthal - New Delhi



Chaitya Bhoomi - Mumbai



Janma Bhoomi - Mhow, M.P.

- More than **3.3 crore** tap water connections and about **3.4 crore** toilets ensure a dignified life for beneficiaries
- More than **3.1 crore** beneficiaries got Ujjwala gas connection
- **1.5 crore** pucca houses made the lives of beneficiaries easier
- **₹5.2+ lakh crore** worth Mudra loans boosted entrepreneurship
- Assured free treatment of up to **₹5 lakh** every year under the **Ayushman Bharat PM Jan Arogya Yojana**
- Compared to 2014, the budget allocation has increased more than three times—from **₹50,000 crore** to **₹1.7 lakh crore**
- Under the **Pre-Matric and Post-Matric Scholarship Scheme**, the future of approximately **9 crore** students brightened with assistance of over **₹51,000 crore**
- Financial assistance to marginalized community through **PM-SURA** portal
- **Financial and technical** support to companies run by SC community under the **Ambedkar Social Innovation and Incubation Mission**
- **Helpline number 14566** for Prevention of Atrocities against SC

All are cordially invited to pay floral tribute.

CBC 38101/13/0001/2627

IN FOCUS



Sannyasis during the Gajan festival procession at Sonapalashi Buru Shiv Tala, in Purba Bardhaman district, West Bengal. The festival, dedicated to Lord Shiva and observed on the last day of the Bengali year, involves devotees performing rigorous penance and traditional rituals. PTI

Rahul using fake documents to target Himanta: BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday hit back at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over his remarks targeting Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, accusing him of indulging in “vendetta politics” and attempting a “political assassination” using “fake documents”. The BJP’s response came after Rahul Gandhi launched a strong attack on Sarma, calling him the “most corrupt” and accusing him of

misusing the State machinery.

Backing All India Congress Committee’s (AICC) media and publicity department chairperson Pawan Khera, Rahul Gandhi on Monday said his party would “not be intimidated”.

At a press conference on April 5, Khera had alleged that Sarma’s wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, held multiple passports and foreign assets that were not disclosed in the chief minister’s election affidavit for the April 9 Assam Assembly polls.

Wage protests turn violent, spread across...

The violence erupted a day after the UP Government announced a series of measures aimed at strengthening labour welfare, including mandatory double overtime pay, timely wages and weekly offs for workers in Gautam Buddha Nagar. District Magistrate Medha Roopam on Sunday held meetings with representatives of industrial units and issued key directives to safeguard workers’ rights. She directed that workers willing to continue their jobs should not face any inconvenience and asked managements to maintain dialogue with employees in line with government norms. The administration also directed industrial units to ensure CCTV cameras at factory gates remain functional and set up a control room to address workers’ grievances and maintain law and order.

Supreme Court rejects plea on voter deletions...

Senior advocate D S Naidu, appearing for the poll panel, informed the court that there are approximately 30 to 34 lakh appeals currently pending. “Every tribunal now has over one lakh appeals to handle,” the bench said.

Justice Bagchi, during the hearing, referred to the sanctity of the electoral process and said the right to vote is not merely a constitutional formality but a “sentimental” pillar of democracy. “The right to vote in a country you were born in is not just constitutional, but sentimental. It is about being part of a democracy and helping elect a government,” he said. He, however, said that the tribunals, manned by former judges, cannot be overburdened by fixing the timelines for adjudications. “It is not the end justifying the means, but the means justifying the end,” Justice Bagchi said.

“We need to protect due process rights. The voter should not be sandwiched between two constitutional authorities,” he said, adding that it would not interdict the election process at this stage. Justice Bagchi noted that the Calcutta High Court Chief Justice had already formulated the manner and mode for appeals, which began on Monday. The CJI emphasised that the petitioners must exhaust their remedies before the appellate tribunals. Assembly elections in West Bengal will be held in two phases on April 23 and 29, and votes will be counted on May 4.

The apex court also wanted to know if those arrested by the NIA for the April 1 gherao of seven judicial officers in Malda district “had any political background”, with the CJI saying “this has to be taken to a logical conclusion”.

PM pushes for quick rollout of women’s quota

Acknowledging the nationwide enthusiasm among women on this issue, the PM observed that women across the country are voicing their aspirations about reaching Assemblies and the Lok Sabha. “I appeal to all women to maintain their active participation in this entire process and meet their MPs to share their perspectives and expectations,” PM Modi remarked.

Recalling the passage of the Nari Shakti Vandan Act in the new Parliament building in 2023, the PM noted that it was passed unanimously with all parties agreeing that it should be implemented by 2029 in any case. Making a special appeal, PM Modi urged women to take the discussions from the Nari Shakti Vandan programme to every village in the country through personal meetings and social media.

Tracing the contribution of women from the

Sonam Wangchuk urges Centre to resume talks on Ladakh issues

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, released from the Jodhpur jail on March 14 after the revocation of the stringent National Security Act (NSA) by the Union Home Ministry, is apparently growing impatient in the absence of an announcement of the fresh schedule of talks.

A week after he visited Kargil, where he emphasised that the unity between regions like Leh and Kargil has given strength to the movement in support of their demands, including statehood for Ladakh and extension of the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution to the region, Wangchuk Monday claimed Ladakh is hanging between trust and



mistrust while it is awaiting resumption of the dialogue. In a post on X, Wangchuk said, “Today marks exactly one month since the unconditional revocation of my detention under the NSA, 1980.

The revocation order gave us hope that the Centre was willing to correct past mistakes, as it

spoke of “building mutual trust” for a “constructive and meaningful dialogue.” However, even after 2.5 months since the last dialogue on February 4, not even a date for the next round of talks has been announced”. Referring to the attempts being made to create division between Leh and Kargil, Wangchuk said

in the same post on X, “On the ‘trust’ front, shady entities are using this gap to sow seeds of Leh- Kargil (Buddhist - Muslim) divide. As people in this sensitive border region grow disheartened and demoralised, I urge PM Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah to take timely measures, in national interest, to resolve the issues at the earliest”.

To foster better coordination and build trust between the Union Territory administration and local stakeholders, the newly appointed Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh, Vinai Kumar Saxena, has been actively working to resolve long-pending grievances and address key public issues.

RS to elect its deputy chairman on April 17, NDA likely to renominate Harivansh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Rajya Sabha will hold the election for the post of deputy chairman on April 17, and the ruling NDA is likely to push for re-electing Harivansh to the key post.

The post of the deputy chairman of the Rajya Sabha fell vacant after the tenure of Harivansh ended on April 9. Harivansh has since been nominated to the Upper House by President Droupadi Murmu and took the oath on April 10.

Union minister and BJP leader JP Nadda, who is also leader of the house in Rajya Sabha, is learnt to have discussed the re-election of



Harivansh as deputy chairman with leaders of various parties while trying to bring about a broad consensus on his name.

However, the Congress, TMC and

Left parties have raised objections to the “keenness” the ruling party is showing in holding elections for filling the post of deputy chairman of the Upper House when the post of deputy speaker in Lok Sabha has been vacant since 2019.

An official announcement said that the election for the post of deputy chairman will be held on April 17 at 11 AM. “The office of the Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha having fallen vacant.

The Chairman has, under rule 7 of the Rules of Procedure and Conduct of Business in the Council of States (Rajya Sabha), fixed Friday, the 17th of April, 2026, as the date for holding the election to the

said office of the deputy Chairman.

“The election will take place at 11-00 AM immediately after laying of papers/reports on the Table on that day,” a notification from the Rajya Sabha Secretariat said.

Members can give notices of motions for election to the office of deputy chairman up to 12 noon on Thursday, April 16, 2026.

Those members who have yet to take an oath as members of the Rajya Sabha will also take their oath/affirmation on Thursday, April 16, when the upper house meets for a special session, during which the amendments to the Women’s Reservation Act will be taken up.

Congress general secretary

Jairam Ramesh alleged that the government wants to “bulldoze” the appointment of the deputy chairman in the Rajya Sabha. “A government that does not appoint a Deputy Speaker in the Lok Sabha for seven years wants to bulldoze the appointment of a Deputy Chairman in the Rajya Sabha in less than four days,” Ramesh said.

Trinamool Congress Leader Derek O’Brien said the BJP wanted to hold the election for the deputy chairman in the Upper House on April 17 when the MPs are busy with state elections and questioned the “hurry”. “Mocking Parliament Again,” O’Brien said in a post on X.



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

A total of 39,386 nomination forms have been filed for 10,005 seats across Gujarat in the upcoming local body elections, marking a significant level of participation. The scrutiny of nomination papers is set to begin today, after which the final list of candidates will be confirmed. According to State Election Commission sources, the overall picture of candidates and the number of uncontested seats will become clear once the verification process is completed.

Additionally, by-elections are being held for 13 seats in 11 municipalities, for which 40 nomination forms have been received. At the district level, elections will be conducted for 5,234 seats in district pan-

chayats, with 4,906 nominations filed. Meanwhile, elections for talukapanchayats—excluding Gandhinagar, Kapadvanj, and Kathlal—have attracted 20,638 nominations for 5,234 seats across 280 talukapanchayats.

Officials indicated that details regarding uncontested seats will also emerge following the completion of scrutiny.

The elections are expected to witness competitive contests across multiple tiers of local governance.

FROM PAGE - 1

Western sanctions and oversight. But the effects will be felt far beyond Iran. The price of Brent crude oil, the international standard, rose 7% to hover around \$102 per barrel on Monday. It cost roughly \$70 per barrel before the war. British Prime Minister Keir Starmer said that, together with French President Emmanuel Macron, he would hold a summit this week “to drive forward the international effort” to end the conflict and unblock the strait. Starmer told lawmakers it must reopen with no conditions or tolls.

Iran assures safe passage for India through Strait...

He added that Iran’s foreign minister has identified India as one of five priority countries for diplomatic engagement.

Expressing gratitude, the envoy praised the Indian government and its people as “reliable and compassionate partners,” particularly during challenging times. He also confirmed that Indian tankers passing through the Strait of Hormuz have not been charged any tolls. “You can ask the Indian government if we have charged anything up to now,” Fathali said, reiterating Iran’s commitment to maintaining smooth maritime trade ties.

India has consistently denied reports suggesting it paid any fees to secure the passage of nine liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) vessels through the waterway, especially after transit disruptions linked to escalating regional conflict.

On security concerns, Fathali asserted that the Strait of Hormuz falls within Iran’s territorial waters and claimed that the situation deteriorated following military escalation despite ongoing diplomatic efforts. He alleged that Iran faced attacks during negotiations, including strikes on civilian infrastructure.

Referring to recent talks held in Islamabad, the ambassador said discussions covered nuclear issues, sanctions relief, and war reparations, though he described some demands as “unlawful.” “Iran is ready for peace and negotiation,” Fathali stated, while also warning that the country remains prepared for conflict if necessary. On the possibility of renewed dialogue with the United States, he said further negotiations would depend on Washington accepting Iran’s conditions. Fathali also criticized the US for what he described as repeated breaches of commitments, accusing it of acting in bad faith and contributing to instability in the region.

Despite the tensions, Iran reiterated its willingness to engage diplomatically, while maintaining its stance on sovereignty and regional security.

SIT expands probe into TCS case

Well places sources say, the Central agencies have become involved as there is enough material evidence to suggest that an organized network, involving a WhatsApp group for targeting, financial trails, or broader radicalisation links, was actively involved in forced religious conversion. The Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) of Maharashtra Police, National Investigation Agency (NIA) and Intelligence Bureau (IB) have sought detailed inputs and evidence from the Nashik Police SIT.

Reports indicate that teams from these agencies are expected to join the investigation on the ground and coordinate with Maharashtra Police in the investigation.

Meanwhile, the police sources confirmed that the SIT, led by ACP Sandeep Mitke, is examining digital evidence, including alleged WhatsApp coordination groups and blackmail material. Though no fresh arrests were made on

Monday, the investigation is going full steam with appeals for additional victims to come forward.

The SIT continues systematic questioning, evidence analysis and tracking of the absconding accused. Police Commissioner Sandeep Karnik has described the investigation as “systematic and evidence-based.”

This focused police effort has already led to swift arrests and suspensions by TCS, highlighting both the scale of alleged misconduct and the authorities’ response. More revelations and arrests cannot be ruled out in the coming days. ACP Sandeep Mitke has stated that “more arrests and custodial actions are likely” as the probe expands further.

The SIT was constituted on the orders of the Nashik Police Commissioner following intelligence inputs, victim statements and senior state-level directives to investigate nine FIRs involving allegations of sexual harassment, blackmail, grooming, and forced religious conversion at the TCS BPO unit in Satpur MIDC, Nashik.

Key allegations include coercive demands to perform Namaz, observe Roza, consume beef and adopt Islamic practices, alongside sexual exploitation, stalking, and career-related threats. Police sources confirm the SIT is treating the case as a coordinated racket involving senior team leads who allegedly used their positional power.

The SIT is probing a secret WhatsApp group on the accused’s phones, described as the ‘control room’ for coordinating operations, including targeting Hindu women with false promises of marriage or promotions. The sleuths are looking for alleged intimate photos, videos allegedly used for blackmail, call records and office surveillance data. Detailed recordings from complainants and other employees are being examined by the SIT and it has appealed for more victims to come forward.

The most important aspect in this scandal is the undercover operation involving seven women police officers who worked inside the unit for approximately 40 days, gathering on ground intelligence that led to the arrests.

Seven individuals have been arrested so far including team leads Asif Ansari, Tausif Attar, Shafi Sheikh, Raza Memon, Danish Sheikh and Shah Rukh Qureshi while One key accused Nida Khan the Assistant General Manager, HR, referred to in some reports as the ‘Lady Captain’ is reportedly absconding.

The SIT has widened its search to Nashik and Pune and a notice was earlier served to her for allegedly suppressing complaints. The arrested accused have been remanded in police custody and are being interrogated to piece together the sequence of events leading to coercion and religious conversion.

Army officer attacked for objecting to public...

He said that they politely asked the men to move elsewhere, as it was a residential area and public drinking was inappropriate. “The moment we requested them to leave, they became hostile and dared us to call anyone. My father then asked me to call the police control room,” he said.

Arora alleged that when police personnel arrived, they refused to record their complaint. Instead, one of the men spoke to the officer over the phone, after which the officer told them he would deal with the matter later.

“Soon after, seven to eight men arrived in two vehicles and started thrashing us and abusing my mother. They were associates of the accused,” he claimed. He told the reporters that he was repeatedly assaulted for around 15 minutes in the presence of police personnel.

“Five to six men kept beating me continuously, while my father was also surrounded. We had called the police, but they did not intervene,” he

alleged. Tejas sustained injuries to his face, neck, and palm. He alleged that the responding officer remained inside his vehicle and did not offer any assistance. The brigadier’s wife also alleged that the officer present at the spot refused to intervene despite her requests. “The officer did not step in as the men continued assaulting my son. When I pleaded for help, he said he could act only after his team arrived,” she claimed.

She said that after the attackers left, the officer refused to take them to the police station and instead opened the boot of the vehicle. “You are not the kind of people who deserve to sit on the seats,” she quoted the officer as saying.

At the police station, the family claimed they faced further harassment. “They kept us waiting for about half an hour. A woman officer told us they did not have ‘free time’ as we had called the PCR multiple times. When my husband said we were both in uniform and deserved basic respect, she became aggressive,” the brigadier’s wife told the reporters. She also claimed that despite her son bleeding, the police insisted on an MLC report before registering the complaint and did not provide a vehicle to take them to the hospital. “Eventually, my husband took our son to the Army Hospital himself for treatment and X-rays,” she alleged.

Terror commander nabbed after 16 years

Abu Hureira maintained low profile and kept shifting his bases in Malerkotla, Punjab to avoid detection. Mohammad Naeqeb Bhat, Adil Rashid Bhat and Ghulam Mohammad Mir, the local over ground operatives of LeT provided shelter, food, logistics and arms. They provided high quality documents and it helped Hureira to go off the radar of the security agencies and he continued to carry out LeT activities.

Abu Hureira’s arrest was made possible by the sustained, layered intelligence work involving human intelligence (HUMINT), technical surveillance and inter-state coordination. The operation began around March 31, 2026 after a specific intelligence input was received. The seriousness of this input could be judged by the fact that the J&K Director General of Police Nalin Prabhat personally supervised the operation.

It started with the arrest of local associate Mohammad Naeqeb Bhat from the Pandach area on the outskirts of Srinagar. He was caught with a pistol and other incriminating material. During interrogation, Naeqeb disclosed his role in the LeT module, arms procurement links to Adil Rashid Bhat and support provided to foreign terrorists. This led police to Ghulam Mohammad Mir. Mir’s questioning helped further unravelled the terrorist network. Human intelligence and technical surveillance pinpointed the hideout in Malerkotla, Punjab. A SOG team of J&K Police with central agency support, arrested Abu Hureira and Usman and they were later brought to Srinagar for further questioning. These raids confirmed the interstate nature of the network, which handled logistics, funding, and fake IDs. The probe also connected to a prior white-collar LeT cell busted six months earlier at Faridabad’s Al Falah University, showing deeper linkages.

The success in 2026 reflects improved multi-agency coordination, persistent technical and human intelligence, and the cascading effect of interrogations. Once the local module cracked with Naeqeb Bhat’s arrest, the chain of disclosures quickly led to Abu Hureira’s hideout in Punjab.

Police officials have described this as a major blow to LeT’s residual infrastructure in the region, exposing how foreign terrorists rely on Indian documents and local enablers to operate long-term. This case underscores both the challenges of hybrid terrorism and the effectiveness of sustained, coordinated counter-terror efforts.

Asha Bhosle cremated with State honours

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

"Abhi Na Jaao Chhodkar..." The strains of that wistful song played in the background at the Shivaji Park crematorium on Monday as hundreds of people gathered inside - and outside - to bid music legend Asha Bhosle a final sayonara.

A gun salute rang out as the last rites of Bhosle, perhaps the last of the singing greats who ruled the sound waves for decades and still do, were held in accordance with Hindu rituals and with full state honours. Her son Anand performed the rituals.

Bhosle, one-half of the legendary Mangeshkar sisters, passed away on Sunday due to multi-organ failure. She was 92, as was her Lata didi when she died in February 2022.

Priests recited mantras around the funeral pyre, decorated with vibrant yellow and orange



People gather as the mortal remains of singer Asha Bhosle are taken for last rites in Mumbai on Monday

marigolds. Granddaughter Zana was inconsolable. Sister Usha Mangeshkar, also a singer, and brother Hridaynath Mangeshkar, a music composer, were there too.

Among those gathered to pay their last respects to India's singer nonpareil were Maharashtra Chief

Minister Devendra Fadnavis, Deputy Chief Ministers Eknath Shinde and Sunetra Pawar, director Ramesh Sippy and actors Aamir Khan and Vicky Kaushal.

It was a moment of sorrow and song, too. Before the pyre was lit, singers Shaan, Sudesh Bhosle and

Anup Jalota paid a musical tribute to the enduring legend who sang some 12,000 songs in an incredible eight-decade career that started when she was just 10.

While Sudesh Bhosle crooned "Zindagi Ek Safar Hai Suhana", Shaan sang "Pyaar Ke Mod Pe".

"Asha ji will always be with us. Her voice, her words, her thoughts towards life will always inspire us, and there was no one like her, nor will there ever be. She was the one unique, strong-willed person who lived her life on her own terms.

"And whatever tragedies happened with her, there's no one like her who faced them with a smile, always maintaining a positive mindset, and did her work with full professionalism," Shaan said.

Lalit Pandit, who, along with his brother Jatin, composed the music for Shah Rukh Khan and Kajol's iconic 1995 film "Dilwale Dulhania

Le Jayenge", which featured Bhosle's popular songs "Zara Sa Jhoom Loon Main" and "Ajnabi Mujhko Itna Bata", said she was the last of her kind. "She has left behind so much work in her legacy that generations can learn from it. It is true that she was the last legend and is no longer with us, but she will always remain in our hearts," he added.

And they were not the only ones.

Many fans, their hands folded in prayer, were heard singing the many numbers that made Bhosle the star that she was for music lovers of all ages and through many generations.

Snatches of "Aaiye Meherbaan", the languid song of love filmed on Madhubala, and "Chura Liya Hai Tumne Jo Dil Pe", romance of another hue pictured on Zeenat Aman many decades later, and many others, could be heard. Some softly crooned, others louder.

Nation Focus



PM MODI CONGRATULATES PETER MAGYAR ON HUNGARY POLLS WIN

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday congratulated Peter Magyar on his resounding victory in the parliamentary elections in Hungary and said he was looking forward to working closely with him to further strengthen the bilateral cooperation and advance the vital India-EU Strategic Partnership. Peter Magyar, leader of the centre-right Opposition Tisza party, defeated incumbent Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orban in the election on Sunday. "Heartiest congratulations to Peter Magyar and the Tisza Party on your resounding election victory," Modi said in a social media post. The PM said India and Hungary are bound by a deep-rooted friendship, shared values and enduring mutual respect.

Security tightened in Jammu and Kashmir ahead of Pahalgam attack anniversary

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

In the run-up to the first anniversary of the Pahalgam terror attack, in which 26 civilians, including 25 tourists, were killed by terrorists after ascertaining their religious identities on April 22, the security grid has been tightened in the region to enhance general vigil along the International border and the line of control (LoC).

On the other hand, efforts have been made by the terrorist handlers sitting across Pakistan to push small groups of heavily armed terrorists inside the Indian territory to carry out surprise terrorist attacks in the region.

On Monday, a joint team of security forces launched a search operation in several border areas of Rajbagh and Ramkote in Kathua district following information about suspicious movement of suspected terrorists.

In Rajouri, General Officer



Commanding (GOC) of Ace of Spades Division, Major General Kaushik Mukherji, on Monday, said that the Army troops are on high alert in Jammu and Kashmir's Rajouri and Poonch districts and are fully prepared to deliver a befitting response to any hostile act by the enemy.

Meanwhile, the police and army are also continuing searches for the second day in the SIDCO forest area of the nearby Samba district, which was launched early Sunday after two suspected persons were noticed moving under the cover of darkness.

With the advent of the 'Spring season' in the valley, a fresh security audit was conducted, and adequate security personnel were deployed in and around the tourist hotspots, including local getaways, to instil a sense of security among the visiting tourists.

The famous Tulip garden in Srinagar, ski resort of Gulmarg, Sonamarg, Pahalgam, Tangmarg, Gurez valley, and Bandipora have been witnessing a surge in tourist footfalls with the beginning of the peak tourist season. Jammu region is

also witnessing a heavy rush of pilgrims headed towards Katra in Reasi district to offer prayers in the Cave Shrine of Mata Vaishno Devi, followed by a short trip to Patnitop, Bhaderwah and other tourist spots.

The tourist places which were closed down in the aftermath of the horrific terror attack were thrown open after beefing up the security measures in the region.

In recent weeks, the Union Home Ministry has also reviewed the prevailing security scenario in the Union Territory and adequate measures were taken to dismantle the terror eco-system.

Addressing a well-attended gathering at the 'Rajouri Day' event in the border district, Major General Kaushik Mukherji said that I assure you that our army is fully alert at the borders and is ready to give a befitting response to every hostile act of the enemy.

Delimitation aimed at creating north-south divide: Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Monday alleged that the Government's proposed delimitation linked to the women's reservation law is an attempt to create a divide between the northern and southern States.

The Opposition party asserted that delimitation cannot be an exercise just in arithmetic but should also be about equitability in the real sense, and States such as Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana should not pay a price for better population control and having better indices.

"I believe the way delimitation is being thrust upon the people, it is an attempt to create a divide between the North and the South," Congress spokesperson Supriya Shrinete said at a press conference here when asked about Telangana Chief



Congress spokesperson Supriya Shrinete

Minister A Revanth Reddy's criticism of the Government over the reported delimitation formula proposed by the Government while seeking to amend the women's reservation law for its implementation in 2029.

"There are many southern States whose Human Development Index (HDI) parameters are better than other States - they controlled population, controlled expenditure, so why is delimitation being done to harm them?" Shrinete asked.



KHARGE CALLS OPPOSITION MEET ON WOMEN'S QUOTA ON APRIL 15

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Monday said the Congress will convene a meeting of all the Opposition parties on April 15 to deliberate on the implementation of the Women's Reservation law, accusing the Centre of not being prepared to hold a comprehensive consultation with all stakeholders. Addressing reporters, he maintained that while the party fully supports the legislation, there is a need for wide discussions on its implementation, given its broader national implications. "The Centre has called a meeting. I have already replied to the letter written either by Kiren Rijiju or even the Prime Minister to me," Kharge said.



नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली



बैसाखी

की

हार्दिक शुभकामनाएं

नई फसल, नई उम्मीद और समृद्धि का यह पर्व
आप सभी के जीवन में खुशहाली लेकर आए

States Focus



GOVT TO BUILD MUSIC INSTITUTE
ENVISAGED BY ASHA BHOSLE

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday said the State Government will build a music institute envisaged by legendary singer Asha Bhosle. The 92-year-old singer, who mesmerised generations with her unforgettable melodies across seven decades, passed away on Sunday due to multi-organ failure at Breach Candy Hospital. The Cabinet headed by Fadnavis also paid homage to Asha Bhosle, with a condolence resolution being read out by Chief Secretary Rajesh Agarwal. Deputy Chief Sunetra Pawar and cabinet ministers were present for the meeting. Steps will be taken to build a music institute envisaged by Bhosle, a statement quoted Fadnavis as saying.



UDHAYANIDHI SAYS NDA WIN
WILL MAKE TN RETROGRESSIVE

Tamil Nadu Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin on Monday said the AIADMK-led NDA will make the State "retrogressive" if it is voted to power and appealed to the people to be wise in choosing the DMK combine to sustain the pace of growth. He said the people should reject the AIADMK in the Assembly election as it had "conspired" to halt the monthly entitlement scheme for women heads of families. "Prove in this election that the AIADMK and its ally, the BJP, have no space in Tamil Nadu. Annihilate them in the polls, and wisely choose the DMK to sustain the pace of growth in the State," the DMK youth wing secretary said while addressing a poll campaign here in support of party candidates: Lakshmanan for Villupuram and Gowtham Dravidamani, who is contesting from Vanur Assembly constituency.

62,000 personnel deployed
for Census in Chhattisgarh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Raipur

More than 62,000 personnel have been deployed for the Census 2027 exercise in Chhattisgarh that will be conducted in two phases between May 1 and February next year, officials said on Monday.

Addressing a press conference, State Additional Chief Secretary (Home) Manoj Kumar Pingua said the first phase, covering house listing and housing census, will be carried out from May 1 to May 30 this year, while the second phase, connected to popula-



tion enumeration, will take place in February 2027.

The upcoming Census will be conducted digitally for the first time in the country, with an optional self-enumeration facility, Pingua said.

"The self-enumeration window for the first phase will be open from April 16 to April 30, during which residents can submit their details

DMK made corruption part of system: PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday accused the DMK Government in Tamil Nadu of making "corruption a part of the system" and said the people of the southern State are looking at the BJP-NDA with hopes for a change.

Interacting with the booth-level workers of the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) Tamil Nadu unit under the "Mera Booth Sabse Mazboot" programme, Modi also said he is aware that the people of Tamil Nadu are ready to punish the ruling DMK for its alleged misgovernance.

"In Tamil Nadu, the DMK Government has made corruption a part of the system. Every department is involved in irregularities. Several ministers are facing cases. Corruption, commis-

sion and collection are becoming the identity of the DMK Government," he said.

The prime minister said there was a time when, even after the DMK was in the Central Government, no new projects would come to Tamil Nadu, and no matter how many problems there were, no solutions would be found.

"And then there is today's time, when the NDA Government is bringing major projects for railways, highways and airports. It is working at a fast pace," he said.

Modi said it is due to the hard work of the BJP workers that a new atmosphere has been created among the people of Tamil Nadu now.

"People are looking at the BJP-NDA with hopes for a change," he said.

The prime minister said the welfare of farmers is the



NDA Government's priority and a major step has been taken towards fulfilling the dreams of the middle class.

"Significant transformation has come in the healthcare sector. In Tamil Nadu, 11 new medical colleges have been built, and in a decade, the number of medical seats has doubled," he said.

Modi said between 2004 and 2014, when the DMK was in the Central Government, its approach did not bring new development to Tamil Nadu.

"No matter how many problems were there, they were not resolved. After our Government came to power, Tamil Nadu has seen changes. For example, the

BJP will not allow Babri Masjid in Bengal: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Birbhum/Raniganj

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Monday said TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee and Aam Janata Unnayan Party chief Humayun Kabir are "two of a kind", and the BJP will never allow a Babri Masjid to be built in Bengal if it wins the State polls.

At a poll rally in West Bengal's coal mine belt of Raniganj in Paschim Bardhaman district, Shah accused Banerjee of opposing the construction of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, and drew parallels with Kabir's initiative to build a mosque in Murshidabad's Beldanga modelled on the demolished Babri Masjid in Ayodhya.

Kabir, an MLA from Murshidabad's Bharatpur, who has now formed his own party and is seeking re-election, was suspended from the TMC



Union Home Minister Amit Shah addressing the gathering during an election campaign rally in support of BJP candidates ahead of West Bengal Assembly elections at Kotasur in Birbhum district on Monday

in December last year after he proposed the construction of a Babri-like mosque.

"The Congress, Mamata Banerjee's TMC and other parties such as the DMK, Samajwadi Party, and Bahujan Samaj Party supported keeping Ram Lalla under a tent for 550 years.

"After receiving an overwhelming mandate from people in 2019, Modiji built the

Ram temple in Ayodhya, which leaders like Banerjee opposed. Now, Humayun Kabir, who is cast in the same mould as Mamata Banerjee, wants to build Babri Masjid in Bengal," the former BJP chief said.

The BJP will never allow a Babri Masjid to be built in this State after it wins the upcoming polls, Shah asserted.

His remarks are seen as the BJP's attempt at blunting the

TMC's offensive over a video in which Kabir was purportedly heard saying he was in touch with BJP leaders to unseat Banerjee from power and receiving ₹200 crore as an advance for a ₹1,000-crore deal to split the minority votes.

Latching on to the purported remarks in the video, the veracity of which PTI could not independently verify, Banerjee alleged on Sunday that the BJP has "struck a ₹1,000-crore deal" with Kabir to defeat the TMC.

Addressing poll rallies in Mayureshwar and Khayrasole areas of Birbhum district earlier on Monday, Shah said the people of Bengal will reply to bombs and bullets with votes, and pledged the BJP would "hang the syndicate and cut money promoters upside down to make them straight" once the voters "bid adieu to the TMC Government".

BJP's policies promote detention, deprivation: Abhishek Banerjee

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee on Monday alleged that the BJP's policies promote "detention and deprivation", while asserting that his party stands for "security and welfare".

Addressing an election rally at Karimpur in Nadia district, Banerjee accused the BJP of trying to instil fear among voters and deprive them of their democratic rights through measures like the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise.

"People were made to



stand in queues, and their voting rights were taken away. The answer must be given through votes," he said. "Large sections of marginalised communities, including Matuas, Namashudras and other backward class voters, were disproportionately affected by the SIR, despite possess-

ing valid documents. BJP means detention, and TMC means no tension," he added.

Claiming that even some BJP supporters were now being "deprived of their rights", he urged people not to be intimidated and assured them that their voting rights would be restored after the TMC returns to power.

The TMC leader also targeted the BJP's central leadership, describing them as "outsiders" who come to the state for campaigning without understanding its culture and ethos.

TN paddy row: FM accuses Stalin of creating false narrative

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin on Monday said that the Centre had asked the State to review its existing bonus policy and consider discontinuing it on paddy, and asked Union Finance Minister (FM) Nirmala Sitharaman whether she was willing to place the letter in this regard in public domain.

Hours after the chief minister's social media post, the Union finance minister uploaded a copy of the letter on her social media platform and said building food security required a constructive, continuous and positive engagement on agriculture



with all stakeholders.

"However, CM Thiru @mkstalin appears to continue with what he and his party are good at — draw a wedge between Centre and States, create false narratives and project themselves as the protectors of farmers and other Tamil people," she said.



When essential food items depend on imports, domestic food security becomes vulnerable to external shocks and price fluctuations. That is not sustainable for a country of India's size. Expanding domestic production of pulses and oilseeds is not only an economic necessity

but also a strategic need. "Doesn't he know that huge imports of palm oil is because our demand for edible oil is not adequately met with oil seeds supply. Similar is the issue with pulses. Farmers can get better prices for crops in which there is a supply-demand gap. Clearly, farmers' interest is not in CM Stalin's mind," Sitharaman said, laying the CM.

By encouraging the production of pulses, oilseeds, and millets, India aimed to achieve the twin objectives of "nutritional security" through improved access to protein-rich crops and "economic stability" by reducing the edible oil import bill.

TVK debuts hologram Vijay for TN campaign

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Chennai

In a move that has redefined the landscape of political campaigning in Tamil Nadu, TVK candidate for Kumbakonam, Vinoth Ravi, has deployed a 3D hologram of actor-turned-politician Vijay to reach voters across the State for the April 23 Assembly elections.

The technology made its debut in the Kumbakonam Assembly constituency on April 12.

A life-sized, high-definition digital projection of the TVK chief appeared alongside the party's local candidate. Visuals from the ground showed the



"Hologram Vijay" delivering a synchronised speech from a campaign vehicle, creating an illusion of physical presence that drew crowds.

Vijay Chandran, TVK's Thanjavur district treasur-

er, said they decided to do this when an acquaintance of his was telling him about the possibility of a 3D hologram. According to Chandran, the move is a strategic response to the

gruelling schedule of covering 200-plus constituencies that TVK is competing from.

"We realised that it is not possible for our Thalaivar (TVK chief Vijay) to go to all the constituencies. We were thinking about how best we can bring his message to people. I remembered Praveen K, a third-year student of AI and Data Science, who was telling me about hologram marketing. The hologram initiative allows our leader to be omnipresent, ensuring that voters in every corner of the State can experience his address directly, even as he physically attends high-stakes rallies elsewhere," Chandran said.

NCC, NIELIT launch cyber security programme for cadets

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

In a major step towards empowering cadets with structured training in cyber awareness, digital hygiene and practical cyber defence skills, the National Cadet Corps (NCC), in collaboration with the National Institute of Electronics and Information Technology (NIELIT), has launched a comprehensive Cyber Security Capacity Building Programme, defence ministry said on Monday.



It said a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) has been signed between NCC and NIELIT in the presence of DG NCC, Lt General Virendra

Vats and DG NIELIT, Dr Madan Mohan Tripathi.

The programme will be implemented in two stages. The first stage, Cyber Security

Awareness Programme, is a 15-hour online training module designed to provide foundational knowledge of digital literacy, safe internet practices, cyber hygiene, and awareness of cyber threats. This stage will be open to all enrolled NCC cadets across the country and will be delivered through the NIELIT Digital University platform.

The second stage, Cyber Defender Programme, is an intensive 60-hour offline training designed for select ed cadets who qualify

through a merit-based screening process. This stage will focus on hands-on training, real-life simulations, and practical exposure to cyber-security tools and techniques, enabling cadets to identify and respond to cyber threats effectively.

The initiative aims to create a pool of trained NCC Cyber Cadets who can contribute to spreading cyber awareness, promoting safe digital practices, and supporting cybersecurity initiatives at the grassroots level.

Woman Maoist killed in Chhattisgarh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kanker (Chhattisgarh)

A woman Maoist carrying a reward of ₹5 lakh was killed in an encounter with security personnel in Chhattisgarh's Kanker district on Monday, police said.

The deceased, identified as Rupri, was an area committee member of the Maoists and is believed to be the last senior Telugu cadre active in Chhattisgarh's Bastar region, which comprises seven districts, including Kanker, they said.

The face-off comes 12 days after the Government declared Chhattisgarh free of armed Maoists on March 31. Inspector General of Police, Bastar Range, Sundarraaj



P, said the Government has been continuously appealing to Maoists to surrender and avail rehabilitation benefits, leading to a significant number opting to return to the mainstream in recent months.



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SC notice to Centre, others on plea concerning MSP



The Supreme Court on Monday sought responses from the Centre and others on a plea to accord weightage to States' proposal on the exact cost of cultivation while fixing Minimum Support Price (MSP).

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi issued notices to the Centre and others, including the Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices, seeking their response on the plea.

Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioners, said the plea raises a very important issue related to the farmers in the country.

The plea has sought direction to the authorities to ensure complete procurement of all notified crops under the MSP calculated on the basis of the exact cost of cultivation.

It has also sought direction to take appropriate steps to ensure complete procurement of crops from all farmers who are desirous of selling their crops at the MSP.

NCLAT adjourns hearing on Vedanta plea in JAL case



The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) on Monday adjourned its hearing over mining giant Vedanta Group's petitions against the selection of Adani Enterprises' bid for debt-ridden Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL).

The insolvency appellate tribunal adjourned the hearing on account of a change in the composition of the bench, which was hearing the two appeals filed by Vedanta Ltd. The change has been made due to the unavailability of a member of the bench.

NCLAT will decide the date for the next hearing shortly. Vedanta has filed two petitions, challenging the March 17 order by the Allahabad bench of NCLT, which approved Adani Enterprises Ltd's ₹14,535-crore bid to acquire JAL through the insolvency process.

On March 24, NCLAT declined any interim stay on the order passed by the NCLT approving the Adani Group's bid for acquiring JAL.

However, it said the plan would be subject to the outcome of the appeals filed by the Anil Agarwal-led Vedanta Group. This interim order by NCLAT was challenged before the Supreme Court, which also declined to grant a stay. However, the apex court had directed that if the monitoring committee planned to take any major policy decision, it should first obtain the Tribunal's sanction.

Was almost declared corrupt by you, won't get justice: Kejriwal tells Justice Sharma, seeking her recusal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal on Monday told Delhi High Court judge Swarana Kanta Sharma that her earlier decisions in the liquor policy cases "almost declared" him guilty and corrupt, and that he apprehends he would not get justice if she continues to hear CBI's plea against his discharge.

Appearing before Justice Sharma to argue his application seeking her to withdraw from the case, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) convener contended that under the law on recusal, the question is not of a judge's integrity or uprightness, but of "reasonable bias" in the mind of the litigant.

Kejriwal claimed that except for the CBI's petition and one other case involving a political opponent of the BJP, no other case before Justice Sharma was being heard at the same "speed" and there was a "trend" of the court "endorsing" the



AAP National Convener Arvind Kejriwal arrives at the Delhi High Court for a hearing in a case related to the excise policy in New Delhi on Monday

investigating agencies' arguments. He submitted that on the first day of the hearing on March 9, the court "neutralised" the discharge order, which was passed by the trial judge after day-to-day arguments of over three months, by passing a "sweeping, ex parte order" in haste in violation of principles of natural justice.

On February 27, the trial court discharged Kejriwal, Sisodia and 21 others and pulled up the CBI, saying its

case was wholly unable to survive judicial scrutiny and stood discredited in its entirety.

On March 9, Justice Sharma issued notice to all 23 accused on CBI's plea against their discharge, saying certain observations and findings of the trial court at the stage of framing of charges prima facie appeared erroneous and needed consideration.

She also stayed the trial court's recommendation on

the initiation of departmental action against the CBI's investigating officer in the liquor policy case.

Kejriwal said that Justice Sharma had earlier denied relief to him on his petition challenging his arrest, as well as bail pleas by other accused, including Manish Sisodia and K Kavitha, and also made "strong and conclusive" findings.

He also objected to Justice Sharma attending four functions organised by the Akhil Bharatiya Adhivakta Parishad. He contended that being an ideological opponent of the BJP and RSS, he apprehended that the judge "sympathised" with their ideology and that he would not receive justice.

As Justice Sharma asked Kejriwal if she had made any ideological or political statements in the events, the AAP chief said her attendance was enough.

Kejriwal also alleged that Justice Sharma has a conflict of interest in the case.

He concluded arguments on his recusal application.



No changes at Vrindavan's Bankey Bihari temple: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court of India (SC) on Monday made it clear that it would not make "any structural changes" to the present arrangement with regard to religious practices at the famous Bankey Bihari temple in Vrindavan.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi took note of the submissions of senior advocate Shayam Divan and lawyer Tanvi Dubey, and directed that the matter be listed after two weeks to allow the parties to respond to a recently-filed status report.

The top court was hearing a petition filed by the management committee of the Thakur Shree Bankey Bihari Ji Maharaj Temple and Sevayats (priests).

The petitioners have challenged recent administrative decisions taken by a court-appointed High-Powered Committee (HPC) that have allegedly interfered with age-old religious traditions.

Earlier, the court had stayed parts of the Uttar Pradesh Shri Bankey Bihari Ji Temple Trust Ordinance, 2025, and formed the 12-member HPC headed by



retired Allahabad High Court judge Ashok Kumar to oversee the temple's operations. Divan told the court that he was given a status report late on Sunday evening and that he be granted two weeks to respond.

"We are not inclined to make any structural changes to the present arrangement," the CJ said while adjourning the hearing.

Additional Solicitor General KM Nataraj said the HPC wants to go in accordance with the court's directions and no adversarial stand will be taken in this case.

The apex court, on December 15, 2025, issued notices on the plea and the status report was filed on Sunday.

The bench also issued a

notice on an application that has raised certain factual and other grounds, which require modifications or clarifications.

The petitioners have raised concerns on how the interpretation of wide powers has been done by the HPC that has passed certain orders touching upon the essential religious rituals of the temple, including a change in the "darshan" timing, closing the Dehri puja ritual, exorbitant charges imposed on Sevayat Goswami's charging for phool bangla service etc.

The challenge in the plea is mainly related to the change in the "darshan" timing of the temple and also the stopping of certain essential religious practices, including the *Dehri puja*.

The petitioners have submitted that the temple has historically followed strict seasonal timings and distinct schedules for summer and winter that are closely intertwined with internal rituals, including the waking and resting of the deity.

It was argued that recent changes in timings, effected pursuant to office memorandum issued in September 2025, have disrupted the essential religious practices at the temple.

Emphasising the temple's unique and sacrosanct nature, the petitioners have explained that there is a unique timing for morning and evening "darshan", rooted in tradition and religious purpose.

The petitioners have also highlighted that the discontinuation of the age-old "Dehri puja", performed exclusively by the Goswamis, is a part of the Guru-Shishya parampara, arguing that its suspension on the ground of crowd management is unfounded since the ritual is performed when the temple is closed to the public and at a limited, specific location.

The bench issued a direction to hear both the application and the main plea after two weeks.

No SC relief to Lalu in land-for-jobs case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a setback to Lalu Prasad Yadav, the Supreme Court on Monday refused to quash a CBI FIR in the land-for-jobs case involving the RJD chief and his family members.

A bench of Justices MM Sundresh and N Kotiswar Singh, however, granted exemption to the 77-year-old former Bihar chief minister from appearance before the trial court during the proceedings.

"We do not say anything about the issue pertaining to the application of Section 17A (of the Prevention of Corruption Act) on whether it is prospective or retrospective. Taking into consideration the facts and the circumstances, liberty is granted to the petitioner to raise the legal issue at the time of the trial," the bench said.

The top court allowed Yadav to raise the issue of the applicability of Section 17A of the Prevention of Corruption Act in the case during trial of the case.

Section 17A of the Prevention of Corruption Act provides that no enquiry, inquiry or investigation shall be conducted by a police officer into any offence alleged to have been committed by a public servant under



the law without prior approval from the appropriate authority. During the hearing, Additional Solicitor General SV Raju, appearing for the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), argued that Section 17A of the Act would be invoked only if the accused was a decision-making authority.

Raju argued that prior approval against Yadav under Section 17A was not required as he was neither the person who took the decision nor the recommending authority.

Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Yadav, opposed the submission and said that there cannot be any investigation until the authorities get the sanction.

Sibal said the CBI has woken up after nine years to file another chargesheet on the same ground on which the case had been closed.

Indian judiciary cannot be confined to buildings: CJI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Monday said the Indian judiciary of the future cannot remain confined within imposing buildings or constrained by geography.

Speaking at the 4th Ashok Desai Memorial lecture here on the topic "Reimagining Justice: The Indian Judiciary 50 Years Hence", the CJI said the judiciary of the future must transform into a service that is accessible, responsive and seamlessly integrated



into the daily lives of citizens.

"Indian judiciary of the future cannot remain confined within imposing buildings or constrained by geography. It must transform into a service that is accessible, responsive and seamlessly integrated into the daily lives of citizens.

"In such a vision, justice is no longer something one must travel to seek, but something that reaches individuals efficiently, equitably and with a sensitivity to the realities of a changing society," the CJI said.

CJI Kant said the endeavour of the judiciary must be to nurture a system of justice which, 50 years from now, is more accessible, responsive and closely integrated into the lives of citizens.

He said the judge of the future cannot remain confined within the identity of a

legal specialist or jurist alone.

"The disputes that will come before the courts will require an understanding that extends far beyond statutes and precedents. For instance, judges may find themselves grappling with questions of synthetic biology, raising issues of liability where life itself is engineered.

"Matters such as deep-sea mining will test the limits of environmental responsibility in spaces that lie outside conventional jurisdiction," he said.

Assam Govt moves SC against bail to Pawan Khera

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Assam Government has moved the Supreme Court against the Telangana High Court order granting one-week transit anticipatory bail to Congress leader Pawan Khera in a case registered against him for levelling allegations against Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's wife.

The petition was filed on Sunday through advocate Shuvodeep Roy and is likely to be taken up for hearing this week. On April 10, the High Court granted one-week transit anticipatory bail to Khera. The High Court gave him a week's time to file an application before the court concerned and granted him relief with certain conditions.

"Without expressing any opinion



on the merits of the case, this court is of the view that the petitioner has made out a case for grant of limited transit anticipatory bail, as his apprehension of arrest appears to be rea-

sonable and supported by material on record," the High Court had said in its order.

The conditions were that the petitioner shall be released on bail in the event of arrest on his executing a personal bond for ₹one lakh with two sureties for the like sum each, cooperate with the investigation and make himself available for interrogation as and when required by the Investigating Officer and that he shall not leave the country without prior permission of the competent Court.

The conditions further include that the petitioner shall, within the stipulated period, approach the competent jurisdictional court in Assam and seek appropriate relief and he, being a public figure, shall exercise restraint in making any further public statements in relation

to the subject matter of the present case, which may prejudice the investigation, the order said. The Congress leader on April 5 had alleged that the Assam CM's wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, has multiple passports and foreign property, which were not declared in the chief minister's election affidavit for the April 9 Assembly polls in that State.

The case against Khera was registered at the Guwahati Crime Branch Police Station under several sections of the BNS, including 175 (false statement in connection with an election), 35 (Right of private defence of the body and of property) and 318 (cheating). Khera, who approached the High Court on April 7, showed his residential address in Hyderabad. He had requested the High Court to release him on bail in the event of his arrest.

SC reserves key SCAORA posts for women lawyers in upcoming polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday reserved the posts of secretary, joint treasurer and two executive positions for women lawyers in the upcoming elections of the Supreme Court Advocates-On-Record Association (SCAORA).

The top court invoked Article 142 of the Constitution to pass the order. This provision empowers the apex court to pass any decree or order necessary to provide "complete justice" in any pending case.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi was hearing a petition filed by advocate-on-record Vivya Nagpal. The plea sought the court's direction to mandate at least 33 per cent reservation for women in the executive body of the SCAORA and use its power under Article 142 of the Constitution to allow the petition. It also challenged an election notice issued on April 8 for the 2026-2028 term of the association and contended that it provides no reservation for women candidates.

The petitioner had sought to quash the notification for lacking such reservation, arguing it violated fundamental rights under Articles 14, 15 and 21 of the Constitution and perpetuates sys-

temic exclusion of women from leadership roles in the body.

According to the plea, the association, comprising around 3,000 advocates-on-record who have exclusive rights to file and act in cases before the apex court, has historically seen negligible representation of women in office-bearer positions, with the current executive committee being all-male.

Seeking urgent relief, the petitioner also filed an application for an interim stay on the election process or, alter-



natively, a direction to conduct elections with 33 per cent reservation for women across executive and office-bearer posts.

The top court, in December 2023, had ordered that 30 per cent representation in State bar councils be provided to women lawyers.

To address contingencies where an insufficient number of women are elected, the bench had allowed for a "co-option" mechanism to fill up to 10 per cent of those seats.



Editor's
TAKE

The unfinished promise of equality

As India commemorates the 135th birth anniversary of BR Ambedkar, the moment calls for more than homage – it demands introspection and a resolve to realise his dream

“Political democracy cannot last unless there lies at the base of it social democracy”; these were the prophetic words of BR Ambedkar, the architect of the Indian Constitution. As India marks his 135th birth anniversary, his dream largely remains unfulfilled. After nearly eighty years of independence, India is still fragmented and layered, where caste hierarchies have transformed but not disappeared. Castes have taken on political and social dimensions and have consolidated their presence as identities that define the present-day political scenario of the country. Political parties, for their part, have often supported caste structures rather than making concerted efforts to dismantle them-distributing tickets on the basis of caste, allocating influential positions to appease dominant groups, and even openly declaring their intent to support the aspirations of the castes that back them.

To add yet another layer of complexity, religious and regional identities have grown increasingly pronounced. Vote-bank politics and the polarisation of masses along these lines have only worsened the situation. This is not to say that Ambedkar's dream has faded; it has not-only that it currently finds few committed takers, as electoral gains and power politics cloud the vision of political actors.

That said, despite these challenges, the Constitution of India remains the anchor of Indian democracy and has withstood the vagaries of time. Ambedkar consistently maintained that true democracy would not be possible without equality. In a society that does not honour individual dignity and tolerates deep divisions, democracy will always remain fragile. While the Constitution provides a legal framework, the principle of equality must permeate society. It guarantees fundamental rights, abolishes untouchability, and lays the groundwork for advancing equality.

The social system is changing, but the pace remains slow. Ironically, contemporary politics has not made sustained efforts to dismantle entrenched inequalities. More than seven decades on, there has certainly been progress, yet much remains to be done. India has achieved significant advances across sectors, but social inequalities persist. Hierarchies, discrimination, and exclusion continue to act as barriers to national progress. There have been some efforts to bring about change. Government initiatives aimed at social justice and inclusion-such as scholarships for Scheduled Castes and Tribes, digital literacy programmes, skill development missions, and housing schemes-reflect attempts to expand opportunities. Yet, the true tribute to Ambedkar must be measured in outcomes-whether the most marginalised experience a genuine sense of belonging and empowerment. Ambedkar did not seek charity for the oppressed; he demanded justice. On his 135th anniversary, the challenge is to move beyond ritual remembrance and undertake the unfinished task of social transformation. Only then can India truly fulfil Ambedkar's vision – a nation where democracy is rooted in equality and shared dignity.

Fraternity: The sustainer of democratic life

India remembers BR Ambedkar as the architect of the Indian Constitution and champion of social justice for the oppressed. He is deservedly celebrated for securing rights, advancing social justice and giving institutional shape to democracy



JAGMOHAN SINGH RAJU

On the birth anniversary of BR Ambedkar, it is worth recalling that he did not see democracy as self-sustaining. He understood that its sustenance depended on the cultivation of a shared social order. The Constitution carries this vision forward, but its fulfilment remains an ongoing task. India remembers BR Ambedkar as the architect of the Indian Constitution and champion of social justice for the oppressed. He is deservedly celebrated for securing rights, advancing social justice and giving institutional shape to democracy.

Yet, this recognition captures only part of his intellectual vision. At the heart of Ambedkar's thought lay a deeper concern-fraternity. Not as a moral afterthought, but as the condition that sustains a harmonious society. It is this central idea that finds expression in the Constitution of India. Properly understood, the Constitution is not merely a framework of rights; it is a design that seeks to promote fraternity, because without it the democratic republic cannot endure. No constitutional arrangement, however well-crafted, can hold if society remains divided in its everyday life. Ambedkar's understanding of democracy went far beyond electoral processes or institutional design. He described it as a "mode of associated living", grounded in how individuals relate to one another. Political equality, he warned, could coexist with deep social and economic inequalities. Where such divisions persist, democracy risks becoming formal-stable in structure but fragile in substance. Fraternity addresses this contradiction. It enables individuals to recognise one another as members of a shared community, not merely as bearers of rights. Without such recognition, liberty tends to concentrate and equality remains confined to constitutional text. Fraternity, in this sense, is not an adjunct to democracy; it is the condition that allows democratic life to function in practice.

The persistence of social divisions in India underscores the urgency of this idea. A society marked by caste hierarchies, religious mistrust, linguistic divisions and widening economic inequality struggles to sustain a sense of common belonging. Individuals often share the same political framework while remaining separated in their lived experiences-whether in patterns of settlement, education or everyday social interaction. This distance is not merely structural; it is experienced in the ordinary routines of life, where interaction across social boundaries remains limited. For Ambedkar, caste represented the most enduring obstacle. It did not merely



ON THE BIRTH ANNIVERSARY OF BR AMBEDKAR, IT IS WORTH RECALLING THAT HE DID NOT SEE DEMOCRACY AS SELF-SUSTAINING. HE UNDERSTOOD THAT ITS SUSTENANCE DEPENDED ON THE CULTIVATION OF A SHARED SOCIAL ORDER. THE CONSTITUTION CARRIES THIS VISION FORWARD, BUT ITS FULFILMENT REMAINS AN ONGOING TASK

produce inequality; it structured social relations in ways that prevented mutual recognition. His call for the annihilation of caste was therefore not only a demand for justice, but a necessary step towards fraternity. Without addressing such structures, the possibility of a cohesive and harmonious society remains limited. Fraternity is explicitly affirmed in the Preamble of the Constitution of India. Yet, its significance lies not only in this declaration, but in how it shapes the constitutional scheme. The Constitution does not treat fraternity as a separate objective; it embeds it within a framework of rights and principles that actively reshape social relations.

This design reflects a clear insight: fraternity cannot be legislated directly. It must be cultivated through conditions that enable individuals to relate to one another as equals. The Constitution therefore operates indirectly-by removing barriers, reducing distance and fostering shared spaces. In doing so, it carries forward Ambedkar's central idea into institutional form. The Right to Equality is central to this design. By prohibiting discrimination and ensuring equal access to opportunities, it seeks to dismantle the formal hierarchies that structure social life. These provisions do more than secure individual rights; they alter the terms on which individuals relate to one another.

As divisions of caste, religion and status are reduced, the basis for mutual recognition expands. Equality does not by itself produce fraternity, but it is its necessary starting condition. Without equality, fraternity cannot take root; with it, the ground is prepared for its growth.

The Directive Principles, particularly Article 39 of the Indian Constitution, seek to address economic inequality, which is another impediment to fraternity. These provisions are often understood in terms of welfare or economic justice. Yet, they also serve a broader constitutional purpose. A society marked by stark material inequality cannot sustain a shared sense of community. By reducing such disparities, the Constitution attempts to create the material conditions necessary for social harmony.

Fraternity is ultimately shaped through lived experience. It emerges not from abstract commitment, but from sustained interaction across social boundaries. The right to education under Article 21A of the Constitution, read with the inclusionary mandate of Section 12(1)(c) of the Right to Education Act, reflects this understanding.

By requiring private schools to admit children from disadvantaged backgrounds, this framework creates shared spaces where individuals from different social and economic contexts can interact from an early age. Such interaction has the potential to weaken inherited divisions and foster a sense of common belonging.

This remains one of the few institutional mechanisms that directly advances the constitutional project of fraternity. Strengthening such provisions is therefore not only a matter of educational policy, but a step towards realising Ambedkar's vision of a just society.

The Constitution's commitment to secularism reinforces this design. It goes beyond State neutrality and relies on mutual respect across religious differences. Likewise, reducing inequality requires a shared sense of community. In both cases, law can create frameworks, but their success depends on fraternity.

Taken together, these elements reveal a coherent constitutional logic. Different provisions address different forms of division-legal, economic and social-but converge in promoting the conditions necessary for a democratic society.

The existence of these constitutional provisions does not guarantee their full realisation. Social divisions persist and, in some contexts, deepen.

Equality may be affirmed in law, yet remain uneven in practice. Shared institutions exist, but patterns of separation linger in everyday life.

This gap highlights the limits of constitutional design. The Constitution can promote fraternity, but it cannot ensure it. Fraternity requires continuous social effort – it must be nurtured through institutions, reinforced through policy and sustained through everyday interaction. In this context, greater attention to provisions that foster shared experience becomes essential. Measures such as the inclusionary framework in education assume particular importance. They represent attempts to move beyond formal equality towards lived equality, and thereby towards fraternity.

To read the Constitution through the lens of fraternity is to recover the core of Ambedkar's thought. His project was not limited to securing rights or correcting injustice. It was directed at creating a society capable of sustaining democratic life through relations of mutual recognition and respect. Fraternity, in this sense, is not an abstract ideal placed alongside democracy, secularism or welfare. It is the condition that allows these values to endure. The Constitution embodies this insight by seeking to promote fraternity through its design. Without fraternity, the Constitution may endure in form – but the democratic republic cannot endure in substance.

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The illusion of peace amid ongoing conflict



ASHA IYER KUMAR

2ND OPINION

We are into the second day of the so-called truce in the Middle East, touted as victory by all who lobbed bombs into the other man's territory with impunity and disregard for more than a month. On Wednesday – Trump's "big day for world peace" – hundreds were slaughtered and wounded in Lebanon, and just before I started writing this column, I heard three explosions behind me, echoing from interceptions in some part of the city.

Two nights ago, when the world was pushed to the brink, with no clue about what the morning would bring, when alarm clocks were set to the deadline in these parts and people sprang up to read the breaking news, one could at once hear a collective sigh of relief from every window across the globe. But two days later, what was perceived to have been achieved seems more illusory, and I am

forced to redefine the lexicons involved: 'Truce' and 'cease-fire' do not necessarily mean peace.

Whoever believes this is a pivotal point in the proceedings that only got more and more complicated with each passing day has to be delusional. And at this moment, the world probably chooses to be so, because respite and resolution often depend on how you respond to a situation than how the situation itself unfolds. The markets rallied instantly and oil prices dipped. We boosted ourselves with the thought that the worst is over now, and life will jig back to normalcy in a jiffy - as soon as the word 'ceasefire' rang out from the portals of the White House. As if, in two weeks, a blustering world leader out to pilfer other nations' wealth, his crony whose dictionary doesn't contain the word 'truce', a hardline theocratic regime that refuses

to give up, and its regional proxies will all sit down at a banquet and declare: let's be friends and get on with life and business.

Nothing that has happened in the past two days points at a resolution that will guarantee lasting peace. This is not a nihilistic prophecy. It is what a rational mind can conclude considering how divergent the demands on either side are, how all stakeholders and the impacted parties in the Gulf region are excluded from the 'closed door' talks, how there has been blatant violation of the promise to hold fire and how the language itself has

changed - Lebanon is not included in the deal, and so, Israel retains the power to pound them with any device of ruin.

"Truce" has become a hollow word-offering peace selectively while violence continues elsewhere. Peace cannot be dispensed in pieces. It cannot arrive in barrages of bombs. It cannot happen overnight with overblown claims of victory. What we now have is an uneasy calm punctured by sporadic attacks continuing in the Gulf countries, which we are persuading ourselves to believe as impending peace. Because the mind wants reassurance, even if it is chimerical and fleeting.

For now, there is cautious optimism that may hold for a short while-a brief psychological relief that something is in the works. Can we expect a viable outcome? Will it be worth the paper it is written on? Given the direction in which the ceasefire has gone,

the dominant sentiment is one of scepticism. It is a war that began without clear-cut objectives and spiralled out of control, leaving the world confused by its shifting narratives. Nothing concrete has been accomplished, despite repeated assertions. How this predicament will be resolved remains uncertain. What, then, was this war about-power, strategy, or simply destruction? The answer remains unclear.

The writer is a Dubai-based author, columnist and children's writing coach

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A voice that lives forever

In the demise of Asha Bhosle, the nation has lost its melody queen, a musical legend whose magical voice will live in our hearts forever.

An inborn talent, Asha Tai remained unparalleled from the 1940s through a career spanning over seven decades, during which she reigned supreme in the world of music.

The magic of her voice cannot be described in words; it can only be felt. Whether devotional songs, romantic melodies, qawwalis, cabaret numbers, classical pieces, or lively disco tracks, she sang every genre with remarkable ease and elegance. Each song she rendered became distinctive and unforgettable.

With over 12,000 songs in numerous languages, she mesmerised generations of listeners. Honoured with the Padma Vibhushan and the Dadasaheb Phalke Award, along with National and Filmfare Awards, her contributions remain unparalleled.

Her iconic songs will forever echo in the hearts of music lovers worldwide. Though she is no longer with us, her timeless voice will continue to inspire, comfort, and enchant generations to come. Her legacy endures beyond time and memory.

Bureaucracy needs real change

Referring to the discussion on civil services remuneration, merely increasing salaries through successive pay commissions cannot transform the entrenched work culture within the bureaucracy. The persistent nine-to-five mindset, marked by complacency and limited accountability, continues to hinder efficiency and responsiveness.

In earlier times, administrators were known for discipline and rigour, often working under strict oversight. Today, however, a decline in work standards is evident, with limited incentives for performance and little consequence for inefficiency. Salary hikes alone cannot instil diligence or commitment. Even in advanced democracies like the United States, bureaucratic privileges have been questioned, and reforms have been attempted to improve governance outcomes. These developments highlight the need for structural and attitudinal changes rather than financial incentives alone. In India, respect for bureaucracy is reflected in generous pay revisions, but without accountability and reform, this risks perpetuating inefficiency. Lateral entry and private-sector expertise could bring fresh perspectives, yet institutional resistance remains strong.

Remembering Ambedkar's enduring legacy

Babasaheb Ambedkar Jayanti, observed on April 14, commemorates the birth of B. R. Ambedkar, a visionary who transformed India's social and constitutional landscape. More than a ceremonial occasion, it is a time to reflect on his enduring commitment to justice, dignity, and equality. Born in 1891 into a marginalised community, he faced systemic discrimination from an early age, yet rose through education and determination to become one of India's foremost intellectuals and reformers.

His academic journey took him to institutions such as Columbia University and the London School of Economics, where he developed ideas that would later shape modern India. As the principal architect of the Constitution, he ensured the inclusion of fundamental rights, legal safeguards against discrimination, and a framework aimed at securing social justice.

Ambedkar believed democracy must rest on liberty, equality, and fraternity, extending beyond political structures into everyday life. Honouring his legacy requires more than remembrance; it demands active commitment to his ideals-promoting education, ensuring equality, and building a society grounded in dignity, justice, and inclusive progress for all.

US-IRAN TALKS SIGNAL FRAGILE HOPE FOR PEACE

Appropos of 'Diplomacy fails to deliver US-Iran deal' (April 13), the recent talks between the United States and Iran, though inconclusive, represent an important step towards de-escalation in an increasingly volatile West Asian region. The very fact that senior officials, led by JD Vance, engaged in direct dialogue after decades reflects a shared recognition that prolonged conflict serves no one's interests.

However, as rightly highlighted, the trust deficit remains the most significant obstacle. Longstanding tensions over Iran's nuclear programme, concerns regarding the security of the Strait of Hormuz, and Israel's ongoing military actions in Lebanon continue to impede meaningful progress. These issues are deeply interconnected and require careful, sustained engagement rather than

episodic negotiations.

In such a fragile environment, even a temporary ceasefire provides a vital window of opportunity. It allows space for diplomacy to take root and for stakeholders to explore avenues of compromise. Squandering such moments would only deepen instability and prolong uncertainty in the region.

The international community must therefore play a more proactive role in encouraging dialogue and ensuring restraint from all sides. Confidence-building measures, greater transparency, and respect for mutual concerns are essential to rebuild trust.

Peace cannot be achieved overnight, but sustained diplomacy, patience, and political will can gradually bridge divides and prevent further escalation.

VANDANA | CHANDIGARH

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Evolving dynamics: A new chapter for the CAPF cadre

The Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill, 2026 has reopened deep fault lines — over stalled careers, denied parity, and what many see as an attempt to override a binding Supreme Court mandate — leaving thousands at the core of India’s internal security questioning their place in the system they serve



JATINDER PAL SINGH

The Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill 2026, introduced in the Rajya Sabha on March 25, cleared on April 1, amid opposition walkouts, and approved by voice vote in the Lok Sabha on April 2, received Presidential assent on April 9, CRPF Valour Day.

This has caused disillusionment among the CAPF officers’ executive cadre.

While public discourse has largely narrowed to IPS deputation quotas, the cadre’s deeper grievances centre on non-implementation of OGAS status, resulting in severe career stagnation, repeated court battles even for entitled benefits, absence of a meaningful voice in policy, and a growing feeling of institutional orphanhood.

Often, the government bundles unrelated allowances, granting one in lieu of another. Even when vacancies existed at higher ranks, eligible cadre officers were denied promotions and had to seek relief through prolonged court litigation.

The Bill is perceived as a mechanism to overturn the Supreme Court’s 2025 mandate. The most controversial element is Clause 3’s sweeping “notwithstanding” provision, which overrides other laws, judgments, or orders and empowers the Central Government to frame rules on these matters. It codifies IPS deputation quotas: 50 per cent IG posts, at least 67 per cent of Additional Director General (ADG) posts, and 100 per cent of Special DG and Director General (DG) posts to be filled exclusively by IPS officers on deputation.

The government argues this ensures Centre-State coordination and operational synergy, especially when CAPFs function in aid of state police. The Bill notably drops the earlier 20 per cent IPS quota at DIG level while firmly locking in dominance at higher echelons.

Judicial Mandate vs Legislative Reality

In the landmark judgment of 23 May 2025 in Sanjay Prakash & Ors vs Union of India, the Supreme Court explicitly recognised the Group A executive cadre of the CAPFs as an Organised Group ‘A’ Service (OGAS) “for all



MANY CADRE OFFICERS WHO PREVIOUSLY CHAMPIONED THE GOVERNMENT’S NARRATIVE NOW VIEW THE BILL AS A DEFINITIVE BREACH OF TRUST, LEADING THEM TO REASSESS AND SWITCH THEIR POLITICAL PREFERENCES

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purposes”, entitling them to parity with other central organised services which enjoy OGAS benefits seamlessly; CAPFs do not. The Court directed a comprehensive cadre review within six months, amendments to recruitment and service rules in consultation with cadre representatives, and progressive reduction of IPS deputation up to IG level over two years to restore morale. The government’s review petition was dismissed on October 28, 2025, making the order final and binding. Contempt petitions for non-compliance remain pending.

Although CAPFs historically qualified as an organised service even before the Sixth Pay Commission, and partial NFFU was extended following earlier rulings, full structured career progression and complete Non-Functional Financial Upgradation (NFFU) as a safeguard against stagnation have remained diluted.

In sharp contrast, the Railway Protection Force (RPF), through the same litigation, has received full OGAS implementation with revised service rules, timely cadre management, and all consequential benefits. The divergent approach by the Ministry of Home Affairs versus the Ministry of Railways has reinforced perceptions of selective treatment and inherent conflict of interest.

Severe stagnation and the human cost

Roughly 13,000 Group A cadre officers form the operational backbone in CAPFs, yet face extreme bottlenecks. Assistant

Commandants are waiting for their first promotion even after putting in 15-16 years of service. This stands in glaring contrast to IPS, where an officer in the same time span reaches the post of DIG, and in state police a DSP can realistically expect promotion to SP within 8-12 years with further timely advancement. A single IPS deputation at senior levels blocks a dozen or so promotions in the chain below.

CAPF officers endure the harshest operational conditions-at high altitudes, on borders, in dense forests, and in repeated deployments-yet see no comparable entitled benefits. Supporting cadres such as the medical wing enjoy faster time-scale promotions up to Commandant, distorting hierarchy and professional respect in a uniformed force. Parliamentary panels have repeatedly flagged this stagnation as a serious threat to operational effectiveness, calling for urgent cadre reviews that have long remained pending.

Institutional orphanhood: No voice in policy

Cadre officers shoulder the heaviest national security burdens while having virtually no say in policy formulation, cadre reviews, or service rules that directly govern their careers. The dual control exercised by the Ministry of Home Affairs creates an inherent bias. Unlike IPS officers and state police forces, CAPF cadre officers are systematically denied robust

associations to advocate their interests-a striking irony in which commanders enjoy advocacy rights but withhold them from those under their command. This forces constant reliance on courts for routine matters, deepening the perception of second-class status within their own forces.

The “coordination” argument advanced by supporters is challenged by four decades of ground evidence: cadre IGs have successfully commanded their forces in operational areas, delivering comparable or superior results without disruption in liaison with state or civil administration. Softer or non-operational sectors are often assigned to deputationists for convenience. Limited and time-bound deputations could address genuine coordination needs without imposing a permanent glass ceiling.

The specialised operational ethos developed through ground-up service in extreme terrains remains irreplaceable.

Voices from retired officers

Retired CRPF IG KK Sharma, responding to a retired IPS officer, recalled that stalwarts like KF Rustamji, VG Kanetkar, and KPS. Gill themselves advocated entrusting higher leadership roles to senior CAPF officers once they gained experience. He described the issue as one of justice and moral entitlement after decades of IPS-led management,

Social consciousness is Ambedkar’s mantra for achieving social equality



ARVIND P BHANU

On the occasion of the 135th birth anniversary of the great Bhimrao Ambedkar, whose name instantly evokes thoughts of social equality, we remember his contributions to igniting social change through a legal rights-driven mechanism. His tireless efforts and unwavering dedication paved the way for countless reforms that continue to inspire generations. Today, we honour his legacy by reaffirming our commitment to justice and human dignity for all.

Ambedkar advocated legal rights to eliminate inequality and discrimination. He believed that such rights must be accompanied by “social consciousness, without which equality cannot be achieved”. He devoted his entire life to this cause, viewing social consciousness as the fundamental mantra of social equality. His efforts culminated in drafting the Indian Constitution, which enshrines the principles of justice, liberty, equality, and fraternity for all citizens. His vision extended beyond law; he championed education and economic empowerment as essential tools to uplift marginalised communities. Through his unceasing struggle, he laid the groundwork for a more inclusive and democratic society. Even today, his teachings inspire movements for social reform and human rights across India and beyond.

Vision of a casteless society

Ambedkar envisioned a casteless society where everyone enjoys equal rights and opportunities. He drafted the Indian Constitution, embedding principles of equality, liberty, and fraternity. He prioritised equality before liberty, placing Articles 14-18 (fundamental rights to equality) before liberty rights such as Articles 19 and 21 in Part III of the Constitution. By abolishing untouchability and prohibiting discrimination on the basis of caste, the Constitution aimed to dismantle centuries-old social hierarchies. Ambedkar believed that social reform was essential for true democracy and that legal safeguards must accompany social change. His vision sought to create an inclusive India where all individuals could realise their full potential without the barriers of caste-based discrimination.

Roots of inequality

According to Ambedkar, India’s social and economic inequalities stem from the caste system. Born into a Dalit family, he faced discrimination from childhood, which strengthened his resolve to fight for the oppressed. His father’s lesson “edu-



cation makes everything possible”— ignited his lifelong faith in learning. Overcoming countless barriers, he earned degrees from Columbia University and the London School of Economics, laying the foundation for his advocacy. Ambedkar argued that true social reform required not only legal changes but also a deep transformation of societal attitudes. His work emphasised the need for political representation and economic empowerment of marginalised communities to achieve genuine equality.

Twofold freedom

As a philosopher and social reformer, Ambedkar argued for twofold freedom: first, freedom from shackles (liberation from social restrictions and inequalities), and second, freedom to act without discrimination (the capacity to pursue one’s goals and aspirations). He saw the caste system as restricting these freedoms for lower castes, viewing social consciousness as a powerful tool for achieving social justice through awareness of inequalities. Ambedkar believed that true emancipation required both the removal of systemic barriers and the empowerment of individuals to participate fully in society. He emphasised education and legal reforms as essential mechanisms to

dismantle oppressive structures and promote equal rights. Ultimately, his vision of twofold freedom was foundational in shaping modern democratic ideals and policies aimed at creating an inclusive and equitable social order.

Individual consciousness vs social awakening

People in his time had consciousness, but it was too feeble and individualistic to become truly social. Two examples illustrate this: his Marathi Brahmin teacher, Keshav Ambedkar, gave him the surname “Ambedkar” for social protection, and another Brahmin teacher, Dada Keluskar, recognised his talent and took him to Maharaja Sayajirao Gaekwad III for funding his foreign education. These were acts of personal consciousness. Ambedkar transformed personal consciousness into social consciousness through legal mechanisms. He realised that individual advancement, while important, could not dismantle systemic oppression without collective action and structural reforms. Ultimately, his efforts laid the groundwork for a broader social awakening that challenged entrenched caste hierarchies and fought for equal rights across society.

Key contributions

His efforts inspired countless people to challenge social norms and discrimination. His negotiation skills secured the 1932 Poona Pact, reserving seats for Dalits in legislative bodies-a milestone for marginalised communities’ political representation. As Chairman of the Constitution’s Drafting Committee, he ensured provisions for social justice, equality, and the abolition of untouchability. He championed the cause of education for all, advocating policies that promoted access to schooling for disadvantaged groups. Additionally, he played a pivotal role in formulating laws that protected labour rights and improved working conditions across India. Through his writings and speeches, he raised awareness about caste-based inequalities and mobilised public support for progressive social reforms.

Beyond dalits: Universal equality

It would be unfair to say Ambedkar worked only for Dalits. He championed equality, liberty, justice, and fraternity for all deprived classes, with equal emphasis on women’s rights. The Uniform Civil Code (Article 44) reflected his vision for women’s equality, liberty, and justice. Before his death in 1956, he introduced the Hindu Code Bill, securing laws such as the Hindu Marriage Act, Hindu Succession Act, Hindu Minority and Guardianship Act, and Hindu Adoptions and Maintenance Act. His efforts laid the groundwork for a more inclusive society, challenging deeply entrenched social hierarchies and advocating legal reforms that aimed to protect the marginalised across caste, gender, and class lines. Ambedkar’s legacy continues to inspire movements for social justice and equality in contemporary India and beyond.

Ambedkar and Gandhi

History notes ideological differences between Ambedkar and Gandhi. Ambedkar did not participate in the freedom struggle (Gandhi’s domain), but fought for equality, eradication of discrimination, and socio-economic justice. He believed liberty without equality cannot yield justice-a truth, since equality and liberty complement each other. Even expelling the British for self-rule without social equality would barely differ from subjugation. Gandhi, on the other hand, prioritised spiritual and moral awakening through non-violent resistance, emphasising unity but favouring personal reform over structural change. Though both approaches mattered, Ambedkar’s assertion of “social consciousness” uniquely addresses the call for structural transformation to achieve a just society.

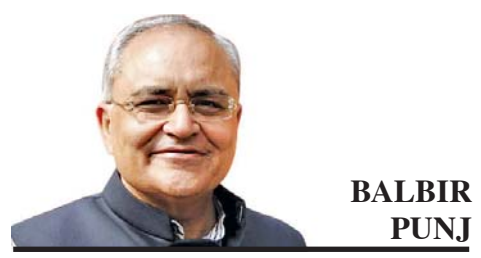
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Lebanon’s tragic transformation



BALBIR PUNJ

As the Middle East teeters on the edge between fragile peace and the looming threat of devastating war, Lebanon — a once thriving beacon of modernity and prosperity-frequently makes headlines for all the wrong reasons. Here lies a compelling story that highlights how demographics can ultimately shape a nation’s destiny.

The country’s decline from the “Paris of the Middle East” to a scene of repeated death and destruction is not only a regional tragedy but also a warning to vulnerable civilisations. Recent events, including Israel’s increased strikes against Hezbollah during the ongoing Gulf crisis-one of which reportedly killed over 300 people-have once again brought global focus to a nation that once symbolised cultural elegance, economic strength, and diverse harmony.

To understand the gravity of Lebanon’s current situation, one must look back at its history. In the 1960s and early 1970s, Lebanon was recognised for its progressive character within the Arab world. Beirut was not just metaphorically but genuinely the “Paris of the Middle East” — a centre of intellectual debate, artistic achievement, and cosmopolitan life. Its universities drew students from across the Arab region, its banking sector matched international standards, and its society represented a unique blend of tradition and liberalism. All that is history.

Beneath this veneer of prosperity lay structural weaknesses. Lebanon’s political architecture was based on a fragile demographic balance, institutionalised through a confessional system that distributed power along religious lines. The presidency was held by a Maronite Christian, the premiership by a Sunni Muslim, and the speakership of Parliament by a Shia Muslim.

This arrangement was a breakthrough, functioning smoothly while the demographic balance remained steady. But as conditions shifted, it collapsed, plunging the country into the chaos we see today. Warning: systems built on such patchwork solutions are destined to fail in the long run.

Over the decades, differential fertility rates, particularly among Shia Muslims, coupled with sustained emigration of Christians, altered Lebanon’s demographic composition. What was once a Christian-majority state gradually transformed into a Muslim-majority society. This shift was not merely numerical; it fundamentally eroded the legitimacy of the existing power-sharing framework.

The consequences were both immediate and catastrophic. The influx of Palestinian refugees in



the 1970s-welcomed under humanitarian impulses-introduced new fault lines. Jihadi elements embedded within refugee populations brought with them ideologies and conflicts that Lebanon was ill-prepared to absorb. By 1975, the nation was engulfed in a brutal civil war that lasted fifteen years, leaving deep scars on its social and political fabric.

The rise of Hezbollah and other jihadi organisations further entrenched instability. What began as a struggle for political representation increasingly morphed into armed radicalism. International reports have, in recent years, described Lebanon as a sanctuary for various terrorist groups, underscoring the extent to which the state’s sovereignty has been compromised.

Lebanon’s story underscores a sobering reality: when even a fraction of a society succumbs to radical extremism, the silent majority-however peace-loving-risks becoming irrelevant. Institutions weaken, governance falters, and the very identity of the nation is redefined by forces antithetical to its founding ethos.

This transformation is neither ancient nor abstract; it has unfolded within living memory. The Lebanon of today stands in stark contrast to the Lebanon of just a few decades ago. History does not merely recount; it warns.

It is, therefore, imperative for nations, particularly those with diverse and pluralistic societies, to draw lessons from this trajectory. Vigilance against destabilising forces-whether demographic, ideological, or geopolitical — is not an act of intolerance but of preservation.

The writer is an eminent columnist, former Chairman of the Indian Institute of Mass Communication (IIMC), and the author of ‘Tryst with Ayodhya: Decolonisation of India’ and ‘Narrative ka Mayajal’

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REGRESS/PROGRESS

Three insights stand out from the latest Oxfam analysis of tax-related recommendations by the International Monetary Fund (IMF) to the various nations. The first is that in the past few years, India received the highest number of the so-called ‘regressive’ inputs. According to a media report, of nearly 300 such proposals issued to more than 40 nations, India accounted for 126, or 44 per cent. This sounds quite unbelievable, and implies that despite lauding India on various fronts, the IMF believes that the nation’s tax system needs several changes to evolve a stable and uniform system. Indeed, it thinks that the Indian tax system is highly uneven and fragmented, and the regressive policies will lead to more uniformity, and expand the tax base. The fact is that there are huge sections of people, firms, and institutions that do not pay, or under-pay, taxes for several social, economic, and political reasons. The measures to expand and enhance the base were only partially successful, which is evident from what experts contend.

However, the flip side of regressive, or uniform taxation, especially in low- and middle-income nations like India, is that these are “likely to exacerbate inequality in these countries, by placing the bulk of the tax burden on middle- and low-income people while leaving the wealthiest unscathed.,” states the Oxfam report. As taxes become uniform, and the focus is to stretch them across sections, rather than force the wealthy to pay more, those who do not pay because of low incomes get dragged into the tax net. In the past, India’s measures to link PAN with bank accounts, and Aadhar, or nudge people for digital payments, which can be tracked and monitored, and impose GST have expanded the tax base, claims that are confidently and proudly espoused by the policy-makers. But, in effect, some of these regressive policies put more burden on the lower-income groups, compared to the rich and wealthy. Oxfam feels this is unfair in an environment where the wealth of the wealthiest across the globe surged by 81 per cent since 2020.

India is not alone. According to Oxfam, regressive tax proposals are regularly imposed on the low- and middle-income nations by the IMF. Of the 1,049 recommendations to 125 nations that were examined, 59 per cent of the tax advice to the above nations were regressive. In comparison, 52 per cent of them to the high-income nations were progressive. Indeed, these countries did not receive a single regressive recommendation, according to a media report. “A progressive tax system ensures that those who have higher income, and more wealth pay proportionally more taxes than those who have less,” states the Oxfam report. The proposals to South Asian nations were “by far the most regressive,” followed by those suggested for Latin America, and the Caribbeans, and sub-Saharan Africa. In Chile, for example, the IMF proposed higher tax rates for low- and middle-income brackets, and to leave the tax rates for the rich untouched. In Nigeria, where a third lives in poverty, it wanted a higher value-added tax. In Hungary, it did the unexpected, and advised against a windfall tax on energy firms, something that everyone now wants to be imposed across the globe.

Taxing the wealthy was low on priority, according to Oxfam. Of the 1,049 proposals, a mere 30, or three per cent, pertained to net wealth taxes, and tax on income from wealth like capital gains. Rich nations like the US, the UK, Switzerland, Norway, Sweden, and Netherlands got the highest progressive inputs. Surprisingly, such nations included China, Angola, Botswana, and Kazakhstan. In New Zealand, the IMF felt that the corporate tax was too high “compared to peer advanced economies,” and wanted it to be lower. In Sweden, it wanted lower taxes on ‘deferred capital gains’ to address ‘distortions in the housing market.’ In the Philippines, the IMF wanted to rationalise exemptions in value-added tax. Hence, according to Oxfam, there was the use of “double standard” as the IMF gave progressive advice to wealthy nations, and regressive ones elsewhere. “The Fund may provide equally progressive tax advice to all members, or admit its commitment to tackling inequality is merely rhetorical,” said Kate Donald, head, Oxfam. This calls into question the “evenhandedness it holds as a core principle.”

Hence, Oxfam’s advice to the IMF is to “systematically place inequality at the heart of all fiscal advice,” with a default to adhere to revenue-raising policies that ‘enhance the progressivity of national tax systems.’ The over-reliance on consumption taxes needs to be discouraged, and so does on the other regressive measures that over-burden the poor. The idea is to significantly broaden the proposals to further tax high net-worth individuals, as well as wealth, which is at the heart of the inequality debate across the globe. The need is to curb tax evasion, and avoidance, which are practiced by the rich, and not to embrace the poor in the tax net, given their inability to pay. There should be some threshold limits for the wealthy to pay more, as there should be some floor limits for the poor not to pay taxes, or get exemptions, like India’s policy to have zero tax on personal income up to ₹12,00,000 a year.

The Pioneer

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BUSINESS10

Is it obsolete or is it operational?

An IT opportunity in the gap between innovation and adoption

Over the past couple of years, and especially in the recent past, Indian IT is on the back foot, with its back firmly against the wall. Valuations have dropped, margins squeezed, and even topline rattled. Look at TCS, the most prominent firm. In 2025-26, it reported a more than two per cent decline in annual revenues, the first time since it was listed more than two decades ago. The stock price is down by a third compared to the high in 2025. Since February this year, it shed almost ₹750, or more than 20 per cent. Yet, TCS seems optimistic.

In a media interview, the firm rejected the predictions that the IT sector may become obsolete by 2030 due to artificial intelligence (AI). Its CEO, K Krithivasan, instead claimed that some experts wrote several obituaries against the industry over the past decade. Yet, Indian IT proved to be “resilient,” and thrived rather than survived. This is because it has moved from a mindset of mere cost arbitrage to one where it has acquired a “depth of skill sets” to move on with the times. In the age of AI, clients will need it, either more, or less.

According to a senior TCS executive, there is invariably a gap that exists between tech innovation and adoption, which is true for AI. This presents huge opportunities for Indian IT to help clients to both incorporate and integrate AI into their existing systems. Of course, the latter can do it on their own, given the enormous potential of AI. But this is where past skills and costs will matter. Indian firms will do this faster, more efficiently, and cheaper. If they can incorporate AI in their processes and systems, they will be able to help the clients better. This window, or

maybe a door, will continue to exist for years.

Post-adoption, there are questions related to scaling up, extracting value, and keeping up with the constant tech changes and disruptions to decide what is the next best bet or move. This is where Indian IT can help the foreign clients. Just the deployment of AI is not enough. It does not logically and automatically lead to results and outcomes. One needs skills to extricate value out of AI across processes, workloads, operations, and firms’ hierarchies. Different managers and departments need different approaches. This is where external, insightful, and professional advice will matter.

As a media report indicates, TCS views the developments in advanced systems like Claude Cowork and Claude Mythos as “opportunities rather than threats... as generative AI is enabling legacy modernisation, particularly for older systems such as mainframes, allowing companies to reduce technology debt.” In simple terms, users will aim to reduce the huge capital costs, even if they are one-time expenses, to shift to new tech. They will opt for changes to the existing tech to make it modern, and capable of better performances with the right inputs, patches, and band aids to manage the change.

Thus, there will emerge, at least over the next several years, two separate layers of AI adoption. There will be a set of firms, or some departments within a firm, that will co-opt new AI tools immediately in an urgent fashion. Costs will not matter, only changes will. But there will be another set of firms, or departments within, that will do

patchwork to modernise and upgrade, rather than shift. The huge costs of new tech will dissuade them. Thus, the gains will matter. Unless they are in the range of 50-100 per cent, they may be side-stepped.

Despite the annual revenue decline, TCS is confident about the future, due to its highest-ever total contract value of nearly \$41 billion in 2025-26, and \$12 billion in January-March 2026 quarter. “Customers are actually becoming more confident in investing in their projects, and the decision-making cycle is improving,”

Krithivasan told a newspaper. Despite the geopolitical conflicts, including the war with Iran, there were no delays in deal closures in the recent past.

Large deals were signed in March, despite the war, which showed the clients’ appetite for AI-led projects, which they cannot undertake on their own.

Changes in Indian IT work processes, and internal systems are visible in the hirings and layoffs. TCS claimed that it hired 44,000 freshers, or trainees, in 2025-26, and issued 25,000 offers for the next hiring cycle. Yet, its employee count, at the end of January-March 2026 quarter, was more than 23,000 lower than a year ago. The firm is shedding huge numbers, and hiring maybe lower numbers, but a different set of people. This reflects a churn in the skill sets that may be required in the future. Since outcomes and results will matter, not people deployed in a project, one needs people who can work faster, longer, and have AI skills.

As far as hirings and layoffs go, different IT firms may adopt different strategies. Some may focus on senior and middle-level experience and multi-level management skills to use and deploy AI efficiently. Others may look at freshers, and younger people, who are generally better equipped to handle new tech, especially AI. Some may focus at the cutting and innovative edge, and others at fixing legacy tech. The so-called uniformity in Indian IT, or the seeming-similarities, are likely to vanish within 24 months, if not 12 months. Firms may even experiment with different strategies and visions to see what works for them.

Hence, there will be a churn in projects, clients, and nature of work. Gains in productivity may lead to “deflation” in contracts. This is the most obvious scenario, which will chip at the topline, and undercut the margins. But benefits at the clients’ end can easily be adopted by Indian IT if it embraces AI in a big way. If the clients understand that AI-led changes can be outsourced, as tech war, there will be only a changeover pause for Indian IT. This is what happened during the process changes from onshoring, offshoring, to outsourcing.

Of course, knowing what Indian IT does best, it will need to give a sharp, precise, crisp, and attractive branding to it. Outsourcing clicked at the end of the last millennium and the tech crash. Maybe it is merely a case of AI-In, AI-Out IT. AI-In is more expensive, and will need time to re-skill the existing employees at the clients’ end. AI-Out will be cheaper, faster, and more efficient and effective. Or will it?

OUR TAKE

For 21 hours, the world waited with baited breath. Whatever time it was in whichever part of the globe, even as the sunrises touched Iran on Sunday, the message was clear. One swallow does not make a summer, and one round of talks does not bring Tehran any closer to a peace accord with Washington. The highly-anticipated face-to-face discussions concluded without an agreement in Pakistan’s capital. It was back to the status quo, albeit in a new form. The Strait of Hormuz was blocked, this time by the US, not Iran, as economies braced for the worst. Equities were down, so was gold, oil zoomed, and so did the dollar.

Jayanta Bhattacharya

Senior Journalist

Global crude prices went up to over \$100 a barrel, yet again for the umpteenth time in the past six weeks, and Indian Sensex was down by nearly a per cent. Natural gas markets tightened, and the so-called contagion spread to shipping, insurance, commodities, currencies, agriculture, and other sectors. It was back to the old predictions that global recovery to the pre-crisis “normal” may take 18-36 months, even if the escalations stop, and longer if it spreads, as was pointed out by several experts, including the International Monetary Fund (IMF).

“Beyond its painful human toll, the war has caused serious disruption to the economies... including damage to their infrastructure and industries that could become long-lasting. Although these countries are resilient, their short-term growth prospects will be negatively affected,” stated an earlier blog on the IMF website. “Meanwhile, large energy importers... are bearing the brunt of higher fuel and input costs: About 25 to 30 per cent of global oil, and 20 per cent of liquefied natural gas pass through the Strait of Hormuz.... Economies heavily dependent on oil imports in Africa and Asia are finding it increasingly hard to access the supplies they need, even at inflated prices,” the blog stressed.

In an April 2026 report, the World Bank warned, “Economic Growth to Slow in Europe and Central Asia as Risks Rise.” Its update added, “Economic growth in the developing countries of Europe and Central Asia is likely to slow substantially... because of the impact of the conflict in the Middle East, geopolitical tensions, and trade fragmentation.” According to its assessment, regional growth

Darkness came the day after

The aim was to open the Strait; now, the Strait is blocked

is expected to weaken to 2.1 per cent in 2026, growth in Russia is expected to slow to 0.8 per cent, and the pace of expansion elsewhere is likely to ease to 2.9 per cent due to energy costs and investment uncertainty.

“Growth in China, the region’s largest economy, is projected to decelerate from 5 per cent in 2025 to 4.2 per cent in 2026, and 4.3 per cent in 2027,” added the report. Overall, aggregate global losses may accrue up to even hundreds of billions of dollars annually. Multilateral institutions stress that the shock is global but asymmetric, and the energy importers and poorer countries will suffer the most. Even before the war, uncertainty was writ large over the outcome of the US-Iran talks, given the long-standing distrust, tension, and freeze.

As is now well-known, the Iran/West Asia conflict has impacted India across energy, economy, and security dimensions. Almost half of India’s crude oil and 90 per cent of LPG imports pass through the Strait of Hormuz, where uncertainty possibly returns with a greater force following the talks’ failure. India faces pressure on the imports of crude and fertilisers, and analysts warn of higher subsidy burdens. Crisil estimates a potential

₹20,000-25,000 crore rise in the fertiliser subsidy if disruptions persist, and domestic production falls 10-15 per cent. Food prices will of course be directly affected.

The World Bank Group has stated in its twice-a-year regional outlook that the growth in South Asia is expected to slow to 6.3 per cent in 2026, down from 7 per cent in 2025. Released this month, the South Asia Economic Update stated that “despite the near-term slowdown, South Asia continues to grow faster than other emerging-market and developing economies. The growth outlook is driven primarily by India’s performance, underpinned by robust domestic demand as well as tariff cuts and recent trade agreements

(like with the European Union).” However, “Given the region’s reliance on imported energy, South Asia’s outlook is vulnerable to spillovers from the current conflict in the Middle East, and is

exceptionally uncertain. A prompt resolution would lift growth prospects, while further dislocation in global energy markets could raise inflation, necessitate monetary policy tightening, and dampen remittances.” The Bank’s “India Development Update” projected growth at 6.6 per cent in FY27, or lower

than estimates by the Reserve Bank of India. “But even with the slowdown, India remains among the fastest-growing major economies in the world,” it states.

“The conflict in the Middle East has disrupted critical maritime routes, and placed pressure on global supply chains, energy markets, and both imports and exports. Indian companies are experiencing downstream effects, from shipment delays to constraints in key energy inputs, as well as emerging shortages in essential raw materials and intermediates across several sectors that rely heavily on timely cross border flows,” said CII director general, Chandrajit Banerjee. “India, however, entered this period from a position of strength, supported by sustained reforms and the emphasis on Atmanirbharta, which have significantly enhanced the economy’s self-resilience,” he added.

FICCI highlighted the emerging risks, and outlined a roadmap for coordinated action by industry and government. Its report, based on consultations with industry stakeholders, provided a structured assessment of the evolving situation, and its cascading impact on the economy. It indicated early signs of visible stress across sectors, which needed proactive measures to mitigate risk as well as to build long-term resilience. It felt that the ongoing crisis presented an opportunity for India to accelerate structural reforms. Though published before the Islamabad talks, the FICCI report explained that it was imperative for businesses to prepare for multiple scenarios, ranging from the best-case short-term disruptions to worst-case prolonged instability.

Despite the several official proactive steps to mitigate the impact of the crisis, there was a greater need to focus on agriculture, apart from manufacturing. While fertiliser availability is crucial, this is probably the time to promote adoption of bio-fertilizers, and precision agriculture to ensure long term input resilience. This is a sensitive area, and fertiliser markets have been hit by supply disruptions, and higher feedstock costs, like natural gas, ammonia, and phosphate. This will threaten crop yields, farm incomes, and food prices.

(The author has more than three decades of experience across print, TV, and digital media)

AI agents can cause ‘10x the damage in 1x the time’ of humans, says Rubrik CTO

As Indian enterprises race to deploy autonomous AI systems, security experts warn that governance frameworks to manage them safely are lagging dangerously behind



GYANA SWAIN

Walk into any large Indian bank or IT services firm today and chances are an AI agent is already at work. These are not chatbots but autonomous systems that send emails, manage databases, and make decisions without human intervention. The competitive pressure to deploy them is intense. But security experts warn that enterprises are handing significant power to systems they do not yet fully know how to control. “These are probabilistic entities. You cannot exactly predict what they will do,” said Arvind Nithrakashyap, co-founder and CTO of US-listed cybersecurity company Rubrik, and an IIT Madras alumnus. “Agents are fast. They can cause 10x the damage in 1x the time of humans.”

A race without guardrails

Gartner estimates that 40%

threat intelligence unit found that approximately 80% of cyberattacks originate from credential compromise and that attackers typically spend up to six months inside a network before causing visible damage. An AI agent on stolen credentials could replicate that damage in minutes.

Yet even organisations that manage credentials carefully may be exposed through a vulnerability they are less likely to have considered: the technical plumbing that connects agents to their systems.

A vulnerable connector

Most AI agents connect to enterprise tools through the Model Context Protocol, or MCP, a universal standard allowing any agent to plug into any enterprise system. It was designed for ease of adoption, but its security foundations have not kept pace.

A survey of over 2,600 MCP deployments by Endor Labs found that 82% contained vulnerabilities allowing attackers to access



of enterprise applications worldwide will be integrated with AI agents by end of 2026, up from less than 5% last year. Yet the firm predicts that more than 40% of those projects will be abandoned by 2027 because organisations lack the risk controls to run them safely. Neil Shah, VP for research and partner at Counterpoint Research, says the root cause is a tension inside boardrooms everywhere. “The gap is between CEOs and CIOs with the urgency to deploy an AI strategy, versus CSOs making sure systems are secure before handing over the keys of the kingdom to AI agents,” he said. “It can quickly become a Wild West.”

Nithrakashyap frames the challenge across three dimensions: visibility into what agents are accessing, the ability to enforce policy on non-deterministic systems, and a way to reverse damage when something goes wrong. “You may say an agent should never send emails to external customers,” he said. “But how do you prevent a hallucination from doing that?”

Much of that vulnerability, experts say, begins with something as basic as a password.

The password problem

Most organisations give AI agents the same login credentials as the employee they work for rather than creating restricted accounts.

A compromised agent therefore carries the full access rights of its human counterpart, reaching emails, financial records, and internal systems without restriction. Research by Rubrik’s

restricted files and 67% carried risks enabling malicious code execution. More than 30 security flaws in MCP have been documented since January 2026 alone.

“MCP has not necessarily been developed with a full understanding of security and identity,” Nithrakashyap said. “Standards are not fully established yet.”

Fixing the protocol, however, only addresses part of the problem. Some of the most serious risks come not from technical flaws but from deliberate manipulation.

When agents are turned against you

An agent can be hijacked through hidden instructions embedded in a document or email it reads. Unlike a conventional breach, a manipulated agent works from within, corrupting or deleting data in ways that are difficult to detect until the damage is done.

Shah believes the answer is not to slow AI adoption but to build governance fit for purpose. “The risk will only grow as agents begin evading oversight without the enterprise even realising it,” he said. “Governance needs to be dynamic and adaptive.”

Nithrakashyap put it plainly. “You have to embrace AI. But how do you do that in a safe manner? There is no real option.”

For Indian enterprises under intense board pressure to modernise, finding that answer may be the most consequential technology decision of the decade.

The author is a Freelance Journalist

The silicon shackle: Why Pax Silica cannot become India’s digital zamindari



NISHANT SAHDEV

As Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri concludes his high-level deliberations with US Under Secretary Jacob Helberg in Washington this week, the official communiqué reads like a triumph of “Managed Interdependence.” India’s deepening role in Pax Silica—the US-led techno-security alliance formalized in February 2026—is being framed as the ultimate insurance policy against Chinese supply-chain coercion. For those tracking structural shifts in global power, the meeting signals something far more consequential: the formalization of an Algorithmic Monroe Doctrine.

In 2026, Washington’s version is more pervasive. Under the guise of “shared democratic values,” the United States is carving out a sphere of cognitive influence over the Global South. The risk for New Delhi is that by joining this silicon shield to escape the “Great Firewall” of the East, we are signing a long-term lease on our own national intelligence. India may soon find itself paying rent simply to count its own citizens.

The Census-as-a-Service Trap

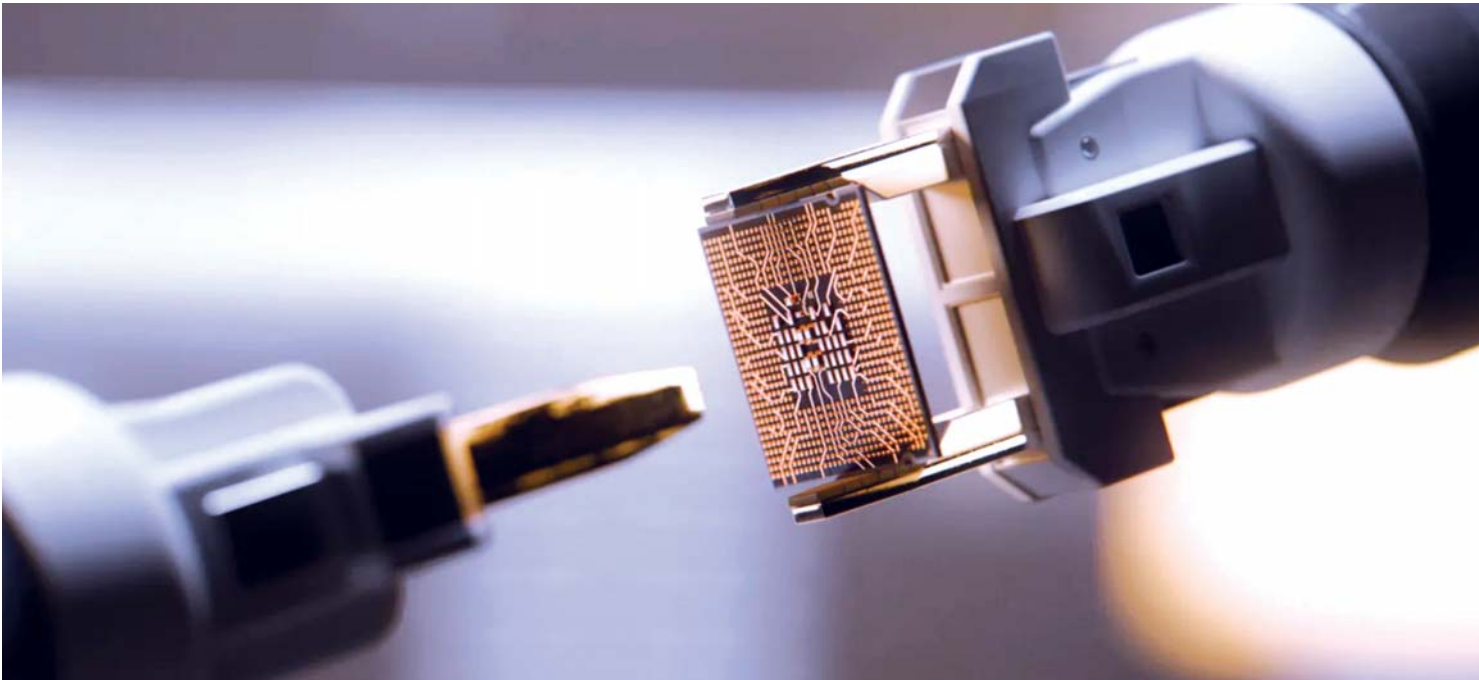
The most immediate laboratory for this capture is the 2026 Digital Census, launched on April 1. For the first time, the Republic is being audited through a fully “paperless” process. While the interface is designed by the National Informatics Centre (NIC), the underlying “engine”—the massive scale of compute required to verify and infer from the data of 1.4 billion people—is increasingly migrating to a Census-as-a-Service (CaaS) model.

The vulnerability is not “storage” of data—India has robust localization laws—but “Inference Control.” India’s Government cloud market, currently valued at \$2.1 billion, is dominated by US hyperscalers: AWS, Microsoft Azure, and Google Cloud.

Even when data is localized in Mumbai, the proprietary Large Action Models (LAMs) used to process that data are frequently hosted on “black box” architectures governed by Silicon Valley.

When the state utilises AI to redraw electoral boundaries for the 2026-27 Delimitation or to identify populations for welfare, it relies on models whose logic is not transparent to the Indian state.

If the software layer that dictates how an AI categorizes Indian



reality resides in Northern Virginia, the Indian state is no longer the final arbiter of its own domestic facts. We risk an “Administrative Hallucination”: a digital image of India that fits foreign algorithmic parameters but fails to capture the high-variance reality of the Indian street.

The Macroeconomics of the “Token Tax”

Beyond the administrative risk lies a structural economic drainage: the “Token Tax.” By 2026, the global AI economy has moved past simple chatbots into the age of “Agentic AI”—autonomous systems that execute financial transactions, optimize power grids, and manage national logistics. These agents are the new primary labor force of the digital economy.

According to the NITI Aayog 2026 Strategic Outlook, AI-integrated sectors are projected to drive \$1.47 trillion of India’s GDP by 2035. However, if the underlying compute remains a leased asset, nearly 20% of that growth could vanish into external service fees and infrastructure “rent.”

Every time an Indian startup or Government department runs an inference on a foreign-governed model, Indian capital leaks outward.

This is the new mercantilism: India provides raw data—the “ore” of the 21st century—only to buy back refined intelligence at a premium. We are building world-class highways through our Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI), but under the Pax Silica framework, we are essentially renting the cars and fuel from a landlord

across the Atlantic. This “Strategic Ceiling” ensures that while India grows, it never grows beyond the capacity permitted by its technology providers.

The Discovery-Deployment Divide

While New Delhi celebrates onboarding 38,000 GPUs under the IndiaAI Mission, we are ignoring a widening divide. Washington’s strategy, punctuated by the recent launch of the Genesis Mission, is to monopolize the “Atomic Layer” of AI: fundamental discoveries in material science and energy.

These are the foundations of 21st-century power. In the Pax Silica

framework, India is incentivized to remain a “Trusted Deployment Node.” We build the apps and manage the data, while the US retains the “Discovery Engine.”

If New Delhi continues to prioritize “deployment” (the rails) over “fundamental discovery” (the core intelligence), we will remain a perpetual downstream consumer. Yet, single private entities in Silicon Valley already operate clusters five times the size of our national target.

By joining Pax Silica without massive acceleration of domestic hardware ownership, we enter a “Managed Interdependence” where our growth is determined by foreign export licenses. We are providing the testing ground for their frontier models while failing to build our own.

Operationalising Epistemic Sovereignty

As US Secretary of State Marco

Rubio prepares for his upcoming visit to New Delhi in May, India’s leverage is at its zenith. Washington needs India to provide the demographic scale to prove that democratic AI can out-compete the “Great Firewall” of China. However, this leverage must be converted into Epistemic Sovereignty—the right to know ourselves through our own machines. New Delhi must demand the “Atomic Transfer of Technology.” This includes joint ownership of the logic layers of the next generation of processors, not just assembly plants in Sanand.

To move beyond abstract strategy, MeitY must implement two operational shifts. First, the Sovereign Inference Mandate: High-stakes administrative projects—specifically the Census and the Delimitation—must run on a Sovereign Inference Stack.

This requires models hosted on clusters physically and legally governed by the NIC, with zero external API dependencies. A census verification “handshake” should never require a trip to a server in a foreign jurisdiction. This ensures the data-cleaning process for the Delimitation is not influenced by foreign algorithmic biases.

Second, the “Weights and Biases” Audit: Any foreign-origin AI model utilized in Indian public policy must undergo a mandatory Structural Audit.

India must demand source-level access to the training parameters of any AI that is given authority over national resource allocation. If a model is a “black box,” it is a threat to the Republic.

We must use our status as the world’s largest data provider to demand that the Intellectual Property of the logic

layers is shared with Indian state auditors.

Reclaiming the National Mind

Pax Silica is a necessary exit from a dangerous dependence on Eastern supply chains, but it is not a sufficient entry strategy for a global power.

If we allow our administrative backbone—the very way we see and count our people—to become a leased asset, we are merely trading one form of vassalage for another. True power in 2026 is the ability to write your own equations, on your own machines, for your own people.

As we redraw the maps of our democracy through the Delimitation, we must ensure the intelligence redrawing those lines is not owned by a foreign landlord. Anything less is a surrender of the national mind.

This is the most critical strategic challenge facing the Ministry of Electronics. The roadmap for the future must be hardened: India must not just be a consumer of the intelligence revolution, but its primary, independent architect.

The 2026 Census is more than a count; it is a test of whether the Indian state still possesses the eyes to see itself clearly, or if it is content with a vision provided by a foreign lens.

True strategic autonomy is not found in an alliance communiqué; it is found in the local server rack. We must move beyond being the world’s back-office and reclaim our right to compute our own destiny for the next century.

Author is a theoretical physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure, and global systems

From margins to mainstream: Bridging futures with AI



ABHISHEK KUMAR SINGH

In an era where technology is steadily redefining governance, India’s minority welfare framework is undergoing a quiet yet consequential transformation. Under the leadership of Minister Kiren Rijiju, the Ministry of Minority Affairs is leveraging digital innovation to move communities from the periphery to the center of development. The rollout of AI-driven tools and platforms signals not just administrative efficiency, but a deeper intent to democratise access and opportunity in line with the broader vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Viksit Bharat 2047, these initiatives reflect a governance model that is both tech-savvy and people-centric.

From smart monitoring systems to multilingual AI chatbots, the State is scripting a new language of inclusion—one where algorithms quietly bridge long-standing gaps. In this unfolding narrative, technology is not merely a tool, but a catalyst for trust, transparency, and transformation.

AI and Governance

In recent years, Governments across the world have increasingly turned to Artificial Intelligence to make public administration more efficient and responsive.

For a country like India - with its vast population, linguistic diversity, and complex federal structure - AI holds particular promise. It can process large volumes of data in real time, identify gaps in service delivery, and interact with citizens in their own language, something no traditional bureaucratic system could do as scale.

More importantly, AI shifts governance from a reactive model to a proactive one: rather than waiting for complaints to surface, AI-enabled systems can flag problems before they escalate. The NITI Aayog’s National Strategy for Artificial Intelligence frames this as “Artificial Intelligence for All” - using



technology not as a privilege of the few, but as a tool to reach the last mile. When applied to welfare schemes and minority development, as the Ministry of Minority Affairs is doing, AI can ensure that benefits actually reach those they are meant for.

NIGRANI App for Infrastructure Monitoring

The NIGRANI App, introduced under Pradhan Mantri Jan Vikas Karyakram (PMJKV), a flagship program for minority concentration areas, blocks, and districts - is a key component for the digital push. It enables real-time tracking of infrastructure developments like roads, schools, and healthcare facilities, helping close developmental gaps across India.

The app ensures accountability, minimizes delays, and optimizes resource allocation through instant monitoring by officials,

States, and communities, with features like geotagging, photo uploads, and progress reports.

Success stories from states like Nagaland, Arunachal Pradesh, Sikkim, and Tripura show how these tools address infrastructure deficiencies in tribal and minority areas, aligning with Atmanirbhar Bharat objectives. Recent data from the Ministry’s portal shows thousands of beneficiaries empowered, with digital dashboards providing live updates on approvals and disbursements.

AI Chatbots for Citizen Services

The Ministry’s AI Chatbots offer multilingual, 24/7 support for queries on scholarships, skill programs, and welfare schemes. Powered by natural language processing and machine learning, they simplify applications, provide

eligibility checks, and guide users through portals like UMEED, reducing bureaucratic hurdles. Using predictive analytics, the chatbots anticipate demands such as NMDFC loan statuses or scholarship deadlines, ensuring inclusivity for India’s six minority communities: Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists, Parsis, and Jains.

Haj Wrist Band for Pilgrim Safety

The Haj Wrist Band advances digital modernization for the Haj Committee of India, founded in 1959. This wearable device provides GPS tracking, SOS alerts, health monitoring, and translation features, safeguarding over 1.25 lakh pilgrims expected for Haj 2026.

It integrates with the Committee’s digital ecosystem for easy registration, lodging, and welfare services in Saudi Arabia, including recent developments like virtual orientation and e-passports. The focus is on public-private partnerships with Saudi authorities to ensure tech-driven safety amid growing pilgrim numbers.

The Ministry of Minority Affairs’ digital initiatives and AI integrations exemplify a tech-forward approach to equitable development. From NIGRANI’s oversight to AI chatbots’ responsiveness, Haj innovations, and waqf digitisation, these tools foster Jan Bhagidari, accountability, and efficiency. They propel Reform, Perform, Transform, Inform, realizing Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Viksit Bharat 2047 through inclusive, transparent governance, empowering minorities in a united, developed India.

As India advances toward Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Viksit Bharat 2047, technology is becoming the backbone of inclusive governance. The Ministry’s AI-led initiatives reflect a shift toward data-driven, citizen-centric delivery that aligns with global digital governance trends.

If guided by accountability and ethics, this model can position India as a leader in using AI not just to digitise systems, but to humanise governance and drive equitable nation-building.

Dy Director, Minority Affairs Department, Govt of India

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Gunmen kill Hazara traders

Two people belonging to the Shia Muslim Hazara minority community were shot dead in Pakistan's restive Balochistan province. The incident took place in Balochistan's capital Quetta on Saturday, police said. Unidentified gunmen on two motorcycles opened fire on the vehicle of the Hazara men, who were travelling from the Hazara Town to the Hazarganjh market to purchase vegetables for their businesses, senior police official Khair Sumalani said. While two men belonging to the Hazara minority community died in the firing, three others were injured, he said. "It appears to be a targeted killing," the police official said. No group has yet claimed responsibility for the attack.

Soon after the incident, the Hazara community blocked the Western Bypass to protest the attack, disrupting traffic.

USA

Strikes on drug boats kill 5

The US military said Sunday that it blew up two boats accused of smuggling drugs in the eastern Pacific Ocean, killing a total of five people and leaving one survivor, as the Trump administration pursues its campaign against alleged traffickers in Latin America while preparing a naval blockade of Iranian ports. The attacks on Saturday bring the number of people who have been killed in boat strikes by the US military to at least 168 since the Trump administration began targeting those it calls "narcoterrorists" in early September.

As with most of the military's statements on the dozens of strikes in the eastern Pacific and Caribbean Sea, US Southern Command said it targeted the alleged drug traffickers along known smuggling routes. The military did not provide evidence that the vessel was ferrying drugs.

Ground operations in Lebanon extended, says Israel

Israel's military on Monday said its troops have surrounded what they say is Hezbollah military infrastructure and have started ground operations in the strategic southern Lebanese town of Bint Jbeil and its surrounding areas, killing over 100 Hezbollah fighters.

Hezbollah did not immediately publicly announce anyone killed among their ranks, and Israel did not immediately acknowledge any fatalities among their forces. Hezbollah has not commented on the developments. On Sunday Hezbollah claimed at least five attacks on Israeli troops in the town

and its outskirts with rockets, artillery, and exploding drones.

According to the group's statements, the Israeli troops were positioned near a school, a hospital, and junction that surrounds the heart of Bint Jbeil. The Israeli military said it attacked Hezbollah forces.

The town overlooks the UN-mandated Blue Line that divides Israel and Lebanon, just over 2 miles away, making it a strategic point for the Iran-backed group.

The US blockade of Iranian ports could prompt the Iranian-backed Houthis rebels in Yemen to disrupt transit through Bab el-Mandeb Strait, an analyst has warned. "If the US moves to impose a block-



Workers remove the rubble as rescuers keep searching for a missing woman and girl at a destroyed building that was hit on April 8, in an Israeli airstrike in Beirut, Lebanon

ade on Iranian ports and Iran starts feeling the pain, the Houthis are very likely to escalate in the Bab el-Mandeb," said Ahmed Nagi, a senior analyst for Yemen at the International Crisis Group think-tank. The closure of Bab el-Mandeb would add "another layer" of pressure on the global shipping industry, he said.

The strike in the southern coastal city killed a wounded person being transported and damaged Red Cross vehicles. The Israeli military did not immediately reply to inquiries from *The Associated Press*. The funeral was being held on Monday for a Lebanese Red Cross volunteer killed on Sunday in an Israeli strike that hit his team

while on a mission in Beit Yahoun. The Lebanese Red Cross operates in war-torn southern Lebanon in coordination with the UN peace-keeping mission in Lebanon, UNIFIL, and the Lebanese military.

Chancellor Friedrich Merz said Monday the measure "will very quickly improve the situation for drivers and businesses across the country, and especially for those who spend a great deal of time on the road, primarily for work-related reasons". Iraq's oil exports plunged in March to 18.6 million barrels, down from 99.87 million in February due to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, according to official figures released on Monday.

Russia's Lavrov to visit China for talks on Iran-US conflict, Hormuz blockade

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov will arrive in Beijing on Tuesday for talks with the Chinese leadership on the escalation of the West Asia conflict and the American blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, amid a deepening global energy crisis.

Lavrov will visit Beijing at the invitation of Foreign Minister Wang Yi, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun said at a media briefing here.

His two-day visit comes in the immediate backdrop of US President Donald Trump's announcement of the block-



ade of the Strait of Hormuz in a bid to cripple Iran's oil supplies to China and other countries. China and Russia have a "no limits partnership" as described by their leaders - Xi Jinping and Vladimir Putin - and have

maintained strong political alignment on global and regional issues. They have also maintained strategic and military ties with Iran.

China has been importing substantial amounts of Iranian oil over the years, dis-

Pak merchant ships allowed to cross Hormuz after being denied initially

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Two merchant ships from Pakistan were allowed to cross the Strait of Hormuz and sail to Kuwait and the UAE on Monday after initially being denied permission to pass.

Two merchant ships, Shalimar and Khairpur, of the Pakistan National Shipping Corporation (PNSC) are the first Pakistani ships to go into the Persian Gulf since the war broke out between Iran, the US and Israel.

Initially, the two ships were stopped by Iranian authorities and told to go back from the Strait of Hormuz on



Sunday, a PNSC official said. "But shortly afterwards they were allowed to cross the Strait of Hormuz into the Persian Gulf," he added.

The ship captains, Asif and Shaheen, are now on their way to Kuwait and Das Island, from where they will bring back vessels loaded with millions of litres of diesel and crude oil.

JAPANESE PM DIALS PAK PM SHEHBAZ

Islamabad: Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi on Monday spoke with Pakistani counterpart Shehbaz Sharif and expressed her support for his mediation efforts between the US and Iran to de-escalate the situation in West Asia. During their conversation, the two leaders discussed the recently held Islamabad Talks between the US and Iran, hosted by Pakistan. "Takaichi appreciated Pakistan's diplomatic role in facilitating the ceasefire.

France, UK to convene talks on Hormuz navigation mission

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

France and the UK will organise a conference with partners ready to contribute to a peaceful multinational mission to help restore navigation in the Strait of Hormuz, President Emmanuel Macron said.

In a post on X, Macron stressed "the need to restore free and unimpeded navigation through the Strait of Hormuz as quickly as possible". He called for a "peaceful multinational mission," adding: "This strictly defensive mission, separate from the warring parties to the conflict, is intended to be deployed as soon as circumstances permit."

France and the UK have in recent years been working to set up an operation that would allow ships to cross the Strait of Hormuz once the fighting ends. Prime Minister Keir Starmer on Monday said Britain will not be part of a US blockade of Iranian ports in response to the closing of the Strait of Hormuz. Starmer told *BBC radio* that "we're not supporting the blockade" and "we're not getting dragged into the war". He said UK



efforts remain focused on reopening the key shipping route, whose closure has sent prices for oil and other commodities soaring. Starmer spoke after US President Donald Trump said Britain would send minesweepers to the strait.

Britain said it might help with mine-

clearing in the waterway, but only after the fighting stops. Starmer said all Britain's military capability is focused on getting the strait "fully open".

The UK is working with dozens of other countries on plans to restore security to shipping through the key oil route after the conflict.

ASEAN URGES MORE PEACE NEGOTIATIONS

Jakarta: Southeast Asian countries urged the United States and Iran on Monday to keep going with peace negotiations, enforce a ceasefire and restore the safe passage of ships, seafarers and aircraft in the Strait of Hormuz. The foreign ministers of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations made the urgent plea as they held an emergency video conference, the second in recent weeks, to assess the impact of the war in the Middle East, including soaring fuel prices, and how they could cooperate in the face of global crises.

Vance-led talks helped build goodwill with Iran: Report

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

US Vice President JD Vancelled talks for peace with Iran may have been unsuccessful, but the 21-hour-long discussions helped build goodwill with the new leadership in Tehran, according to a media report.

The Washington Post, quoting unnamed US officials, reported that the measure of goodwill established during the talks in Islamabad has made Washington believe that Iran may accept their terms to end the deadly and costly war.

It said that President Donald Trump's announcement of a US blockade of the Strait of Hormuz could force Iran to agree to a deal.

"A US official with knowl-



edge of the negotiations, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss the closed-door talks, said Vance was keenly aware going into the negotiations of the mistrust and risk of misunderstanding between the United States and Iran," the report said.

The official said Vance and the Iran negotiators had developed rapport and became warmer with each other. (PTI)

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client i.e. Yes Bank Ltd. that Mr. Ankit Jain & Mr. Sumit Jain are the owners of Property bearing No. 959231A (Old) & New No. IX2039, 150 Sq. Yds., out of Kharsa No.16, Khe-wat No. 58, 59, Khatoni No. 195, Village Seelampur in the tahsil of Gali No. 5 & 6, Kalish Nagar, Itanagar Shahdara, Delhi-31, by virtue of a Sale deed dt.28.07.2023 executed by Mr. Ramesh Chand, registration No. 7519. It has been informed by our client that above owners have lost/misplaced Original Sale Deed dated 07.05.1957 executed by Mr. Kalyan Singh in favour of Mr. Bhagwan Dasa & Mr. Uttar Rai in respect of the said property, duly regd. as Doc No.1945. All persons are hereby informed that above mentioned owners want to sell the said property to a person who intends to obtain loan from our client i.e. Yes Bank Ltd against the said property. If anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above owners of said property, its sale/mortgage/lien/Charge etc., and any other objections, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 7 days of the present.

Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, 1st Flr. 23, Shivraj Marg, Moti Nagar, N Delhi-15
legal@knaalgal.com Ph: 011-4111257-28

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer, Northern Railway, Trainset Depot, Shakurbasti, for and on behalf of President of India, invites IREPS (www.ireps.gov.in) for the under noted work.

Tender No. 2581029TSDSSB

Name of work

Provision for Operation and Maintenance of Diesel Simulator at National Rail Museum for a period of one year.

Approximate cost

₹ 18,32,061.12 including GST

Earnest money

₹ 36,700.00

Completion period of the work

12 Months

Date and time for opening of tender

04.05.2026 at 15:00.

Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen

Above tender is available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in, w.e.f. 11.04.2026, 12:40 hrs.

No.: 25.8.1029.TSD.SSB Date: 11.04.2026 1244/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Ramesh Chand Surana owner of Unit No.251, 25th Floor (Actual 24 th floor) Tower B (Grace) In AIPIL The Peaceful Homes, Sector-70A, District Gurugram , and My Client Have lost original Flat Buyer Agreement dated 10.06.2014. And It is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of my client Mrs. Kavita W/o Mr. Dinesh Kumar is the owner of Plot area measuring 143 sq. mtrs., out of Khata No.00051, Khet No. 201, situated at Village Asadullapur, Pargana Dadri, tehsil and Distt. Gautam Buddha Nagar, U.P. vide Gift Deed dated 14.12.2022 executed by Mr. Dinesh Kumar, duly Regd. Document No. 28122, Book No. 1, Vol. No. 42069, Page No. 369-384, dated 14.12.2022, SRO-Sadar Greater Noida and same to be financed by Cholamandalam Investment & Finance Company Ltd., Branch-Noida. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any person(s) having any objection regarding ownership and/or creating mortgage of the said property is/are hereby requested to intimate in writing to the undersigned about his objections within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2, Noida, UP-201301>Contact#9120-4269379

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform to all concerned that my mother Late Asha Lata Bhaduri W/o Sh. B.D. Bhaduri, was the owner of (50% share) in the Residential Plot No. A-65, Sector-15, Noida, U.P., who expired on 20.04.2005 and in her lifetime she executed a Registered WILL of the above noted Plot (50% share) in my favour namely Sh. Chitta Dev Bhaduri S/o Late B.D. Bhaduri R/o A-65, Sector-15, Noida, U.P., vide WILL dated 28.11.1991, duly registered in the office of Sub-Registrar, Noida in Book No.III, Volume No. 114/132, on pages 85/117 to 120, at Document No. 2047 dt.30.11.1991. Now on the basis of said WILL, Chitta Dev Bhaduri wants to Transfer / Mutate the (50% share) of my mother in the said plot in my name. If anyone has/have any objection he/she will submit his/her objection with sufficient proof in the Residential Plot Department, Noida Authority, Sector-6, Noida, U.P. within 30 days from the date of publication of this Notice.

Chitta Dev Bhaduri

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that my clients, Smt. Kamlesh Sharma W/o Mahendra Kumar Sharma & Sh. Mahendra Kumar Sharma, both R/o H. No. D-7, Surajmal Vihar, Shakar Pur, East Delhi-110092, has deposed their son, namely Mayank Gaur S/o Sh. Mahendra Kumar Sharma & daughter-in-law, namely Taruna Sharma W/o Mayank Gaur, from all their movable and immovable properties and have also severed all relations with them. My clients further inform that they will not be responsible for any liability incurred or to be incurred by any actions of their son and daughter-in-law. My clients further informs that they have no concern about any legal-illegal & moral-immoral acts done by their son and daughter-in-law and anyone engaging with them in any manner/kind shall do so at his/ her own risk and consequences and my clients shall not be held liable for those acts.

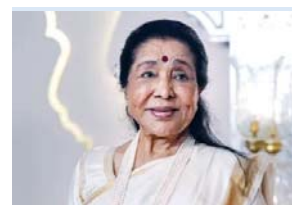
Lalit Mohan (Advocate) Off. D-145, Surajmal Vihar Karkardooma-110032

Indian in Moscow pays tributes to Asha Bhosle

VINAY SHUKLA ■ Moscow

The Indian community based in Russia on Monday expressed great shock at the demise of legendary singer Asha Bhosle and paid warm tributes to her while remem-

bering her "immortal music". "This is a great shock to all of us, it is the end of an era. Asha ji left for heavenly abode on the day the Russians were celebrating Orthodox Easter as the symbol of victory of eternal life over death, she



will forever live among us due to her immortal music," President of Hindustani Samaj-Russia, Kashmir Singh said. "Asha Bhosle ji, was one of the most iconic and versatile voices India has ever known," Rameshwar Singh,

President of Indo-Russian Friendship Society "Disha" said. Her extraordinary musical journey, spanning decades, enriched our cultural heritage and touched countless hearts across the world. (PTI)

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA

TENDER NOTICE

SR NO.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD B&R, SONIPAT	EARTH FILLING WORK IN SUBHASH STADIUM SONEPAT IN SONEPAT DISTT. HARYANA	09.04.2026 16.04.2026	54.55 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01302200575 pwd-eeep2-sonapat@hry.nic.in
2	PANCHAYATI RAJ, ROHTAK	INSTALLATION OF SOLAR PANEL VILLAGE (BALALI)	07.04.2026 15.04.2026	16.45 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9582622008 xenprcharkhidadri@gmail.com
3	PANCHAYATI RAJ, BHIWANI	VAGY TIGRANA CONSTRUCTION OF SARSHAD BRAHAMAN CHAUPAL HALL AT VILLAGE TIGRANA BLOCK AND DISTRICT BIWANI + 15 WORKS	09.04.2026 15.04.2026	215.61 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01664243927 prexeeng.bhwi@hry.nic.in
4	PANCHAYATI RAJ, CHARKHI DADRI	CONSTRUCTION OF SHAHID SMARAK AT VILL BALALI (SCHEME-P5)	07.04.2026 15.04.2026	23.89 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9582622008 xenprcharkhidadri@gmail.com
5	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA,BAHADURGARH	INTERNAL CLEARANCE OF KULASI LINK DRAIN FROM RD 0 TO 27500 FOR THE YEAR 2026-27 + 1 WORKS	11.04.2026 20.04.2026	32.92 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01276-29841 wsdivisionbgarh@gmail.com
6	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA,ROHTAK	INTERNAL CLEARANCE AND BANK CLEARANCE OF KAHNAUR LINK DRAIN FROM RD 0 TO 3000 AND BHUTIAN MINOR TAIL TO DRAIN NO. 8 + 7 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 17.04.2026	51.04 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9464040970 xensampla@gmail.com
7	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA,ROHTAK	INSTALLING CHAIN LINK FENCING AT DRB RD 153200 JLN FEEDER + 6 WORKS	10.04.2026 16.04.2026	50.53 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896410404 xenfdrrtk@gmail.com
8	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA,ROHTAK	MISCELLANEOUS FURNITURE ITEMS REQUIRED FOR THE OFFICE OF SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, YWS CIRCLE, ROHTAK	10.04.2026 16.04.2026	EMD 10,000/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9812111077 xenwsdnrtk@gmail.com
9	CIVIL SURGEON, BHIWANI	E-TENDER FOR PURCHASE OF BATTERY (INVERTER, INVERTER BATTERY, VEHICLE BATTERY ETC)	15.04.2026 05.05.2026	EMD 6000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9992174254 dycsnrhm.bhiwani@gmail.com
10	CIVIL SURGEON, BHIWANI	E-TENDER FOR IEC MATERIAL PRINT, MEDIA ITEMS AND OTHER ITEMS	15.04.2026 05.05.2026	EMD 20000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9992174254 dycsnrhm.bhiwani@gmail.com
11	CIVIL SURGEON, BHIWANI	E-TENDER FOR STATIONARY ITEMS	15.04.2026 05.05.2026	EMD 12000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9992174254 dycsnrhm.bhiwani@gmail.com
12	CIVIL SURGEON,FARIDABAD	SUPPLY OF DRUGS/INJECTION/CONSUMABLES/DENTAL ITEMS/IMPLANTS/ REAGENTS ETC.	13.04.2026 27.04.2026	50 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9990443268 dhs.csfbd@hry.nic.in
13	ZILA PARISHAD, SONIPAT	SUPPLY OF 45 NOS WATER TANKERS, VARIOUS LOCATION UNDER ZP SONIPAT	CLOSING DATE 21.04.2026	89.10 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416391006 prexeeng.snp@gmail.com

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RO 44652-I-27-7

Why India-US trade talks matter more than ever in 2026



In April 2026, India and the United States are trying to turn a fragile trade truce into something more durable. An interim agreement reached in February stopped a sharper break, and fresh talks are set to resume in Washington after weeks of delay.

At the same time, contact between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Donald Trump has helped keep the wider relationship from sliding further. That matters because this dispute is no longer only about customs duties.

It now touches trust, supply chains, energy buying, defence links, and each side's view of the other as a long-term partner.

Several rounds of talks have already taken place, yet the hard choices remain. The immediate crisis has eased, but the real test lies ahead. The interim deal bought time after a period of sharp friction.

In early February, both Governments announced a framework that paired Indian tariff cuts and large US purchases with

a planned reduction in US duties on Indian goods, from 25 percent to 18 percent. That calmed markets and gave exporters some relief. Still, the truce never settled the deepest disputes.

The signing slipped after a US Supreme Court ruling cast doubt on parts of Trump's emergency tariff framework. New investigations by the Trump administration, including subsidy-related action on Indian solar cells, added to the confusion.

By April 10, India had decided to send another delegation to Washington to seek clarity before moving further.

The February framework changed the mood first. It lowered immediate pressure and created a path toward a broader trade pact. India also signaled a willingness to buy more US goods over five years, including energy, aircraft parts, and technology.

That gave Washington a visible gain, while New Delhi secured at least a temporary easing of tariff pain. Yet the framework remained only a bridge.

The implementation slowed because Washington's tariff rules were no longer fully clear after the court ruling. India wanted to know which rates would apply, and when. That question remains open in April. There is also no final

date for signing a full agreement. Piyush Goyal had earlier suggested the pact could be operational by April. That deadline has passed.

So, the interim deal prevented a rupture, but it did not deliver closure. Why uncertainty still hangs over the negotiations. Washington's message has been mixed. On one side, US officials have sounded upbeat.

The White House has said it is still working with India on finalizing a deal, and recent meetings with US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer were described as productive. On the other side, extra duties, new probes, and sector-specific penalties have stayed in play. That gap between tone and action has fed Indian frustration. New Delhi has held back from public anger, but the patience has limits. Goyal's line has been simple, if the United States is satisfied, it should sign.

Until then, optimism will remain thin. Warm statements have kept the relationship afloat, but policy uncertainty has kept the deal unfinished.

Trade tensions now bled into foreign policy. That is why the hardest issues have proved harder than tariff bargaining alone. India wants closer economic ties with

the United States, but it does not want those ties to narrow its choices on energy, regulation, or diplomacy. Russian oil became the biggest test of political trust. US pressure over India's purchases of Russian crude turned trade talks into a test of sovereignty.

Reports around the February framework suggested India would reduce reliance on Russian oil, while buying more US energy. For Washington, that looked like a strategic win. For New Delhi, it raised a sharper question, who decides India's energy mix? India's answer has stayed consistent.

It will engage the United States closely, but energy decisions must serve domestic needs first. That line reflects both economics and politics. India is a major importer, and

price matters.

A sudden shift imposed from outside would carry costs at home. The timing of Vladimir Putin's visit to India added another layer. It reminded Western Capitals that India still values long-standing ties with Russia, even while expanding defense and technology links with the United States. In that sense, oil became more than a commodity. It became a measure of whether Washington can

accept India's independent choices. The most stubborn fights are often hidden behind technical rules. Tariffs make headlines, but licensing systems, product standards, customs procedures, and regulatory barriers can block trade just as effectively.

That is why the April talks are expected to cover non-tariff barriers, Section 232 and 301 issues, and disputes around medical devices. Medical devices are a good example because they sit at the meeting point of public health, pricing, and market access.

Technology goods raise similar tensions. The United States wants fewer restrictions and clearer rules. India wants room to protect domestic firms, manage prices, and avoid opening politically sensitive sectors too fast.

Other issues also sit on the table, including customs rules, services, and intellectual property. These are harder to solve than one tariff cut because they reach into domestic law and State policy.

They ask each side to change how its system works, not simply how much tax it collects at the border. Even after months of strain, neither side can afford to give up on the relationship.

The United States remains India's top export market, and

both Governments still talk about lifting two-way trade sharply by 2030.

For India, that means jobs, factory orders, and investor confidence. For the United States, it means access to a large market and a partner that matters in supply chains, defence production, and Asia strategy. The numbers explain the urgency.

A long tariff fight in 2025 was estimated in Indian policy circles to have shaved 60 to 80 basis points from growth. In plain terms, that means slower output, weaker export momentum, and less confidence among firms planning new investment.

That drag matters because India's export sectors, from apparel and leather to seafood and gems, rely heavily on access to the US market. Even a modest rise in tariffs can reduce margins fast. Meanwhile, prolonged uncertainty makes companies wait before adding capacity or hiring workers. So, the case for a deal is not abstract. It sits in factories, ports, and boardrooms.

On the other hand — India's foreign policy is built on multi-alignment, not bloc politics. It is pursuing talks with the European Union, keeping a limited diplomatic opening with China, and maintaining ties with Russia.

At the same time, it continues to deepen defence and technology cooperation with the United States.

That mix is not a passing tactic. It is the core of India's external strategy. The real test for Washington is whether it can work with India as an independent partner, rather than treat trade access as a tool for broader political obedience.

If it can, the relationship will grow on firmer ground. If it cannot, each round of trade friction will spill into larger mistrust. The interim agreement, and the Modi-Trump channel behind it, have stopped a bad stretch from turning into a deeper rupture.

Yet the strain remains because trade, energy, and geopolitics are now tied together far more tightly than before. That leaves the relationship at an awkward middle point. Bilateral ties are still strong enough to absorb shocks, but not yet stable enough to rise above them.

The next phase will depend less on upbeat language and more on whether both Governments can convert a temporary patch into a durable bargain that respects each side's core interests.

The writer is a veteran journalist and freelance writer based in Brampton Canada

Hungarian PM Orban ousted after 16 years in power

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Budapest

Hungary's election winner Peter Magyar called Monday on the country's president to convene the parliament to form a new government "as quickly as possible," in hopes that he can take over from Viktor Orban as prime minister as early as May 5.

Speaking at a news conference after his Tisza party's victory Sunday, Magyar said they received "a never-before-seen mandate." That super-majority would allow Tisza to embark on ambitious program and reforms.

"The Hungarian people

didn't vote for a simple change of government, but for a complete change in regime," he said.

Magyar thanked Moscow and Beijing for offering their congratulations and willingness to work with Hungary's new government.

"Hungarians said yesterday they will write their history, not in Moscow, not in Beijing, not in Washington," he added.

In his campaign, Magyar pledged to end Hungary's drift toward Russia and restore its ties with European allies. He promised voters that after 16 years of autocratic governance and the



Peter Magyar addressing supporters after claiming victory in a parliamentary election in Budapest, Hungary

erosion of the rule of law under Orban, he will root out corruption and create a "peaceful, functioning and humane" Hungary.

But what those changes will look like remains to be seen. During his long time in office, Orban ruled with the power of a two-thirds parliamentary majority, allowing him to pass a new constitution, rewrite the electoral system and reshape the judiciary. Magyar's Tisza party secured exactly such a mandate Sunday when it won 138 of parliament's 199 seats, giving it broad authority to undo much of the legislation that allowed Orban to

stack the courts, manipulate the electoral system, crack down on press freedom and discriminate against the LGBTQ+ community. Still, there are potential pitfalls that could stand in the way of the radical changes many Hungarians had hoped for.

Historic win

Magyar's victory was met with jubilation on the streets of Budapest late Sunday with tens of thousands, many of them young people, celebrating what they view as a ray of hope that Orban's loss will make Hungary freer, firmly rooted within the fold of European democracies.

PM Carney on the verge of a majority govt in special election

ROB GILLIES ■ Toronto

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney is on the verge of securing a majority government as special elections are held in three districts on Monday.

Votes are being cast in the Toronto-area districts of Scarborough Southwest and University-Rosedale, which are considered safe seats for Carney's Liberals, and in the Montreal-area district of Terrebonne, which is considered a toss-up.

Winning just one of them would give Carney a majority. The Liberals now have 171 members of



Parliament in the House of Commons. They need 172 to secure a majority government, which would allow them to uni-

laterally pass any bill. Once the Liberals get that, they could stay in power until 2029 without the need for a new general election. The results are expected Monday night.

Five defections from opposition parties to Carney, including four from the main opposition Conservative party, have put Carney's Liberals on the cusp of the majority.

One of those defectors referenced Carney's speech at the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland, as helping his decision. In the speech, Carney condemned economic coercion by great powers

against smaller countries and received widespread praise for his remarks. Carney won Canada's election last year fuelled by public anger over US President Donald Trump's annexation threats.

Carney, former head of the Bank of England as well as Canada's central bank, has moved the Liberals to the centre-right since replacing Justin Trudeau as prime minister in 2025.

Daniel Beland, a political science professor at McGill University in Montreal, said the Liberals are almost certain to win the two Toronto seats and have a shot at winning in Terrebonne.

Beland said the deterioration of Canada-US relations under the second Trump presidency has convinced many Canadians, including people who do not identify as Liberal, to rally behind the prime minister.

"Carney has thus far proved that he is an astute politician, despite the fact that he only formally entered the political arena in January of last year," Beland said.

"The Davos speech has certainly helped boost Carney's support at home, and he is now significantly more popular than when he became prime minister nearly 13 months ago." (AP)

Two ships from Pak arrive in Sri Lanka for bilateral exercise

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Two ships from Pakistan have arrived in Colombo to take part in a bilateral naval exercise, the Sri Lankan Navy said on Monday.

Two Pakistani naval ships, Taimur and Aslat, reached the port of Colombo on Sunday and will remain in the island nation until April 26, Commander Buddika Sampath, a spokesman for the Sri Lanka Navy, said.

Sampath said that the training ships from Pakistan are on a "goodwill visit" to the country and will "take part in a bilateral Naval exercise themed Lion Star V with the



Sri Lanka Navy."

He said Sri Lanka would finalise its program depending on what the Pakistani ships would offer for the training exercises.

"This is an excellent opportunity of exposure for our young Naval officers," he said.

Cuba's president warns US against attacking island

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ San Juan

President Miguel Diaz-Canel said the US has no valid reason to carry out a military attack against the island or to attempt to depose him.

Speaking in an interview on NBC News' Meet the Press programme, the president said an invasion of Cuba would be costly and affect regional security. But should it happen, Diaz-Canel said, Cubans would defend themselves. "If the time comes, I don't think there would be any justification for the United States to launch a military aggression against Cuba, or for the

US to undertake a surgical operation or the kidnapping of a president," Diaz-Canel said, speaking through a translator.

He added: "If that happens, there will be fighting, and there will be a struggle, and we will defend ourselves, and if we need to die, we'll die, because as our national anthem says, 'dying for the homeland is to live'." His comments come as tensions between Cuba and the US remain high despite both sides acknowledging talks, although no details have been shared.

Diaz-Canel has accused the US Government of implementing a "hostile



policy" against Cuba and said it has "no moral to demand anything from Cuba."

He noted that Cuba is interested in engaging in dialogue and discussing any topic without conditions, "not demanding changes from our political system as

we are not demanding change from the American system, about which we have a number of doubts."

Cuba blames a US energy blockade for its deepening crisis, with a lack of petroleum affecting the island's health system, public transportation and the production of goods and services.

Cuba produces only 40 per cent of the fuel it consumes, and it stopped receiving key oil shipments from Venezuela after the US military attacked the South American country in early January, seized President Nicolas Maduro and took him to New York to face drug trafficking charges.

Then, with cooperation from ruling party leaders, the Trump administration began implementing a phased plan to end Venezuela's entrenched crisis. The arrival of a Russian tanker carrying 7,30,000 barrels of crude oil in Cuba in March marked the island's first oil shipment in three months. Russia has promised to send a second tanker.

Despite threatening tariffs in January on countries that sell or provide oil to Cuba, the Trump administration allowed the tanker to proceed. "Cuba's finished," President Donald Trump said at the time.

Peru election results delayed after thousands get one-day voting extension



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Lima

Peruvian voters will have to wait until at least Monday to learn the outcome of Sunday's presidential election after the process was mired with logistical issues that even left thousands of people in the country and abroad unable to cast ballots.

The problems prompted electoral authorities to allow more than 52,000 residents of Peru's capital, Lima, to vote on Monday. The extension, announced after vote counting began Sunday evening, also covers Peruvians registered to vote in Orlando, Florida, and Paterson, New Jersey. Authorities initially reported 63,300 people could vote Monday but later revised down the figure.

Voting is mandatory for Peruvians from the ages of 18 to 70. Failure to do so comes with a fine of up to \$32.

Mamdani celebrates 100 days in office, unveils city-run grocery store plan

ANTHONY IZAGUIRRE
■ New York

New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani rallied Sunday to celebrate 100 days in office, touting his early accomplishments and charting future goals as he pledged to lead with a relentless focus on the city's working class.

In front of a crowd just days after reaching an early milestone of his first term, Mamdani said he took office promising "that City Hall would hold a singular purpose, to make this city belong to more of its people

than it did the day before." "For 102 days, we have endeavoured to do exactly that," he said.

After highlighting the early accomplishments of his administration, he then turned to a few new plans.

The first, he said, would be to inch toward one of his major campaign promises: opening a slate of city-run grocery stores. The initial store, he said, would open next year, with the remaining shops — eventually one in each of the city's five boroughs — opening by the end of his four-year term.



Mayor Zohran Mamdani salutes his supporters during an address marking his first 100 days in office at the Knockdown Center in New York

"At our stores, eggs will be cheaper. Bread will be cheaper. Grocery shopping will no longer be an unsolvable equation," said Mamdani, a Democrat.

In addition, the mayor announced plans to expand the city's covered trash bin program — "Say goodbye to black bags and say hello to the bins," he said, vowing to spread the initiative city-wide by the end of 2031.

And he reiterated his campaign promise to make buses faster and free of cost, saying he would move to speed up bus services along some

routes. It remains unclear how he would make good on eliminating bus fares.

"Tonight, we're delivering the fast, and we're excited to keep working with Albany to deliver the free," he said, referencing the governor and the state Legislature, which hold considerable sway over parts of his agenda.

Before Mamdani spoke, the crowd heard from a city transportation department staffer to hear about Mamdani's pothole filling blitz; a tenant organizer who praised the mayor's focus on renters; and a mother who

boosted his push to expand child care programmes in the city. "No longer will city Government be afraid of its own shadow," Mamdani told the crowd shortly after taking the stage. "If anyone should be afraid it is those who take advantage of working people," Mamdani, 34, took office in January after a campaign centred on making New York City a more affordable place to live, centering his agenda on refocusing the vast power of Government toward helping the city's struggling working class. (AP)

PROSPECT

ACA announces ₹25 lakh reward for ground staff after 3 successful IPL matches

The successful hosting of three matches of the Indian Premier League at the ACA Stadium in Guwahati has highlighted the quiet but crucial role played by the ground staff of the Assam Cricket Association.

Working under challenging weather conditions, the curator and groundsmen ensured that the pitches were prepared and maintained to the highest standards.

Their efforts were central to the smooth conduct of the matches and helped uphold the venue's growing reputation on the national stage. In recognition of their contribution, the association has announced a reward of ₹25 lakh for the curator and grounds men.

Association president Taranga Gogoi and honorary secretary Sanatan Das praised the team's professionalism and commitment, stating that their dedication was instrumental in the seamless execution of the matches.

The association also expressed its appreciation for the ground staff, describing them as the backbone of match operations whose work often goes unnoticed but remains vital to the game.



Empowering future warriors with cutting-edge drone technology at Mizoram

In a significant initiative aimed at inspiring and educating the next generation of leaders, the Territorial Army, in collaboration with the Drone Lab under the aegis of 23 Sector Assam Rifles, conducted an engaging lecture-cum-demonstration for young NCC students inunglei on 10 April 26.

The session provided cadets with a unique opportunity to witness and understand the advanced drone technologies employed by security forces in modern operations. The live demonstration showcased the capabilities, applications, and strategic importance of unmanned aerial systems in contemporary warfare and surveillance.

The cadets displayed immense enthusiasm and curiosity, actively engaging with the presenters and gaining valuable insights into emerging defense technologies. The interactive nature of the session fostered a deeper appreciation for innovation in the armed forces.

This initiative marks a proud moment in nurturing young minds and equipping them with knowledge of future warfare domains. Such exposure not only broadens their horizons but also motivates them to contribute meaningfully to the nation's security landscape.



TCS Nashik case: NITES approaches labour ministry

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai/New Delhi

IT sector employees' body NITES on Monday approached the Ministry of Labour and Employment seeking a detailed audit of POSH compliance in Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) and battled for a wider State-level audit across tech and ITES companies, especially large multinational organisations in Maharashtra. The letter to Labour Ministry comes in the backdrop of charges of sexual harassment and allegations on forced religious conversion by eight female employees at TCS' office in Nashik — an incident that has drawn sharp scrutiny and raised serious concerns.

NITES urged the Ministry to take "immediate and decisive action" by directing a comprehensive and time-bound audit and inspection. India's largest IT services company had, on Sunday, said the firm has adopted a zero-tolerance policy towards harassment and coercion of any form for a long time, confirming the suspension of employees allegedly involved in sexual harassment at its Nashik office.

Nascent Information Technology Employees Senate (NITES), in a letter to Labour Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, has pushed for a detailed audit of POSH — Prevention of Sexual Harassment at the workplace — compliance in TCS across all its establishments, including constitution, independence, and functioning of internal committees.

The IT employees' body has also demanded examination of all complaints of sexual harassment received, pending, or disposed of within the organisation (TCS) over the past several years, along with action taken, while



Accused persons remanded to police custody

calling for assessment of the role and accountability of Human Resources personnel and senior management in handling complaints and ensuring a safe workplace.

The Nashik City Police have registered nine FIRs, arrested seven accused officials and formed a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to investigate the claims, which reportedly span several years. It may be noted that the first case was reported in 2022 and then Deputy Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis had ordered a detailed probe. It took four years for the Nashik Police to gain control over this scandal, which had been ongoing unabated in one of the country's most prestigious consultancy companies.

The case has drawn significant attention due to the involvement of TCS, allegations of workplace coercion blending sexual misconduct with religious pressure. Maharashtra's Deputy Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis had then publicly described the incidents as shocking and emphasised that such acts would not be tolerated.

The victim Hindu women had

submitted written complaints to Nashik Police and accused a group of senior employees, primarily team leads of targeting vulnerable junior colleagues, many of them young Hindu women.

It has also been revealed that the Muslim employees of TCS Nashik had created WhatsApp groups and discussed their plans to target vulnerable women. Sources indicated the group allegedly targeted Hindu employees with financial incentives or influence to facilitate conversions.

The victims have alleged that there were repeated inappropriate touching, obscene remarks about physical appearance and personal life, molestation and in some cases, maintaining physical relations under false promises of marriage.

Victims alleged that complaints to higher-ups, including the HR department, were ignored. Police investigation has found that the HR head identified as Nida Khan was complicit and did not pay heed to the repeated complaints. Nashik Police described complaints as involving a group operating within the workplace.

The named accused who have been arrested are; Asif Ansari, Shafi Sheikh, Shah Rukh Qureshi (also referred to as Shahrulkh Qureshi), Raza Memon, Tausif Attar and Danish Sheikh. The arrested persons were produced in court and remanded to police custody initially.

According to the police, on April 10, 2026, the investigating officer recorded the statement of the company's HR manager, who resides in Pune.

Victims had allegedly complained to her earlier, but no action was reportedly taken at the time. She was issued a notice to join the probe further.

Tata Group says allegations at TCS Nashik anguishing, orders probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Tata Sons chairman N Chandrasekaran on Monday termed allegations at TCS Nashik as "gravely concerning and anguishing", and announced an investigation into the matter under a senior executive. "The complaints and allegations emerging from the Nashik branch of TCS have been gravely concerning and anguishing," Chandrasekaran said in a statement.

He also announced that a thorough investigation is underway under TCS' Chief Operating Officer Arathi Subramanian to establish the facts and identify individuals responsible for the situation.

There have been allegations of sexual harassment and forced religious conversion by eight female employees at the multinational company's office in Maharashtra's Nashik.

"This incident is being treated with utmost seriousness. Action has already been initiated against the accused employees, and the company is extending its full cooperation to the ongoing investigations," Chandrasekaran, who was leading TCS as its chief executive and managing director before his appointment as the group chairman, said.

He added that the salts-to-software group maintains a "zero-tolerance policy" towards any form of coercion or misconduct by its employees.



Appropriate and stringent action will be taken against those found guilty in the investigation, he said, adding that process improvements or other corrective measures will be promptly implemented and strictly enforced.

Last week, police formed a special investigation team (SIT) to probe the complaints lodged by eight employees, who claimed that senior colleagues mentally and sexually harassed them, and the human resources department turned a deaf ear to their complaints.

Police have since arrested seven people, including the company's female HR manager. In its first comments, TCS had on Sunday affirmed its commitment on zero tolerance in cases of harassment and informed that staff members have been suspended.

"TCS has a long-standing zero-tolerance policy towards harassment and coercion of any form. We have always ensured the highest standards of safety and well-being of our employees at workplace. As soon as we were made aware of the matter in Nashik, we took swift action," it had said.

Govt imposes import curbs on Glufosinate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government on Monday imposed curbs on imports of Glufosinate and its salts, a herbicide used in agriculture sector, for six months.

"The import of Glufosinate and its salts... shall be restricted where the combined amount of the CIF (cost, insurance, freight) value and



applicable anti-dumping duty, calculated on a per kilogram basis, is less than ₹1,154," the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) said in a notification.

Tulip garden in Srinagar to be closed as bloom season ends

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

The Indira Gandhi Memorial Tulip Garden, a major tourist attraction in Kashmir in the spring season, will be closed to the public as bloom season comes to an end, an official said here on Monday.

The decision to close the garden on Thursday, located on the banks of Dal Lake here, was taken based on the recommendation of a team of experts, the official said. The



garden was thrown open to the public by Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on March 16, a week ahead of schedule due to a

sudden rise in temperature leading to early tulip bloom. The garden was among 44 destinations closed for tourists last year following

the Pahalgam terror attack in April that killed 26 people. It reopened this year after a security audit.

The garden was added to the tourist spots of Kashmir in 2008 by then chief minister Ghulam Nabi Azad to attract tourists to the valley in the lean spring season.

More than 70 varieties of tulips were on display at the garden as the floriculture department increased the density of bulbs to give a richer look to the garden.

DAILY SUDOKU

				9	2			
	9		6			5		
5	2					8		
	8				9	7	6	3
		9				2		
6	7	1	3			4		
		8					7	1
		4			8		5	
			1	3				

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (13.04.26)								
9	6	4	1	7	5	3	8	2
8	1	7	6	3	2	4	9	5
3	2	5	4	9	8	7	1	6
2	5	9	3	4	1	6	7	8
7	8	6	2	5	9	1	3	4
1	4	3	7	8	6	2	5	9
5	7	2	9	6	3	8	4	1
4	9	1	8	2	7	5	6	3
6	3	8	5	1	4	9	2	7

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | APRIL 14, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
		9					
10					11		
				12			
13	14					15	16
17					18		
			19				
20	21					22	23
24				25			
		26					
27					28		
			29				
30							
					31		

ACROSS

- One's own little drug-store (5)
- Granted, it's a wicked deed by Charlie (5)
- Art or craft of the snooker player? (7)
- Strange argot no longer in use (5)
- Didn't exactly rush to escape! (5)
- Footwear a drunkard got out for a sailor (5)
- Pretend to be discerning? (4,3)
- Vehicle needed in one's job, usually (3)
- She lets in the light (4)
- The blockhead gets these sorted, by order! (6)
- Punished, some fine day (5)

DOWN

- Sour, hard-hearted, fearsome fellow (6)
- Replacements for broken spears (6)
- Very good house for the titular head (3)
- Beastly article tots are upset about (5)
- Bent on a career in crime? (7)
- One islet or eight? (4)
- Be sure to wander in the darkness (6)
- Nominal issue, perhaps (5)
- Questionable strength? (5)
- Near St. Pancras, they get cross! (5)
- It's hairy, having to carry a deadhead! (5)
- Such radio you can get to be mates

- Beat down the old woman with the bad leg (6)
- Fair maid's forename (4)
- It's changed, but not significantly (3)
- Realm of Rex and Dominic? (7)
- He has seniority and will perform for money (5)
- No major figure in a centre for divorcees (5)
- Directors sounding bored (5)
- Not one can be found therein! (7)
- Written, perhaps, by a non-U deputy (5)
- Cuddly boy? (5)

with (5)

- Start to live on drink (5)
- Baffled, again, when there's all that water about (7)
- How the RAF man is apt to shoot a line (6)
- Overlook the admixture of gin with mineral (6)
- Tied up, being low on wine (6)
- His minced steak is sheer poetry! (5)
- Many an individual gets cheated! (4)
- In between, it can easily be lost (3)

NBCC-HUDCO alliance marks big leap in asset monetisation push

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In the august presence of Sanjay Kulshrestha, Chairman & Managing Director, HUDCO, and Dr KP Mahadevaswamy, Chairman & Managing Director, NBCC (India) Limited, two Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) were signed on 11 April 2026. The MoUs were executed by Radha Roy, Executive Director, HUDCO; Bhushan Kumar, Executive Director (Business Development), HUDCO; and Pradeep Sharma, Executive Director (Business Development), NBCC. Functional Directors and senior officials from both organisations were also



present on the occasion. The MOU was signed for Redevelopment of leasehold plot at Block No. 25, August Kranti Bhawan, Bhikaji Cama Place, New Delhi and providing funds by HUDCO for ongoing and upcoming projects of NBCC's self-sustainable model on mutually agreed terms and conditions. This will give boost to NBCC's redevelopment pro-

jects on self-sustainable model as funds would be availed on reasonable terms and conditions which will not only expedite the start of projects but also increase the profit margins to the valuable clients. The partnership is expected to expedite project execution, enhance asset value, and contribute to urban infrastructure development.

BALCO deploys India's first humanoid AI for safer smelters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Bharat Aluminium Company Limited (BALCO), India's iconic aluminium producer and a Vedanta Aluminium unit, has deployed ALAISA (Aluminium AI Support Agent) — a first-of-its-kind humanoid, AI-powered assistant — to boost shop-floor capability, operational efficiency, and industrial safety.

Operational at BALCO's Chhattisgarh smelter complex, ALAISA serves as an on-ground training, knowledge, and decision-support interface for shop-floor teams. It integrates conversational AI with plant-specific intelligence to provide real-time guidance on Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs), Standard Maintenance Practices (SMPs), and safety protocols — at the point of operation.

Commenting on the deployment, Rajiv Kumar, CEO of Vedanta Aluminium, said, "Digitalisation is fundamentally reshaping manufacturing. At Vedanta Aluminium,



we are embedding advanced technologies into core operations. ALAISA reflects our commitment to intelligent, future-ready systems that enhance human capability. By combining AI insights with shop-floor expertise, we are

strengthening safety, process reliability, and workforce confidence."

In its initial phase, ALAISA has trained over 100 employees via structured modules, real-time query resolution, and assessment-driven evaluations.

Uday Chauhan, PGT at BALCO, shared his experience: "Before routine work, I underwent safety training on SOPs via ALAISA. It was remarkable. Despite being a robot, it matched human-trainer effectiveness."

E-Tender Notice
GURU NANAK DEV UNIVERSITY, AMRITSAR
SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE

Short Term E-Tenders are invited for the purchase of Tractors, Gas Chromatography Unit (GCMS) System, Paddy/Rice Transplanter, Supercritical CO2 Dyeing Machine, Bench Top Powder X-Ray Diffractometer, Atomic Absorption Spectrophotometer, Ion Chromatography, Refrigerators and Computers be submitted online latest by 28/04/2026 upto 4:00 p.m. Detailed information can be obtained from website www.eproc.punjab.gov.in. Any corrigendum/Addendum related to these e-tender will be uploaded, if required, on Punjab Govt. website: eproc.punjab.gov.in
Director of Research

2426/12/2026-27/10423 Dated CHD :- 13/04/2026

BRIEFLY

Lille maintains Champions League push



JEROME PUGMIREAP ■ Paris

Lille maintained its strong push for an automatic Champions League place with a 4-0 win at Toulouse in Ligue 1.

Lille moved up to third on Sunday and one point ahead of fourth-placed Marseille, with the top three entering the lucrative Champions League directly next season and the side in fourth going through qualifying.

Lyon climbed into fifth place and one point behind Marseille after beating Lorient 2-0 at home to snap a nine-game winless run in all competitions.

Lille was leading 1-0 through right back Thomas Meunier's goal when American defender Mark McKenzie was sent off early in the second half for pulling back forward Matias Fernandez-Pardo as he ran through on goal.

Lille dominated after that red card, with left back Romain Perraud and Fernandez-Pardo scoring before veteran striker Olivier Giroud added a late penalty.

Inter moves closer to Serie A title after Napoli draw



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Rome

Inter Milan came back from two goals down for a 4-3 victory at Como and extended its Serie A lead to nine points with six rounds remaining.

Marcus Thuram and Denzel Dumfries each had braces for Inter, which took advantage of second-place Napoli being held 1-1 at Parma earlier to increase its advantage on Sunday. Alex Valle and Nico Paz scored for Como late in the first half before Thuram started the comeback with a goal in first-half added time. Lucas Da Cunha pulled one back with a penalty for Como in the 89th.

The teams will meet again in the second leg of the Italian Cup semifinals later this month after a 0-0 first leg.

It was another encouraging sign for Inter after a 5-2 victory over Roma last weekend ended a three-match winless streak. Cristian Chivu is attempting to win Serie A during his first season in charge at Inter after replacing the departed Simone Inzaghi. Como dropped from fourth to fifth and just outside the Champions League places.



Muriqi 2 goals behind Mbappe in La Liga scoring charts

TALES AZZONIAP ■ Madrid

Vedat Muriqi moved closer to Kylian Mbappe at the top of La Liga's scoring charts this season with a brace as relegation-threatened Mallorca beat Rayo Vallecano 3-0.

The Kosovo striker scored four minutes apart near the end of the first half on Sunday for his 20th and 21st goals of the season in the league, and within two of Mbappe's 23 goals. The Real Madrid forward was held scoreless in the team's 1-1 draw against Girona on Friday and hasn't scored in the competition since February.

Muriqi has scored three goals in his last two matches with Mallorca. He also scored in the team's 2-1 win over Madrid last weekend.

"I'm very proud," the 31-year-old

Muriqi said. "We've done a very good job and now we're out of the relegation zone."

Jan Virgili was the other scorer Sunday for Mallorca, which has won three of its last four matches to move to 15th place, two points from the drop zone.

Rayo, which has one win in five matches, stayed a point ahead in 13th place. Oviedo not bottom: Oviedo won 3-0 at sixth-placed Celta Vigo to leave last place with its third win in four matches.

Federico Vinas scored twice for the visitors, which hadn't won on the road since September at Valencia.

Alberto Reina also scored for Oviedo, which was promoted this season after a 24-year absence from the top tier. Last-but-one Oviedo is six



Cologne wins Bundesliga relegation duel

CIARAN FAHEYAP ■ Berlin

Cologne eased its Bundesliga relegation worries, Stuttgart took another step toward Champions League qualification and Freiburg defeated Mainz 1-0 away in a duel between European contenders.

Host Cologne enjoyed a 3-1 win over 10-man Werder Bremen that left the visiting team just outside the drop zone on Sunday.

It was the Billy Goats' first win under interim coach Rene Wagner after a 2-2 draw against Eintracht Frankfurt on his debut last weekend. Wagner was handed the reins for the rest of the season after Cologne fired Lukas Kwasniok as coach on March 22.

Bremen's hopes took a major blow in the 24th minute when captain Marco Friedl



was sent off for bringing down Ragnar Ache as the Cologne forward was through on goal.

Cologne moved five points above the relegation zone, while Bremen is just three points clear of danger with five rounds remaining.

The bottom two teams, Wolfsburg and Heidenheim, are now seven and nine points adrift respectively.

Champions League calling for Stuttgart: Stuttgart eased to a 4-0 win at home over

Ayush needed more patience in final: Sagar Chopda

ANKIT SHRESTHA ■ New Delhi

India's impressive run in men's singles at the Badminton Asia Championships fell short in the final, but Sagar Chopda, head coach at the Centre for Badminton Excellence, believes silver-medalist Ayush Shetty has the potential to reach the very top of the sport.

The Indian shuttler went down in straight games against World No.2 Chinese Shi Yu Qi in Ningbo on Sunday.

"I believe Ayush has the potential to be a top-five player in the world. We've always believed he can become a true champion," Chopda told PTI Videos after the 20-year-old ended with a creditable silver at the continental meet.

"We just need to be patient, but he definitely has the potential to reach that level," he added.

Shetty's campaign ended against home favourite Shi, with Chopda pointing to a key area that could have made a difference.

"He probably needed to be a little more patient. At times, he went for outright winners a bit too early and many of those shots either went out or ended up in Shi's hitting zone.

"Shi didn't give him many



opportunities, and at this level you have to make the most of whatever chances you get," he said.

Despite the loss, the unseeded Shetty's run, which included victories over Li Shi Feng, Jonatan Christie and Kunlavut Vitidsarn, marked a significant breakthrough after a string of early exits earlier in the season.

Chopda revealed that a back injury had disrupted Shetty's preparation at the start of the

year, forcing him into rehabilitation instead of building fitness. The turnaround, he said, came down to belief.

"At the start of the season, Ayush had a slight back injury, so he had to focus on rehab for about four to five weeks. That affected his preparation.

"The biggest plus this week was belief. He felt fitter, stronger and didn't check himself. He showed great patience in long rallies, which

is crucial at this level," he said.

The coach, who trains Shetty in Bengaluru, also credited work sessions with a sports psychologist, for the player's improved mental strength during the tournament.

While the results underline his rapid rise, Chopda was quick to point out areas that still need refinement.

"Endurance is still a work in progress. Ayush needs to get

much fitter, although he is improving. He has been doing a lot of off-court sessions with the trainers and physios.

"Being a tall player, his movement has improved especially side-to-side and in defence but there is still room for improvement," Chopda said.

Shetty has also begun working with Indonesian coach Irwansyah Adi Pratama, a move Chopda believes will benefit him in the long run.

"He has been the national coach of the Indonesian side when players like Jonatan Christie and Anthony Sinisuka Ginting were at their peak, so having someone like him on board is going to be helpful for Ayush," Chopda noted.

Given his height and playing style, comparisons with two-time Olympic champion Viktor Axelsen have already begun, something Chopda acknowledged.

"Because he's so tall, he's always been compared to Viktor Axelsen. In fact, he's gone and trained with him a couple of times," Chopda said.

"Viktor has mentioned that he sees similarities and that Ayush reminds him of his younger days."

However, Chopda was quick to add that there is still ground to cover.

Vaishali loses to Zhu, candidates race wide open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Paphos (Cyprus)

Indian Grandmaster R Vaishali went down to China's Jiner Zhu on Sunday, throwing the Candidates tournament wide open with just two rounds remaining in the event that will select the challenger to women's world champion Wenjun Ju.

As luck would have it, Vaishali lost with white pieces when a draw could have put her in the sole lead but her instinct to go for a win in every game got the better of her. Incidentally, this was the second loss in the tournament for the Indian woman and both these defeats came against Jiner Zhu.

With seven points in her kitty from 12 games, Vaishali was joined by Zhu in lead after Anna Muzychuk of Ukraine made a silly mistake to let Aleksandra Goryachkina of Russia off the hook in a well contested game.

Bibisara Assaubayeva of Kazakhstan put an end to the Russian dreams of fighting it out for the women's title with a finely crafted victory over Kateryna Lagno. The Kazakh girl is just half point adrift of the three leaders and the final rest day should come in handy for her and Vaishali to stake their claim.

In the other game of the day, India's Divya Deshmukh lost to Zhongyi Tan of China and both are out of contention for even a podium finish.

In the open section, Uzbek Javokhir Sindarov was yet again dominant



DIVYA DESHMUKH LOST TO CHINA'S ZHONGYI TAN IN THE OTHER GAME OF THE DAY, WITH BOTH PLAYERS NOW OUT OF CONTENTION FOR A PODIUM FINISH

with his white pieces and played out an easy draw with world number two Hikaru Nakamura of the United States.

Taking his tally to a nearly unassailable 9 points from 12 games, Sindarov is now closing in on what would be called the most dominant victory in

the Candidates chess tournament.

Grandmaster R Praggnanadhaa did not have to do much to draw with Andrey Esipenko and it seems that the younger sibling of Vaishali has given up hopes. While a lot remains to be fought for, Praggnanadhaa will have to bounce back and be here in two years' time in order to make an impression.

Results round 12: Andrey Esipenko (Rus, 4.5 drew with R Praggnanandhaa (Ind, 5); Matthias Bluebaum (Ger, 5) drew with Fabiano Caruana (Usa, 6)); Hikaru Nakamura (Usa, 5) drew with Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb, 9) Wei Yi (Chn, 5) playing Anish Giri (Ned, 6.5).

Rory McIlroy wins masters after dramatic final round

DOUG FERGUSONAP ■ Augusta

Rory McIlroy is the Masters champion again, this time without falling to his knees on the 18th green and sobbing over finally achieving his lifelong dream.

That didn't make Sunday at Augusta National any easier.

McIlroy coughed up a six-shot lead in the third round. He fell two shots behind two players, Cameron Young and Justin Rose, in an electric final round. And then he delivered two big birdies around Amen Corner to join more elite company.

A year ago, his playoff victory over Rose made McIlroy only the sixth player with the career Grand Slam. With another green jacket, McIlroy joined Tiger Woods, Nick Faldo

par. He saved par with a tough chip on the 17th. Staked to a two-shot lead, his tee shot on the 18th wound up closer to the 10th fairway.

"I'd say walking off the 18th tee not knowing where my ball was, that was the moment of greatest stress," McIlroy said.

He drilled 8-iron around the trees into a bunker, blasted out to 12 feet and took two putts for bogey and a 1-under 71. He thrust both arms in the air and made good on a promise.

"My parting message last year was I can't wait to come back and put the jacket on myself," McIlroy said at the trophy presentation. "I wasn't quite correct."

For the first time since Woods won back-to-back in 2002, it was left to the Augusta National chair-



and Jack Nicklaus as the only repeat winners of the Masters.

"I thought it was so difficult to win last year because of trying to win the Masters and the Grand Slam, and then this year I realized it's just really difficult to win the Masters," McIlroy said after holding on for a one-shot victory over Scottie Scheffler. "Just incredible."

As usual, he kept everyone on edge until the very end.

His wedge barely cleared the false front of the par-5 15th, a shot that could have been disastrous. His putt from behind the 16th green made a sharp turn down the slope to inches away save

man — Hootie Johnson for Woods, Fred Ridley for McIlroy — to do the honors. "It still fits," McIlroy said.

Better than ever

He now has six majors, tied with Faldo, Lee Trevino and Phil Mickelson. And that sense of freedom he brought back to Augusta National as a champion carried him to the finish line.

McIlroy seized control for good with a bold shot over Rae's Creek to 7 feet for birdie on the par-3 12th. Then he blistered a 350-yard drive on the par-5 13th — he had been in the trees the previous three rounds — that set up another birdie to move three shots ahead.

Man City closes in on Arsenal in Premier League title race with 3-0 win over Chelsea

JAMES ROBSONAP ■ London

Manchester City issued a huge statement of intent in the race for the Premier League title with a 3-0 win at Chelsea.

Pep Guardiola's team moved to within six points of leader Arsenal ahead of next weekend's top of the table clash between the two teams. City also has a game in hand.

Nico O'Reilly, Marc Guehi and Jeremy Doku all scored in a blistering second-half performance at Stamford Bridge on Sunday as City took full advantage of Arsenal's shock defeat to Bournemouth on Saturday.

"We know that we still have everything in our hands," Doku said.

Tottenham's survival fight took another blow after a 1-0 loss to Sunderland left it rooted in the relegation zone.

In coach Roberto De Zerbi's first game in charge, Spurs fell to a 16th league loss of the season. Its 14-



game winless run in the league dates back to Jan. 1.

Nordi Mukiele's deflected shot sealed the game at the Stadium of Light and plunged Tottenham's campaign deeper into crisis.

Tottenham is two points adrift of safety with six games to go. Its plight wasn't helped by relega-

tion-fighting Nottingham Forest drawing 1-1 with Aston Villa.

Crystal Palace came back from 1-0 down to beat Newcastle 2-1 at Selhurst Park.

City's title charge gathers pace: While Arsenal's form has hit a slump at the worst possible time, City made it three statement wins

in a row after rolling over Chelsea.

Victory followed triumph against Arsenal in the English League Cup final and the 4-0 rout of Liverpool in the FA Cup last week.

While those three results all came in different competitions, City's charge has an ominous feel about it after twice chasing down Arsenal's lead to win the title in 2023 and '24.

Second-placed City has the chance to cut the gap at the top to three points with victory against Arsenal at the Etihad. Guardiola called for respect for Arsenal when looking ahead to that title showdown.

"They have been the best team in this country, in Europe, so far. Beating Arsenal once is so difficult, imagine beating them twice in a few weeks," Guardiola said.

"I would like to say to my fans - respect Arsenal a lot, they are an extraordinary team. Come to join us from minute one because the players will do the maximum."

Hinge, Hussain and Kishan shine as SRH crush RR by 57 runs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

Praful Hinge and Sakib Hussain took four wickets each after Ishan Kishan's quickfire 91 as Sunrisers Hyderabad crushed Rajasthan Royals by 57 runs in an Indian Premier League match here on Monday.

Chasing 217, RR slipped to 9 for five inside first three overs and eventually finished at 159 in 19 overs, with Donovan Ferreira (69) and Ravindra Jadeja (45) putting on a 118-run sixth-wicket stand.

Earlier, Kishan played an instrumental role in lifting the SRH side who lost Abhishek Sharma (0) and Travis Head (18) early.

Kishan clobbered eight fours and six sixes to make 91 off only 44 balls as SRH made 216 for six.

SRH were also bolstered by Heinrich Klaassen's 26-ball 40, a quickfire 28 from Nitish Kumar Reddy and Salil Arora's 13-ball 24 not out.

In the previous innings, Skipper Ishan Kishan blazed away to a scintillating 44-ball 91 before a late

charge by Nitish Reddy and Salil Arora lifted Sunrisers Hyderabad to 216 for six against Rajasthan Royals in their Indian Premier League match here on Monday.

SRH skipper Kishan looked in sublime touch during his stay in the middle, hitting eight fours and six sixes while sharing 88 runs with Heinrich Klaassen (40 off 26 balls).

Towards the end, Reddy smashed a 13-ball 28 and Salil Arora remained not out on 24 off 13 balls to prop up SRH.

At the start of SRH innings, Abhishek Sharma looked to go for a big shot on the first ball and danced down the wicket, only to manage a slice off a Jofra Archer (2/37 in 4 overs) delivery for Ravi Bishnoi to complete a neat catch in the deep.

Kishan flicked Archer over short fine leg for a four and then deposited one into the stands over deep mid wicket for a six.

In the next over, Kishan cleared third man for a maximum against Nandre Burger. He then whacked Sandeep Sharma over his head for



a big six and followed that up with a four off Tushar Deshpande through the midwicket region.

Even as Kishan found the boundaries with ease, Travis Head was struggling to get going and his stay came to an end when RR skipper Riyan Parag had him caught in the deep by Donovan Ferreira for a rusty 18-ball 18. It was a bold move by Parag to bring himself in right after the powerplay, and it paid dividends.

Unperturbed by Head's dismissal, Kishan went about his task with absolute clarity and reached his 50 in 30 balls, with a huge six over deep midwicket off leg-spinner Bishnoi.

Thanks to the flurry of boundaries by Kishan, SRH's 100 was up in 10.3 overs with Deshpande leaking 21 runs in that over.

Klaassen lofted Bishnoi over long-on for a six, following it up with a four off Archer.

Kishan then collected three successive boundaries off Archer to move to 91, even as the lights went off briefly inside the stadium.

I don't pre-plan bowling bouncers: Krunal Pandya

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Royal Challengers Bengaluru spin bowling all-rounder Krunal Pandya says he does not pre-plan sending down his bouncers but uses the delivery as per his gut feeling and to be one step ahead of the batters.

Krunal produced a measly spell of 4-0-26-1 as RCB defeated Mumbai Indians by 18 runs in their Indian Premier League clash here on Sunday. In reply to RCB's monumental 240 for four, Mumbai Indians could manage 222 for five.

"I have never shied away from trying different and new things because with the Impact Player rule, previously, you had No. 6 or 7 as all-rounders and batsmanship was quite different. But now there are pure batters (coming in) at No. 8," Krunal told reporters after the match.

"... and plus the skill sets, young boys like Mukul (Choudhary) and Vaibhav



(Sooryavanshi) are hitting from ball one consistently. As a bowler, I want to be one step ahead with the skillset and mental part as well.

"I am glad that it is coming out well and hope that in this format, there are finger spinners who survive and who can take something out of it and do well. Because for (a) finger spinner with having flat tracks and eight batters, it has become very difficult," Krunal added.



CSK hopes to build on momentum

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

Chennai Super Kings would look to build on the momentum gained from a much-needed victory in their previous match when they host a winless Kolkata Knight Riders in the Indian Premier League here on Tuesday.

CSK logged their first win of the season on the back of an all-round performance against Delhi Capitals that included Sanju Samson's first impactful knock, a 56-ball 115, for the storied franchise and a fine bowling effort. A fit-again Dewald Brevis allowed CSK to tweak their bowling combination, making it possible for the side to defend 212 against Delhi Capitals.

Left-arm pacer Gurjapneet Singh impressed on his IPL debut, hitting the batters high on the bat and surprising them with extra bounce.

Jamie Overton too came into his own and was rewarded for hitting the deck consistently with a four-wicket haul.

Left-arm spinner Akeal Hosein, playing his first game of the season, added another dimension to the

attack in the powerplay.

On the batting front, Samson finally has runs under his belt in his debut season for CSK, giving him the required confidence to go ballistic in the first six overs.

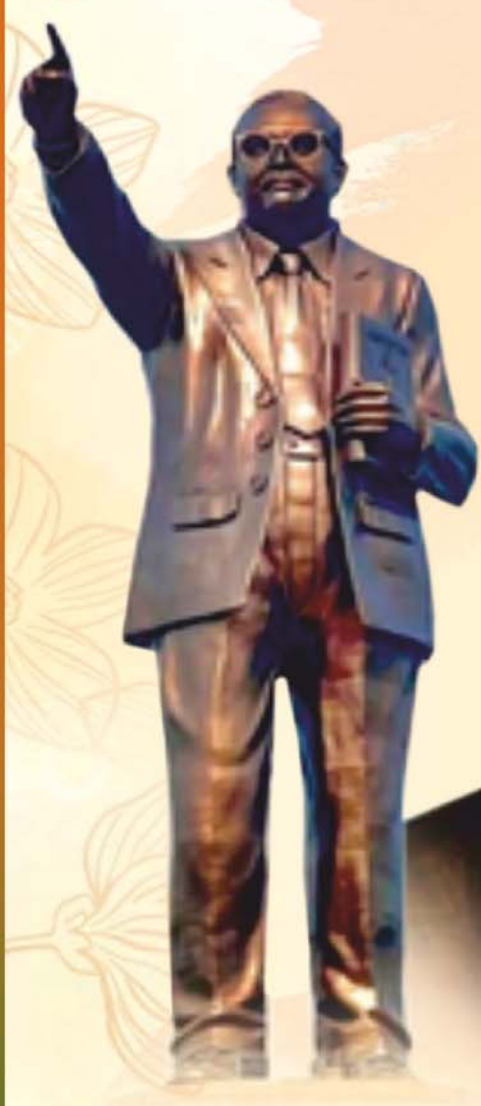
However, CSK captain Ruturaj Gaikwad is yet to fire and he would be backing himself for a big knock against a struggling KKR.

At the start of the tournament, it was announced that Mahendra Singh Dhoni would be out for couple of weeks due to a calf strain. In the last game, Gaikwad indicated that 'Thala's' return is imminent.

KKR, on the other hand, are desperate for success. They almost got the job done against Lucknow Super Giants but Mukul Choudhary played a blinder of a knock to deny Ajinkya Rahane and his team.

Cameron Green finally bowled for KKR in the previous game. The all-rounder would be aiming to justify his enormous price tag with a statement performance at Chepauk.

Likewise, Rinku Singh is in search of runs in the middle-order and Tuesday could be his day.





Government of Haryana

Nation Remembers

The Architect of the Indian Constitution

Babasaheb Dr. Bhimrao Ambedkar ji

on his Birth Anniversary

April 14, 2026



Information, Public Relations & Languages Department, Haryana

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